Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 14 · DAYS 496-564

The Return and the Chronicles Perspective

Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther, Chronicles, Joel, Obadiah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi

A partial return. God keeps his promises but the full restoration awaits.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey."

ZECHARIAH 9:9

Songs of return (85, 107, 126), the closing praise psalms (145 to 150), the reign psalms (96 to 99), and temple psalms (115, 132, 135, 136).

UNIT 14

In this unit

WEEK 71

496	Ezra 1:1-3:13	*Reading*
497	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 72

498	Ezra 4:1-6:22	*Reading*
499	Psalm 126	*Psalm*
500	Psalm 85	*Psalm*
501	Psalm 107:1-22	*Psalm*
502	Ezra 7:1-8:36	*Reading*
503	Ezra 9:1-10:44	*Reading*
504	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 73

505	Nehemiah 1:1-2:20	*Reading*
506	Nehemiah 3:1-4:23	*Reading*
507	Nehemiah 5:1-7:73	*Reading*
508	Psalm 147	*Psalm*
509	Psalm 148	*Psalm*
510	Nehemiah 8:1-10:39	*Reading*
511	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 74

512	Nehemiah 11:1-13:31	*Reading*
513	Esther 1:1-3:15	*Reading*
514	Esther 4:1-7:10	*Reading*
515	Esther 8:1-10:3	*Reading*
516	Psalm 145	*Psalm*
517	Psalm 149; Psalm 150	*Psalm*

518	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 75

519	Psalm 115	*Psalm*
520	Psalm 71	*Psalm*
521	Psalm 144	*Psalm*
522	1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55	*Reading*
523	1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26	*Reading*
524	1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44	*Reading*
525	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 76

526	1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14	*Reading*
527	1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27	*Reading*
528	Psalm 96	*Psalm*
529	Psalm 105:1-15	*Psalm*
530	1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19	*Reading*
531	1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32	*Reading*
532	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 77

533	1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30	*Reading*
534	2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22	*Reading*
535	2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22	*Reading*
536	Psalm 132	*Psalm*
537	Psalm 135	*Psalm*
538	Psalm 136	*Psalm*
539	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 78

540	2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16	*Reading*
541	2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14	*Reading*
542	2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37	*Reading*

543	2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27	*Reading*
544	2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27	*Reading*
545	2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33	*Reading*
546	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 79

547	2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23	*Reading*
548	Joel 1:1-2:32	*Reading*
549	Joel 3:1-21	*Reading*
550	Obadiah 1:1-21	*Reading*
551	Psalm 97	*Psalm*
552	Psalm 98	*Psalm*
553	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 80

554	Psalm 99	*Psalm*
555	Haggai 1:1-2:23	*Reading*
556	Zechariah 1:1-3:10	*Reading*
557	Zechariah 4:1-6:15	*Reading*
558	Zechariah 7:1-8:23	*Reading*
559	Zechariah 9:1-11:17	*Reading*
560	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 81

561	Zechariah 12:1-14:21	*Reading*
562	Malachi 1:1-2:17	*Reading*
563	Malachi 3:1-4:6	*Reading*
564	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 496 · WEEK 71

Ezra 1:1-3:13

The return decreed; the Temple foundation, joy and weeping

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 69 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 1:1-3:13. A pagan king releases the exiles, and a remnant returns to rebuild the temple. The chapter ends with a sound that is half laughter and half weeping. Read the last verses slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the final unit of the Old Testament. It covers about 150 years, from the decree of Cyrus in 538 BC to the close of the prophets around 400 BC. The exile ended just as Jeremiah said, after seventy years. Ezra and Nehemiah tell what happened next. Chronicles retells the whole story for the returned community. The theme of the unit is a partial return: God keeps his promises, but the full restoration is still to come.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of the LORD by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus” (1:1).
2. “Whoever is among you of all his people, may his God be with him, and let him go up to Jerusalem” (1:3).
3. Cyrus returned the temple vessels that Nebuchadnezzar had taken (1:7-11).
4. About 42,360 people returned, along with servants and singers (2:64-65).
5. “Then Jeshua… and his kinsmen… arose and built the altar of the God of Israel” (3:2).
6. “They set up the altar on its foundation, for fear was on them because of the peoples of the lands” (3:3).

7. “And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel” (3:11).

8. “Many of the priests and Levites and heads of fathers” houses, old men who had seen the first house, wept with a loud voice when they saw the foundation of this house’ (3:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezra begins by repeating the last verses of 2 Chronicles. God “stirred up the spirit of Cyrus,” the same Cyrus Isaiah had named by name 150 years earlier. The mightiest king in the world was moved by the LORD to send his people home. God works through pagan kings as easily as through prophets.

Only a remnant goes. Of the hundreds of thousands in exile, about 42,000 make the journey. Most stayed in Babylon, comfortable and settled. The ones who go are those whose spirits God stirred. Return costs something. The list in chapter 2 is full of names, as if to say that God knows each family who made that trip.

Their first act is not building a house for themselves. They build the altar. “For fear was on them because of the peoples of the lands,” yet they begin with worship. Then, in the second year, they lay the temple foundation. The priests blow trumpets, the Levites clash cymbals, and the people sing the refrain you met in Psalm 136: “He is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

Then comes the strange mixture. Many shout for joy. But the old men who remembered Solomon’s temple weep aloud, because this foundation is so small by comparison. “The sound was heard far away.” No one could tell the shouts of joy from the sound of weeping. That is the mark of the whole unit. The return is real, and it is smaller than the promise. The people have come home, but they are still under Persia, and the glory has not yet returned. Joy and sorrow sit side by side, and both are right.

STEP 5

Connection

Haggai 2:3 asks, “Who is left among you who saw this house in its former glory?” Jesus began with small things: a mustard seed (Matthew 13:31-32). Zechariah 4:10 says, “Who has despised the day of small things?” Romans 8:23 says that we groan inwardly as we wait for redemption, though we have the first fruits of the Spirit. Philippians 1:6 promises that God who began a good work will bring it to completion.

STEP 6

Application

Where has God given you a beginning that seems small compared to what you hoped? Thank him for it anyway.

Build your altar first: begin your day or your project with worship.

Be honest that joy and sorrow can coexist. You do not have to choose only one.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to stir your spirit to go where he calls.
- Thank him for bringing a remnant home.
- Tell him what you want to rebuild.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."

EZRA 3:11

DAY 497 · WEEK 71

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezra 3:11 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."

EZRA 3:11

REST

Meditation

This sentence was sung by a small group of people standing in front of a foundation. They had come back to a ruined city. The walls were down. The temple was a pile of stones. And they sang.

"They sang responsively." One group sang a line, and another answered. Worship together has a shape: we speak to each other and to God. No one is alone. In a time of rebuilding, they needed each other's voices.

"Praising and giving thanks to the LORD." The foundation was only a foundation. But they praised God for what he had done, not for what was finished. Gratitude does not wait until the work is complete.

“For he is good.” This is the reason for praise: God himself, not their circumstances. The circumstances were mixed. The old men were weeping. Persia was still in charge. Enemies were waiting. But God was good.

“For his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.” The word “endures” reminds us that the exile did not end it. Seventy years of captivity could not cancel God’s covenant love. It is the same refrain as Psalm 136 and the same truth as Lamentations 3. Their song was an act of faith: the God who sent them away has brought them back.

Say this verse whenever you stand at the foundation of something that is not yet finished. You do not have to wait for the walls to go up. Sing now.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Old Testament’s exile story and began its last chapter. You finished Daniel with the writing on the wall, the lions’ den, the vision of the Son of Man, and the promise of resurrection. Then, on the first day of Unit 14, you read the decree of Cyrus and followed the first returning exiles home. You saw them build the altar before the temple, and lay the foundation to the sound of trumpets, cymbals, and a song of thanks. And you heard the sound that mixes shouting with weeping. The week taught that God keeps his promises and moves the hearts of kings, that he brings his people home, and that the return, though real, is still only a beginning.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The returning exiles built the altar before they built anything else. What would it look like to put worship first in your day, your work, or your home?

The old men wept when they saw the small foundation. Is there something in your life that is smaller than you hoped, and how might God want you to receive it?

God stirred up the spirit of Cyrus, a pagan king, to fulfill his word. Where have you seen God work through someone who did not know him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for his steadfast love.

Thank him for bringing his people home.

Rest in him.

DAY 498 · WEEK 72

Ezra 4:1-6:22

Opposition; the Temple completed; Passover kept

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 4:1-6:22. Enemies stop the work for about fifteen years, and God uses two prophets to restart it. The temple is finished, and the people keep the Passover. Read for the way opposition is met.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The neighbors of the returning Jews, resettled peoples of the former northern kingdom, offered to help build the temple. When Zerubbabel and Jeshua refused, they became enemies. They discouraged the builders, bribed officials, and finally wrote letters to the Persian court. The work stopped from about 536 to 520 BC. Haggai and Zechariah, whom you will read near the end of this unit, then preached, and the work resumed. The temple was finished in 516 BC, seventy years after its destruction.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You have nothing to do with us in building a house to our God” (4:3).
2. “Then the people of the land discouraged the people of Judah and made them afraid to build” (4:4).
3. “Then the work on the house of God in Jerusalem stopped” (4:24).
4. “Then the prophets, Haggai and Zechariah the son of Iddo, prophesied to the Jews” (5:1).
5. “But the eye of their God was on the elders of the Jews, and they were not stopped” (5:5).
6. “We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth, and we are rebuilding the house that was built many years ago” (5:11).

7. “And the elders of the Jews built and prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet” (6:14).

8. “And they kept the Feast of Unleavened Bread seven days with joy, for the LORD had made them joyful” (6:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The conflict begins with an offer that sounds friendly. The local peoples say, “Let us build with you, for we worship your God.” Zerubbabel refuses. It was not unkind but wise. These people had mixed the worship of the LORD with other gods (2 Kings 17:33). To build together would have meant a compromised temple. The refusal cost them, because opposition followed: discouragement, fear, bribes, and accusations. Tactics of those who oppose God’s work have not changed.

The work stops. For sixteen years, the foundation sits unfinished. The people turn to their own homes. This is a lesson in how a good beginning can stall when we are tired, afraid, or distracted.

But God sends help. Haggai and Zechariah prophesy, and the leaders rise and start building again. When the governor Tattenai asks who authorized them, the Jews answer with confidence and with their history: “We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth.” A letter is sent to Darius, and he discovers the original decree of Cyrus in the archives. He not only allows the work but orders the provinces to pay for it. The enemies who tried to stop it are made to fund it.

The note in 5:5 is the heart of it: “The eye of their God was on the elders of the Jews, and they were not stopped.” God is watching. The temple is finished in the sixth year of Darius, and the dedication is full of joy. They keep the Passover, as in Hezekiah’s and Josiah’s days. And the writer adds: “The LORD had made them joyful, and had turned the heart of the king of Assyria toward them.” Even the opposition was in God’s hand.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18). Nehemiah and Paul faced similar opposition (Acts 19, 2 Corinthians 11). 1 Peter 2:5 says we are being built up as a spiritual house. Galatians 6:9 says, “Let us not grow weary of doing good.” Philippians 4:6: do not be anxious. Romans 8:31: if God is for us, who can be against us?

STEP 6

Application

Think about a project God gave you that has stalled. Ask what is needed to start again.

Pray for those who face opposition in their ministry or work.

Be discerning about offers of “help” that would compromise your devotion to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you building when you are afraid or tired.

Thank him that his eye is on those who serve him.

Ask him to raise up encouragers around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

“For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel.”

EZRA 7:10

DAY 499 · WEEK 72

Psalm 126

When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 126. You read this psalm in Unit 13 as a hope for the exiles. Now that the first exiles are home, read it again as their own song, sung with the foundation of the temple in front of them.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 126 is a Song of Ascents. Earlier, you read it as a dream of return. Today read it as a song of those who have returned. The joy of verses 1 to 3 is the joy of the day the decree was announced. The prayer of verses 4 to 6 fits the days of delay, opposition, and small beginnings that you have just read in Ezra. It holds both: thanks for what God has done, and a plea for more.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion, we were like those who dream” (v. 1).
2. “Then our mouth was filled with laughter, and our tongue with shouts of joy” (v. 2).
3. “Then they said among the nations, The LORD has done great things for them” (v. 2).
4. “The LORD has done great things for us; we are glad” (v. 3).
5. “Restore our fortunes, O LORD, like streams in the Negeb!” (v. 4).
6. “Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy!” (v. 5).
7. “He who goes out weeping, bearing the seed for sowing” (v. 6).
8. “Shall come home with shouts of joy, bringing his sheaves with him” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a song of already and not yet. In the first half, the people remember the day God restored them. It was so wonderful that it felt like a dream. Laughter, shouts of joy, and even the nations noticing. Ezra 1 and 3 are a commentary on this: a pagan king's decree, the singing at the foundation. They were glad.

But in the second half, there is a request. "Restore our fortunes, O LORD." The returned exiles are back, and yet they still pray for restoration. The land was poor, the walls were broken, the Persians ruled, and the opposition was strong. The first restoration was real, and the work was incomplete. They prayed for more, like the desert streams of the Negeb that burst into life after rain.

Then comes the image of sowing. The farmer goes out weeping because seed is precious, and in a time of famine, it hurts to put it in the ground. He sows in tears, trusting that it will grow. And God promises that he will come back with shouts of joy and with sheaves. The pattern is that tears and joy are connected. Tears are not wasted. They are part of the sowing.

This is what the returned community needed to hear while building the temple under threat. And it is what believers need while waiting for a final restoration. We have tasted the first fruits, and we wait for the harvest. We sow in tears because we live in a world that is not yet made new, and we do it in hope.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Blessed are you who weep now, for you shall laugh" (Luke 6:21). John 16:20: "You will be sorrowful, but your sorrow will turn into joy." Galatians 6:9: "In due season we will reap, if we do not give up." 1 Corinthians 15:58: "Your labor is not in vain in the Lord." Romans 8:23-25 describes waiting for the redemption of our bodies. Revelation 21:4 promises no more tears.

STEP 6

Application

Name something you are currently "sowing in tears." Offer it to God, and trust the harvest.

Thank God for a restoration he has already given you, and ask for more.

Encourage someone who is weeping as they work or serve.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the great things he has done for you.
- Ask him to restore what is dry in you.
- Tell him about tears you are sowing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 500 · WEEK 72

Psalm 85

LORD, you were favorable, will you not revive us again?

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 85. You read this psalm in Unit 13 as a prayer for revival in exile. Read it now as the prayer of people who are back in the land and find that the glory is not what they hoped. Notice again verses 10 to 13.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 85 begins by recalling that God has been favorable to his land and restored the fortunes of Jacob. For the returned exiles, this meant the decree of Cyrus. But the psalm goes on to ask, "Will you not revive us again?" It fits the period of Ezra and Haggai, when the people had returned and still lacked the full blessing. On Day 430 you read it as a lament from the dark side of exile. Today read it as a post-return prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "LORD, you were favorable to your land; you restored the fortunes of Jacob" (v. 1).
2. "You forgave the iniquity of your people; you covered all their sin" (v. 2).
3. "Restore us again, O God of our salvation, and put away your indignation toward us!" (v. 4).
4. "Will you be angry with us forever? Will you prolong your anger to all generations?" (v. 5).
5. "Will you not revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?" (v. 6).
6. "Let me hear what God the LORD will speak, for he will speak peace to his people" (v. 8).
7. "Steadfast love and faithfulness meet; righteousness and peace kiss each other" (v. 10).
8. "Righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way" (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The post-return period was a time of mixed feelings. The people had been brought home, but life was hard. Crops failed, the economy was poor, the temple lagged, and neighbors were hostile. Haggai said that they earned wages and put them in a bag with holes. It would have been easy to think that God was still angry.

The psalm answers by returning to history: God has already forgiven. “You covered all their sin.” It is a statement of faith that does not depend on present feelings. The past forgiveness is the ground for the present request. “Restore us again.” We are allowed to ask God to do again what he has already done.

The psalmist then does something wise. He stops talking and listens: “Let me hear what God the LORD will speak.” The word is peace, but with a condition: “Let them not turn back to folly.” Peace is for those who fear him, and God’s salvation is near to them. The glory will dwell in the land.

The great picture follows. Steadfast love and faithfulness meet. Righteousness and peace kiss. Faithfulness springs from the ground and righteousness looks down from heaven. The Lord will give what is good. This is a vision of heaven and earth cooperating. For Ezra’s generation, it was a hope: someday the land would be so blessed. For us it points to Christ, in whom heaven and earth meet.

The last line is a promise of a path: righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way. God is coming. His footsteps prepare the road.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:78-79 says, “The sunrise shall visit us from on high to give light to those who sit in darkness… to guide our feet into the way of peace.” John 1:14 says the Word became flesh, full of grace and truth. Colossians 1:20 says God made peace by the blood of his cross. Romans 5:1: “Since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God.” Ephesians 2:14: “He himself is our peace.” Isaiah 40:3 speaks of preparing the way of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Pray “Will you not revive us again?” for your church or community.

Be still and ask what God is speaking. Listen for five minutes.

Thank God that in Christ, steadfast love and faithfulness have met, and righteousness and peace have kissed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to revive you.
- Ask him to speak peace to you and keep you from turning back to folly.
- Thank him that righteousness and peace will kiss.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 501 · WEEK 72

Psalm 107:1-22

Give thanks to the LORD; he gathered the exiles

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:1-22. You read this passage on Day 442 as a song of rescue for those in every kind of trouble. Read it now as the psalm of the ones who have actually come home. Let the opening lines be the first words they said.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 107 opens the last book of the Psalter with the words, “Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, whom he has redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands.” That is the exact situation of Ezra’s generation. They were gathered from the east, the north, the south, and the west. On Day 442 you read this as the cry of those still waiting. Today, read it as the thanks of those who have returned and are rebuilding.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!” (v. 1).
2. “Let the redeemed of the LORD say so” (v. 2).
3. “Gathered in from the lands, from the east and from the west, from the north and from the south” (v. 3).
4. “He led them by a straight way till they reached a city to dwell in” (v. 7).
5. “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of men!” (v. 8).
6. “For he satisfies the longing soul, and the hungry soul he fills with good things” (v. 9).

7. “He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and burst their bonds apart” (v. 14).

8. “And let them offer sacrifices of thanksgiving, and tell of his deeds in songs of joy!” (v. 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is the testimony of the redeemed. The psalm does not tell them to wait until the story is complete. It tells them to say so. A redeemed person has something to say, and the first thing is thanks.

The first story is of wanderers in the desert, hungry and thirsty, who found no city to live in. Think of the caravan from Babylon, traveling over 800 miles to a city that lay in ruins. God “led them by a straight way till they reached a city to dwell in.” Their journey was real, and so was God’s guidance.

The second story is of prisoners in darkness. This is what the exile was. They were captives for rebelling against the words of God. And yet, when they cried out, “he burst their bonds apart.” The third is the sick, who were “fools through their sinful ways.” God’s word healed them.

What is the common thread? Each group was in trouble, each cried out, and each was rescued. Each time the response is the same: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works.” The psalm names what the right response is, thanks and sacrifice and songs of joy.

In the setting of the return, thanksgiving was also practical. The altar had been built, and sacrifices of thanksgiving were being offered. Telling of God’s deeds was part of the rebuilding. Remembering and recounting is what keeps the people alive. In the unit’s larger story, Chronicles will do the same on a larger scale, telling the whole history so that the community remembers who they are.

STEP 5

Connection

Colossians 1:13-14 says God “has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son.” Luke 4:18-19: the Spirit anoints him to proclaim liberty to the captives. Ephesians 2:13 says that those who were far off have been brought near. Hebrews 13:15 invites us to offer a sacrifice of praise. 1 Peter 2:9: “that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.”

STEP 6

Application

Say it out loud: tell one person today what God has redeemed you from.

Write a short thank-you list in the pattern of the psalm: from what you were rescued, how you cried out, and how God answered.

Offer a “sacrifice of thanksgiving” this week, through a gift, a word of praise, or a service.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for gathering you from a far place.

Let your own story say, “The LORD is good,” in your own words.

Thank him that his steadfast love endures forever.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

“For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel.”

EZRA 7:10

DAY 502 · WEEK 72

Ezra 7:1-8:36

Ezra arrives; the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 7:1-8:36. Fifty-eight years after the temple is finished, Ezra the scribe arrives in Jerusalem. Notice what the text says about his heart in 7:10, and how he organizes the journey in chapter 8.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezra comes to Jerusalem in 458 BC, in the seventh year of Artaxerxes. He is a priest descended from Aaron and a scribe skilled in the Law of Moses. The temple was built, but the community was spiritually weak, and many were not following the law. The king gave Ezra authority to teach and enforce it. He leads a second group of returning exiles, about 1,800 people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “This Ezra went up from Babylonia. He was a scribe skilled in the Law of Moses” (7:6).
2. “And the king granted him all that he asked, for the hand of the LORD his God was on him” (7:6).
3. “For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel” (7:10).
4. “Blessed be the LORD, the God of our fathers, who put such a thing as this into the heart of the king” (7:27).
5. “I was ashamed to ask the king for a band of soldiers and horsemen to protect us against the enemy on the way” (8:22).

6. “The hand of our God is for good on all who seek him, and the power of his wrath is against all who forsake him” (8:22).
7. “So we fasted and implored our God for this, and he listened to our entreaty” (8:23).
8. “The hand of our God was on us, and he delivered us from the hand of the enemy and from ambushes by the way” (8:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Verse 10 of chapter 7 is among the best descriptions of a teacher of God’s word in the Bible. Ezra “set his heart” to do three things in order: to study the Law of the LORD, to do it, and to teach it. First he studied. Second he practiced. Only then did he teach. The order matters. A teacher who has not studied is shallow. A teacher who has not obeyed is a hypocrite. And study and obedience exist for the sake of sharing.

The phrase “the hand of the LORD his God was on him” appears again and again. Ezra does not take credit. The king’s favor, the safe journey, the gifts and authority all come from God’s hand. The letter from Artaxerxes is remarkable: it commands the treasurers to give whatever Ezra requests for the house of the God of heaven, “lest his wrath be against the realm of the king.” Again, the heart of a Persian king is in God’s hand.

Chapter 8 gives the list of the families and the preparation for the journey. Ezra gathers the people at the river Ahava and discovers that no Levites have come. He sends for them, and they come. Then he does something striking. He is ashamed to ask the king for an armed escort, since he had told the king that “the hand of our God is for good on all who seek him.” Having said it, he proves it. The group fasts and prays for a safe journey. “And he listened to our entreaty.” The caravan carries a fortune in silver, gold, and vessels, and they are not robbed.

The principle is that faith is shown in dependence. Ezra could have asked for soldiers. He chose prayer. He took a risk, the kind that invites God to show who he is.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 2:15 says, “Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth.” James 1:22 says to be doers of the word. Ezekiel 3:1-3 shows the prophet eating the scroll. Ezra’s study, practice, and teaching match Jesus’ pattern (Acts 1:1). Psalm 20:7: “Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.”

STEP 6

Application

Follow Ezra's order: study something in Scripture this week, apply it, and then share it with someone.

Think about when you reached for "soldiers and horsemen" instead of prayer. What would it look like to depend on God in that area?

Give thanks for those who teach God's word faithfully.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a heart set to study his law, do it, and teach it.
- Ask him to let his hand be on you for good.
- Tell him where you are trusting him over human protection.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 503 · WEEK 72

Ezra 9:1-10:44

Mixed marriages; covenant faithfulness restored

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 9:1-10:44. Ezra discovers that many in Israel have married women from the surrounding peoples, who worship other gods. He responds with grief and prayer, and the people respond with repentance. This is a hard passage. Read it carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Soon after Ezra arrives, the leaders report that the people, including priests and Levites, have taken wives from the peoples of the land, adopting their abominations. The concern is not ethnic. The law forbade intermarriage with the Canaanite nations because it would draw Israel into idolatry (Deuteronomy 7:1-4). The same law welcomed foreigners like Rahab and Ruth who came to worship the LORD. The issue here is covenant faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As soon as I heard this, I tore my garment and my cloak and pulled hair from my head and beard and sat appalled" (9:3).
2. "O my God, I am ashamed and blush to lift my face to you, my God, for our iniquities have risen higher than our heads" (9:6).
3. "And now, for a brief moment, grace has been shown by the LORD our God, who has left us a remnant" (9:8).
4. "Our God has not forsaken us in our slavery, but has extended to us his steadfast love in the sight of the kings of Persia" (9:9).
5. "O LORD, God of Israel, you are righteous, for we are left a remnant that has escaped, as it is this day" (9:15).

6. “While Ezra prayed and made confession, weeping and casting himself down before the house of God, a very great assembly of men, women, and children gathered” (10:1).
7. “Shecaniah… said to Ezra, We have broken faith with our God… But even now there is hope for Israel in spite of this” (10:2).
8. “Arise, for it is your task, and we are with you; be strong and do it” (10:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezra’s response is not anger at others. He tears his garment, pulls his hair, and sits appalled until the evening sacrifice. Then he prays on his knees. His prayer is a model. He says “we,” not “they.” He had not married foreign wives himself, but he identifies with the people. He is ashamed. “Our iniquities have risen higher than our heads.” He recalls the history of exile as the result of such sins. And he admits that they have done it again, after all God’s mercy.

The key note is grace. “For a brief moment, grace has been shown by the LORD our God.” Even in the middle of the confession, he acknowledges that being back in the land is itself a gift, “a little reviving in our slavery.” He does not ask for anything. He simply puts himself and the people before the righteous God: “We cannot stand before you because of this.”

The prayer moves the people. A great crowd gathers, weeping. Shecaniah speaks: “We have broken faith with our God… But even now there is hope for Israel in spite of this.” This is the grace of repentance. They propose a covenant to put away the foreign wives and children. It is a painful and controversial decision, and the chapter ends with a long list of names of those who did so. The text does not hide that this was costly and difficult.

We should read this with care. Some readers see in it a harsh ethnic rule. But the text emphasizes the matter of faith: the wives came from idolatrous peoples, and the people of God were in danger of losing their identity as the people who worship the LORD alone. For Christians, the principle is found in 2 Corinthians 6:14-18 and 1 Corinthians 7:12-16, where those already married to unbelievers are told to remain. The heart of the passage is not the specific remedy but the seriousness of repentance and the priority of covenant faithfulness to God.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 9:4-19 shows the same kind of identifying prayer. 1 John 1:9: “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us.” 2 Corinthians 7:10 says godly grief produces repentance that leads to salvation. Ruth, a Moabite, became part of the family of the Messiah by faith (Ruth 4:13-22; Matthew 1:5). Galatians 3:28 says that in Christ there is neither Jew nor Greek. Revelation 7:9 pictures every nation, tribe, people, and language worshiping together.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Ezra's kind of prayer with "we" for your church or community. Confess sins that you share in, even when you were not directly involved.

Ask where your closest alliances and loyalties might draw you away from the LORD.

Receive Shecaniah's words as encouragement: "Even now there is hope."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess in your own words where you are ashamed before God.
- Thank him for being righteous and merciful.
- Ask him to help you turn from what you must leave.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 504 · WEEK 72

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezra 7:10 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

REST

Meditation

This verse is a summary of a whole life. Ezra's greatness was not in a position but in a heart, and the verse tells us exactly what was in it.

"Ezra had set his heart." To set the heart is a decision, a firm resolve. It did not happen by accident or by drift. It was a choice made on purpose and kept over time. The Hebrew word means to fix or establish. His heart was anchored.

"To study the Law of the LORD." The first thing is study. The word means to seek, to inquire, to dig. Ezra approached Scripture as someone who wanted to know it deeply. He was a scribe, skilled in the Law, but skill was not enough. He studied because he loved it.

"And to do it." The second thing is practice. Knowledge without obedience is empty. Ezra aimed to live what he studied. James 1:22 would later say the same: be doers of the word and not hearers only.

“And to teach his statutes and rules in Israel.” The third thing is teaching. Having studied and obeyed, he shared. His goal was the good of the whole people.

The order here is the pattern for anyone who handles the word of God. You cannot teach what you do not do, and you cannot do what you do not know. If you are a parent, a teacher, a leader in the church, or simply a friend, this verse describes the path. Say it as a prayer: set my heart to study, to do, and to teach.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the returned exiles through their first sixty years in the land. You read of the foundation of the temple, the opposition that stopped the work, and the prophets who started it again. You saw the temple finished and the Passover kept with joy. You prayed three psalms of return: Psalm 126, the dream of coming home and the hope of sowing in tears; Psalm 85, the prayer for revival; and Psalm 107, the thanks of those redeemed and gathered from the lands. Then you met Ezra, the scribe who set his heart to study, practice, and teach the law of the LORD. You followed him as he prayed for a safe journey, and as he wept over the sin of the people. The week taught that God keeps his word through the hearts of kings, that opposition cannot stop his work, and that repentance and the word of God are the basis of renewal.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Ezra studied, practiced, and then taught. Which of the three is hardest for you right now, and what is one step you could take?

When the work stopped, God sent prophets to encourage the builders. Who has encouraged you in a stalled season, and who might you encourage?

Ezra prayed with “we” and not “they.” What would it look like to confess sin on behalf of your church or community?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to set your heart to study his law and to do it.

Thank him for teachers who have taught you.

Rest in him today.

DAY 505 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 1:1-2:20

Nehemiah's prayer; commissioned to rebuild the wall

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 1:1-2:20. Nehemiah, a cupbearer to the Persian king, hears that Jerusalem's walls are still broken. Notice that he prays before he speaks, and speaks only after he has prayed for months.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is 445 BC, about thirteen years after Ezra. The temple stands, but Jerusalem has no walls, which leaves it defenseless and shameful. Nehemiah serves in the palace at Susa as cupbearer to Artaxerxes, a trusted position close to the king. A visitor from Judah brings him news of the city's "great trouble and shame." Nehemiah's own memoir fills this book, and it is full of prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When I heard these words I sat down and wept and mourned for days, and I continued fasting and praying before the God of heaven" (1:4).
2. "Let your ear be attentive and your eyes open, to hear the prayer of your servant" (1:6).
3. "Both I and my father's house have sinned" (1:6).
4. "Remember the word that you commanded your servant Moses" (1:8).
5. "Then the king said to me, What are you requesting? So I prayed to the God of heaven" (2:4).
6. "And the king granted me what I asked, for the good hand of my God was upon me" (2:8).
7. "Let us rise up and build. So they strengthened their hands for the good work" (2:18).

8 “The God of heaven will make us prosper, and we his servants will arise and build” (2:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Nehemiah’s first response to bad news is tears and prayer. He does not rush to a plan. For about four months, from Chislev to Nisan, he fasts and prays. His prayer follows the pattern of Daniel 9 and Ezra 9: he praises God for his covenant love, confesses sins including his own and his father’s house, remembers the promise of Moses to gather the scattered, and asks for success before the king.

Then comes the moment. The king notices that his cupbearer is sad, which is dangerous, since sadness in the royal presence could cost a man his life. “Then I was very much afraid.” The king asks what he wants. Nehemiah does something wonderful: “So I prayed to the God of heaven.” In the span of a breath, between the king’s question and his own answer, he sends up a prayer. Then he answers boldly and specifically. He asks for time, letters of safe passage, and timber. All of it is given, “for the good hand of my God was upon me.”

Nehemiah arrives in Jerusalem and quietly inspects the walls at night. Only then does he tell the leaders about the vision God gave him. His appeal ties the work to what God has already done: “I told them how the hand of my God had been upon me for good.” They answer, “Let us rise up and build.”

Opposition appears at once, in the form of Sanballat, Tobiah, and Geshem, who mock and accuse. Nehemiah’s reply is calm: “The God of heaven will make us prosper.” He does not argue or defend himself. He states whose work it is.

The pattern is prayer, planning, and perseverance. Prayer came first and was sustained. Planning followed, with specific requests and a night survey. Then came bold action.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his disciples to pray and not lose heart (Luke 18:1). Philippians 4:6 says, “In everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God.” James 1:5 promises wisdom to those who ask. Proverbs 21:1 says the king’s heart is a stream of water in the hand of the LORD. Colossians 4:2-3 asks us to continue steadfastly in prayer. Luke 14:28 teaches counting the cost before building.

STEP 6

Application

Practice the “arrow prayer” today: breathe a quick prayer before a hard conversation or decision.

Name a broken wall in your family, church, or community that burdens you. Pray about it for a week before you act.

Confess sins you share in, as Nehemiah did, and then ask God for his good hand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray as Nehemiah did: praise God, confess your sin and your people’s, and name what burdens you.

Ask him to let his ear be attentive.

Tell him what you are asking him for.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 506 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 3:1-4:23

The wall rebuilt; opposition from without

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 3:1-4:23. A long list of names builds the wall, and then opposition turns to ridicule and threat. Notice how Nehemiah answers both.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 3 is a work roster. Priests, goldsmiths, perfumers, rulers, daughters, and merchants each repair a section, often opposite their own homes. Chapter 4 shows the enemy's reaction: mockery, a plot to attack, and discouragement from within Judah itself. The wall is half built when the strain begins to tell.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Next to him Zadok the son of Baana repaired. Next to him the Tekoites repaired" (3:4-5).
2. "but their nobles would not stoop to serve their Lords" (3:5).
3. "Next to him Shallum... repaired, he and his daughters" (3:12).
4. "What are these feeble Jews doing?" (4:2).
5. "Hear, O our God, for we are despised" (4:4).
6. "So we built the wall... for the people had a mind to work" (4:6).
7. "And we prayed to our God and set a guard as a protection against them day and night" (4:9).
8. "Do not be afraid of them. Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome, and fight for your brothers" (4:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 3 may look like dull reading, but it carries a point. Everyone had a place. The high priest rebuilt a gate. Goldsmiths and perfumers, who knew nothing of masonry, took up stone. A man named Shallum "and his daughters" worked together. People repaired the part nearest their own houses, so that the protection of the wall mattered to them personally. The wall was a community project.

There is also a note of sadness: "the nobles of the Tekoites would not stoop to serve their Lord." God records the names of those who work and he also notes who did not. Yet the Tekoites, ordinary families, repaired two sections.

Chapter 4 shows the opposition growing. First comes ridicule: "Even what they are building, if a fox goes up on it he will break down their stone wall!" Nehemiah's response is to pray and keep building. He does not retaliate. He simply asks God to hear. "So we built the wall… for the people had a mind to work."

Then comes the threat. The enemy plans to attack, and Judah itself is discouraged: "The strength of those who carry the burdens is failing, and there is much rubbish." Their weariness is honest. Nehemiah answers with a double strategy: "We prayed to our God and set a guard." Faith and wisdom work together. He then arms families by sections and speaks the words that settle them: "Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome." Fear shrinks when God is seen as big.

The chapter ends with workers holding a trowel in one hand and a weapon in the other, sleeping in their clothes. "Our God will fight for us." It was hard, and it was done together.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Corinthians 12:12-27 describes the church as one body with many members, each needed. Ephesians 4:16 says the whole body is "joined and held together by every joint." Ephesians 6:10-18 speaks of the armor of God. Matthew 26:41 says to watch and pray. 2 Corinthians 10:4 says the weapons of our warfare are not worldly. Exodus 14:14: "The LORD will fight for you."

STEP 6

Application

Find your "section of the wall." What is nearest to your own house that you can repair or serve?

When criticized, try Nehemiah's response: pray briefly, and keep working.

Thank someone whose steady, unnoticed work holds up your community.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for a place in his work beside others.
- Tell him what mockery or discouragement you face.
- Ask him to strengthen your hands.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 507 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 5:1-7:73

Social justice; the wall completed; the exiles registered

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 107 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 5:1-7:73. A crisis arises inside the community, and Nehemiah rebukes the wealthy for exploiting the poor. Then the enemies change tactics. The wall is finished in fifty-two days.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

While the wall is rising, a cry goes up from the poor. Famine, taxes, and debt have driven them to mortgage their fields and sell their children into slavery to their own countrymen. This is a problem more dangerous than any external enemy. Nehemiah also faces personal schemes to distract and frighten him, but the wall is finished in the month of Elul.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “There was a great outcry of the people and of their wives against their Jewish brothers” (5:1).
2. “I was very angry when I heard their outcry” (5:6).
3. “I consulted with myself, and I brought charges against the nobles” (5:7).
4. “The thing that you are doing is not good. Ought you not to walk in the fear of our God?” (5:9).
5. “Out of reverence for God I did not do so” (5:15).
6. “Come and let us meet together... But they intended to do me harm” (6:2).
7. “I am doing a great work and I cannot come down” (6:3).
8. “So the wall was finished on the twenty-fifth day of the month Elul, in fifty-two days” (6:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The hardest challenge to the wall came from within. The poor were crushed by debt, and some of the rich were profiting from their brothers' misery. This was exactly what the law of Moses forbade (Exodus 22:25, Leviticus 25:35-37). Nehemiah is furious, yet notice what he does: he "consulted with myself," meaning he took time to think before he acted. Then he called a great assembly and made his case on the basis of the fear of God and the witness to the nations. The nobles repent and give back the fields and interest. Nehemiah then points to his own example. As governor, he refused the food allowance due to him, because "the service was too heavy on the people." He led with his own life.

Then the enemy changes tactics. Four times they invite him to a meeting, planning to harm him. Nehemiah's answer is a classic: "I am doing a great work and I cannot come down." He knew his calling and would not be pulled off it. The enemy tries a false accusation, then a hired prophet who tries to scare him into hiding in the temple. Nehemiah sees through it: "Should such a man as I run away?" He discerned that the prophet was bribed. Then he prays: "Now, O God, strengthen my hands."

And the wall is finished in fifty-two days. Even the enemies recognize "this work had been accomplished with the help of our God." But the end of chapter 6 shows that trouble remains: Tobiah keeps sending letters. Chapter 7 sets up the next task, which is to repopulate the city and put people back in order.

STEP 5

Connection

James 5:1-6 condemns those who defraud their workers. Luke 3:11 and Acts 4:34-35 describe sharing with those in need. 1 Peter 5:2-3 calls leaders to serve as examples. Luke 9:51 says Jesus set his face toward Jerusalem. Philippians 3:13-14: "one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind… I press on." Galatians 6:2: bear one another's burdens.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether there is anyone you could help who is burdened by debt or need. Act on it.

Think of your "great work." What distractions do you need to say "I cannot come down" to?

Lead by example in one area where others look to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for the fear of him that treats others justly.

Ask him to keep you from taking advantage of the poor.

Thank him for the finished work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 508 · WEEK 73

Psalm 147

Praise the LORD who rebuilds Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 147. Imagine the people standing before the finished wall. Notice who builds, who gathers, and who counts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 147 is one of the five "Hallelujah" psalms that close the Psalter. Verse 2 reads, "The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers the outcasts of Israel." Many readers connect it to the dedication of the wall in Nehemiah 12. Whether or not it was written for that day, it fits perfectly. It praises the God who builds cities, heals the brokenhearted, counts the stars, and feeds the animals.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! For it is good to sing praises to our God" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers the outcasts of Israel" (v. 2).
3. "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds" (v. 3).
4. "He determines the number of the stars; he gives to all of them their names" (v. 4).
5. "Great is our Lord, and abundant in power; his understanding is beyond measure" (v. 5).
6. "The LORD lifts up the humble; he casts the wicked to the ground" (v. 6).
7. "His delight is not in the strength of the horse, nor his pleasure in the legs of a man" (v. 10).
8. "He declares his word to Jacob, his statutes and rules to Israel" (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm gives us a surprising list of what God does, all in the same breath. He builds Jerusalem. He gathers outcasts. He heals the brokenhearted and binds their wounds. And he counts and names every star. The same God who handles the vastness of the cosmos kneels to bandage a wound. There is no contradiction: greatness and tenderness belong together.

This is a good word for a people who had just finished a wall. The wall was built by Nehemiah and the workers, and yet "the LORD builds up Jerusalem." Our work is real, and God is the true builder (Psalm 127:1).

Verse 6 declares God's character: he lifts the humble and casts down the wicked. Verses 7 to 9 move to creation: rain on the earth, grass on the hills, food for the beasts and for the young ravens when they cry. God provides for the ravens. If he cares for them, he cares for his people.

Then verse 10 draws a line. He does not delight in the strength of the horse or the legs of a man. He takes pleasure "in those who fear him, in those who hope in his steadfast love." God is not impressed by human power. He is moved by humble trust.

The psalm ends with the word: God has given his statutes to Israel. "He has not dealt thus with any other nation." The greatest gift is not military strength or good weather but a God who speaks. The word is what makes the people a people.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 4:18 shows Jesus proclaiming healing for the brokenhearted and release for captives. Matthew 6:26 says the Father feeds the birds of the air. Matthew 10:29-31 teaches that he knows the sparrows and the hairs of our heads. John 10:3 says the shepherd calls his own sheep by name. Isaiah 40:26 also speaks of the God who calls the stars by name. John 1:1: In the beginning was the Word.

STEP 6

Application

Go outside tonight and look at the sky. Thank the God who named the stars and also knows your name.

Name a brokenhearted person you know. Ask God how you might be part of binding up their wounds.

Praise God aloud for his word, which he has given to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for rebuilding what is broken.
- Thank him that he heals the brokenhearted.
- Tell him what has been healed in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 509 · WEEK 73

Psalm 148

Praise the LORD from the heavens

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 148. This psalm calls every part of creation to praise: heavens, deeps, weather, mountains, animals, kings, and children. Read it aloud as a roll call.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 148 is a hymn that commands praise from everything God has made. It is structured in two halves: praise from the heavens (vv. 1-6) and praise from the earth (vv. 7-14). You will read this psalm again in Unit 24. Today, read it as the response of the rebuilt city, standing on a wall whose stones, towers, and gates lie under the open sky.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!” (v. 1).
2. “Praise him, all his angels; praise him, all his hosts!” (v. 2).
3. “Praise him, sun and moon, praise him, all you shining stars!” (v. 3).
4. “Let them praise the name of the LORD! For he commanded and they were created” (v. 5).
5. “Praise the LORD from the earth, you great sea creatures and all deeps” (v. 7).
6. “Fire and hail, snow and mist, stormy wind fulfilling his word!” (v. 8).
7. “Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all rulers of the earth! Young men and maidens together, old men and children!” (vv. 11-12).
8. “He has raised up a horn for his people, praise for all his saints” (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a vast choir. First the heavens: angels, hosts, sun, moon, stars, even "you waters above the heavens." They praise because "he commanded and they were created." Creation did not come from chance or from rival gods but from a spoken word. Everything in the sky exists by the will of God and is meant to bring him glory.

Then the earth: sea creatures, fire, hail, snow, stormy winds, mountains, fruit trees, cattle, creeping things, and flying birds. Notice the wildness. The deeps and the storms are not enemies of praise; even "stormy wind fulfilling his word." The elements that frightened ancient people are in the choir. Creation praises by being what God made it to be.

Finally comes humanity: kings and peoples, young and old, men and women. Everyone, from the throne to the cradle, is summoned. Humans praise with words and wills, which the rest of creation cannot do. We give voice to the whole choir.

The reason for praise is that "his name alone is exalted; his majesty is above earth and heaven." And then a surprising turn: "He has raised up a horn for his people." The God of galaxies takes special notice of a small people. A horn meant strength and a ruler. For a community just rebuilt, it carried the hope of a coming king.

For you, the point is that praise is not a private act that fits in the margins. It is the purpose of everything that exists. When you praise, you join a choir that is as old as creation.

STEP 5

Connection

Colossians 1:16 says all things were created through him and for him. Romans 8:19-22 says creation waits and groans for the revealing of the sons of God. Luke 1:69 says God "has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David." Philippians 2:10 says every knee will bow. Revelation 5:13 hears every creature in heaven and earth and under the earth and in the sea saying, "To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing."

STEP 6

Application

Spend ten minutes outdoors. Name five things you see and thank God for each.

Praise God with your whole voice today, by singing or speaking aloud.

Notice how everything around you was commanded into being by God's word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Join creation in praising God, naming what in creation moves you.
- Thank him that he commanded and you were created.
- Praise him for raising up a horn for his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 510 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 8:1-10:39

The law read; the Feast of Booths; covenant renewal

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 8:1-10:39. The people gather in the square and ask Ezra to read the Book of the Law. They stand, listen for hours, weep, and then are told to rejoice. They confess their sins and sign a covenant. Read it as the high point of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The wall is done, and the people settle in their towns. In the seventh month, at the Feast of Trumpets, they gather “as one man” in the square before the Water Gate. They have not been summoned by a king. They ask for the Book. This is a revival driven by the word of God. It is the only time in the Bible that we see an entire congregation hear the law and respond with weeping, joy, confession, and covenant renewal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And all the people gathered as one man into the square” (8:1).
2. “And Ezra opened the book in the sight of all the people… and as he opened it all the people stood” (8:5).
3. “They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading” (8:8).
4. “For all the people wept as they heard the words of the Law” (8:9).
5. “Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength” (8:10).
6. “And there was very great rejoicing” (8:17).
7. “You are the LORD, you alone. You have made heaven” (9:6).

8 “But you are a God ready to forgive, gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love” (9:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a scene of a people hungry for the word. Ezra stands on a wooden platform and reads from early morning until midday. Others “gave the sense” so everyone could understand. This is the pattern of faithful preaching: read the text, explain it, and apply it. The people stand, say “Amen, Amen,” lift their hands, and bow. The word was not a lecture but an encounter.

Then they weep. The law had convicted them of how far they had drifted. But the leaders say, “This day is holy to the LORD your God; do not mourn or weep.” The word does not leave them in grief. “Go your way, eat the fat and drink sweet wine… for the joy of the LORD is your strength.” The joy here is not their own mood. It is God’s joy in them, and it is a source of strength. Godly sorrow leads to joy.

They discover the Feast of Booths and keep it with great gladness. For the first time since Joshua, they build and live in booths. Then they gather again to confess. Chapter 9 contains one of the longest prayers in the Bible, a sweeping retelling of history from creation to the present. It praises God for faithfulness and confesses Israel’s repeated rebellion. The refrain is that God was “ready to forgive, gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love,” and he did not forsake them. It ends with honesty: “Behold, we are slaves this day… in the land that you gave.” The return is real and still incomplete.

Chapter 10 records their response: a written covenant, signed by leaders. They promise to walk in God’s law, to avoid mixed marriages, to keep the Sabbath, to support the temple, and to bring the firstfruits. “We will not neglect the house of our God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 119:105: “Your word is a lamp to my feet.” Luke 24:32: “Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road?” Romans 10:17: “Faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.” John 15:11: “that my joy may be in you, and that your joy may be full.” 2 Timothy 4:2 says to preach the word. Hebrews 12:2: “for the joy that was set before him.”

STEP 6

Application

Set aside time this week to read Scripture aloud, perhaps a whole chapter.

Ask what you could do to help others understand the word. “Give the sense” to someone younger in the faith.

When conviction comes, listen for the second sentence: “The joy of the LORD is your strength.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a hunger for his word.
- Ask him to turn your weeping into joy when his word convicts you.
- Thank him that the joy of the LORD is your strength.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 511 · WEEK 73

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Nehemiah 8:10 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."

NEHEMIAH 8:10

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken to a crowd in tears. They had just heard God's law read aloud, and the weight of their failure came crashing down. The leaders did not tell them their sorrow was wrong. They told them where it should lead.

"Do not be grieved." The command is not to deny sorrow. It is to refuse to stay in it. Grief that leaves us stuck is not the grief God wants. 2 Corinthians 7:10 says that godly grief leads to repentance, and repentance leads to life. The next step after sorrow is not more sorrow. It is joy.

"For the joy of the LORD." Whose joy is it? It is the LORD's joy. Not merely the joy the people have in him, though that is included. It is the joy God himself has: in his creation, in his people, in forgiving. Zephaniah 3:17 says he rejoices over us with gladness. This day was a feast day, and their Father was glad to have them home.

“Is your strength.” The word means a stronghold, a refuge. When your joy depends on circumstances, it can be taken. When it rests in God’s own delight, it holds. The people were facing opposition, poverty, and an uncertain future. They needed a strength that did not depend on any of that.

Say this verse when you feel heavy with guilt or weariness. Let it turn your face from yourself to God. He has not given up on you. He is glad to forgive, and his gladness is where you find strength.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked with Nehemiah from a palace in Susa to the walls of Jerusalem. You watched him pray for four months, then pray again in a breath before the king. You saw ordinary people repair the wall in front of their own houses, and you saw the enemy change tactics from ridicule to threat to flattery to fear. You saw Nehemiah rebuke the nobles for oppressing the poor and refuse to come down from his great work. The wall was finished in fifty-two days. In Psalm 147 and Psalm 148, you heard God praised as the builder of Jerusalem, healer of the brokenhearted, namer of the stars, and the one whose name every creature is called to praise. At the end of the week, the people gathered at the Water Gate, listened to the word of God for hours, wept, were told to rejoice, kept the Feast of Booths, confessed their sins, and signed a covenant.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Nehemiah prayed for months and also sent up quick prayers in the moment. How might you practice both kinds of prayer this week?

The returned exiles wept at the law and were told to rejoice. How does the gospel of Jesus Christ turn conviction into joy?

The wall was built by many hands, each near their own house. Where is your section of the wall, and who is working beside you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his joy is your strength.

Thank him for a word that convicts and comforts.

Rest in him.

DAY 512 · WEEK 74

Nehemiah 11:1-13:31

Jerusalem populated; the wall dedicated; final reforms

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 108 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 11:1-13:31. The city is repopulated and the wall is dedicated with two great choirs. Then Nehemiah returns from a trip to Susa and finds that the people have already slipped back into old sins. Notice the ending.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 11 lists those who settled in Jerusalem, chosen by lot to bring one in ten from the towns. Chapter 12 describes the joyful dedication of the wall. Chapter 13 jumps ahead, probably about 432 BC. Nehemiah had returned to Persia for a time. When he comes back, he finds that Tobiah has been given a room in the temple, the Levites are unpaid, the Sabbath is being broken, and some have married foreign wives again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And the people blessed all the men who willingly offered to live in Jerusalem” (11:2).
2. “And at the dedication of the wall of Jerusalem they sought the Levites… to celebrate the dedication with gladness” (12:27).
3. “And I brought the leaders of Judah up onto the wall, and appointed two great choirs that gave thanks” (12:31).
4. “And they offered great sacrifices that day and rejoiced, for God had made them rejoice with great joy” (12:43).
5. “And the sound of the joy of Jerusalem was heard far away” (12:43).
6. “And I was very angry, and I threw all the household furniture of Tobiah out of the chamber” (13:8).

7. “Why is the house of God forsaken?” (13:11).
8. “Remember me, O my God, for good” (13:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The dedication of the wall is a high point. Two great choirs and processions go around the wall in opposite directions, singing, with cymbals, harps, and lyres, and meet at the temple. The people offer sacrifices, and “God had made them rejoice with great joy.” Women and children rejoice too. The sound of Jerusalem’s joy is heard far away. This recalls the sound at the foundation of the temple in Ezra 3, but now it is clearly joy, without the weeping.

And then chapter 13 is a sober coda. Nehemiah returns and finds the covenant broken. Tobiah, the enemy who had mocked the builders, now lives in a storeroom of the temple. The Levites have gone back to their farms because no one paid them. The Sabbath markets are in full swing. Some have married foreign wives. Nehemiah’s reaction is fierce. He throws out Tobiah’s furniture, restores the tithes, shuts the gates on the Sabbath, and rebukes those who intermarried.

The lesson is plain. Reform does not last on its own. A wall can be built in fifty-two days, a covenant can be signed in a day, but the human heart drifts back. Even after confession and revival, the people forgot. This is why the Old Testament ends not with triumph but with a longing for something deeper. The law written on stone and walls built of stone cannot change the heart.

Nehemiah ends with a prayer: “Remember me, O my God, for good.” It is the prayer of a faithful servant who knows that his work is not finished. The book closes with unresolved tension: God’s people are back, but they need a better covenant. The new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31 and Ezekiel 36 is still ahead.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 31:33 promises a law written on the heart. Hebrews 8:6-13 says Jesus mediates a better covenant. Ezekiel 36:26: “I will give you a new heart.” Galatians 3:3 asks, “Are you so foolish? Having begun by the Spirit, are you now being perfected by the flesh?” Revelation 2:4 warns about leaving our first love. 1 Corinthians 10:12: “Let anyone who thinks that he stands take heed lest he fall.”

STEP 6

Application

Think about a reform in your life that has slipped. What helps a good change last?

Be humble about your own heart. Ask a trusted friend to check on you in an area of past failure.

Thank God that the new covenant does not depend on our consistency but on Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the joy of those who worship him.
- Ask him to keep you from drifting back.
- Ask him to write his law on your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 513 · WEEK 74

Esther 1:1-3:15

Esther becomes queen; Haman's plot

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Esther 1:1-3:15. A Persian king deposes his queen, a Jewish orphan becomes queen, and a proud official plots to destroy the Jews. Notice what is missing from the book: God's name is never mentioned.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Esther is set in Susa, the Persian capital, around 483 to 473 BC, between the first return under Zerubbabel and the return under Ezra. Most Jews had stayed in the empire. The book is a story of those who remained scattered. It never names God, never mentions prayer except fasting, and yet shows his hand everywhere. The theme is "God unseen but sovereign."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In those days, when King Ahasuerus sat on his royal throne in Susa, the citadel" (1:2).
2. "For the queen's behavior will become known to all women" (1:17).
3. "Mordecai... had taken her as his own daughter" (2:7).
4. "Esther had not made known her people or kindred, for Mordecai had commanded her" (2:10).
5. "And the king loved Esther more than all the women" (2:17).
6. "Mordecai told them that he was a Jew" (3:4).
7. "Haman... sought to destroy all the Jews, the people of Mordecai, throughout the whole kingdom of Ahasuerus" (3:6).
8. "And the king and Haman sat down to drink, but the city of Susa was thrown into confusion" (3:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a story full of coincidences. The queen refuses to appear, so she is replaced, and a Jewish orphan girl is chosen. Her cousin Mordecai happens to overhear a plot against the king and reports it, and the deed is written in the chronicles. Haman is promoted. Mordecai refuses to bow, and Haman's pride turns his anger against a whole people. He casts lots, called "pur," to choose the day of destruction, and the lot falls on a date eleven months away.

The author never says "God did this." Yet the reader sees a pattern: nothing is an accident. The Hebrew Bible keeps the name of God out of the text, but his purposes steer every scene. This is a book for people who live in a world where God seems silent. Most Jews of that age lived under pagan rule, far from the temple, with no prophet, no miracle, no visible sign. Esther says that God is still working.

There is a deeper background. Haman is an Agagite, a descendant of Agag, king of the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15). Mordecai is from the line of Kish, Saul's father. The old conflict between Israel and Amalek, which Saul failed to finish, is reborn. The enemy of God's people tries again to wipe them out. The question is whether God's promise to Abraham, to bless the nations through his seed, will survive.

The edict goes out, and the chapter ends with an ugly picture: the king and Haman sit down to drink while the city is in confusion. The powerful feast while the powerless tremble.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:28 says that God works all things together for good. Genesis 50:20: "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good." Proverbs 16:33: "The lot is cast into the lap, but its every decision is from the LORD." Exodus 17:14-16 is the LORD's war against Amalek. Psalm 121:4: he who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep.

STEP 6

Application

Where do you feel that God is silent in your life? Ask God to open your eyes to his unseen hand.

Look back at one "coincidence" in your story and thank God for it.

Pray for believers living under hostile or indifferent governments.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he rules even when his name is not spoken.

Ask him to open your eyes to his hand in your circumstances.

Tell him what feels like an accident in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

“And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?”

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 514 · WEEK 74

Esther 4:1-7:10

"For such a time as this"; the king's banquet; Haman exposed

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Esther 4:1-7:10. Esther is called to risk her life for her people. Read for the turning point in 4:14, and for the reversal at the end of chapter 7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

When Mordecai learns of the decree, he puts on sackcloth and ashes and weeps in the city. Esther, in the palace, hears of it. Anyone who approaches the king unsummoned may be put to death, unless the king holds out the golden scepter. Esther has not been called in thirty days. Mordecai's message to her is one of the great speeches of the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And in every province… there was great mourning among the Jews, with fasting and weeping and lamenting" (4:3).
2. "For if you keep silent at this time, relief and deliverance will rise for the Jews from another place, but you and your father's house will perish" (4:14).
3. "And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" (4:14).
4. "Go, gather all the Jews to be found in Susa, and hold a fast on my behalf" (4:16).
5. "And if I perish, I perish" (4:16).
6. "On that night the king could not sleep. And he gave orders to bring the book of memorable deeds" (6:1).
7. "What honor or dignity has been bestowed on Mordecai for this?" (6:3).
8. "So they hanged Haman on the gallows that he had prepared for Mordecai" (7:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mordecai's message is the heart of the book. He makes two points. First, Esther cannot hide in the palace: "Do not think to yourself that in the king's palace you will escape." Second, God's purpose does not depend on her. "Relief and deliverance will rise for the Jews from another place." This is as close as the book comes to naming God. Then comes the question: "Who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" It is a call to see one's position as a calling.

Esther's response grows from fear to courage. She asks for a three-day fast, which means prayer in all but name, and says, "If I perish, I perish." She will go to the king, trusting not in her beauty but in God. When she enters, the king holds out the scepter. She does not blurt out her request. She invites the king and Haman to a banquet, then to a second one. This is not hesitation but wisdom.

Meanwhile, the narrative shifts to a sleepless night. The king "could not sleep," and so he calls for the chronicles. They open to the record of Mordecai's good deed. The ironies multiply. Haman, who has just come to ask permission to hang Mordecai, is asked what should be done for the man the king delights to honor. Thinking it is himself, he proposes royal robes and a parade, and then must lead Mordecai through the streets.

At the second banquet, Esther names her request: "Let my life be granted me, and my people." Haman is exposed, and the gallows he built for Mordecai becomes his own. "Sleeplessness" in the ordinary world is a vehicle for providence.

STEP 5

Connection

Moses faced the same choice in Hebrews 11:24-26, giving up Pharaoh's palace to be mistreated with the people of God. Jesus said, "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (John 15:13). Psalm 7:15-16 and Proverbs 26:27 describe the trap that falls on the one who set it. Acts 17:26 says God determined the allotted periods of nations. 1 Peter 4:10: use your gifts to serve others.

STEP 6

Application

Ask: for what "such a time as this" might God have put you where you are?

Fast and pray before a major decision, as Esther and the Jews did.

Notice the people God has placed in your path, and be ready to speak up for them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to show you what purpose he has put you where you are.
- Ask for courage to speak when it costs you.
- Ask for wisdom in choosing the right moment.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 515 · WEEK 74

Esther 8:1-10:3

The reversal; deliverance; Purim, God unseen but sovereign

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Esther 8:1-10:3. The decree is reversed, the Jews defend themselves, and the festival of Purim is established. Read for the language of reversal.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Haman is dead, but the first decree, written in the king's name, cannot be revoked under Persian law. Esther and Mordecai are authorized to write a second decree, allowing the Jews to defend themselves on the appointed day. The book ends with the establishment of the festival of Purim, still celebrated by Jews today, and a brief note on Mordecai's greatness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On that day King Ahasuerus gave to Queen Esther the house of Haman" (8:1).
2. "And Mordecai… was set over the house of Haman" (8:2).
3. "For how can I bear to see the calamity that is coming to my people?" (8:6).
4. "The Jews had light and gladness and joy and honor" (8:16).
5. "And many from the peoples of the country declared themselves Jews, for fear of the Jews had fallen on them" (8:17).
6. "On the very day when the enemies of the Jews hoped to gain mastery over them, the reverse occurred" (9:1).
7. "As the days on which the Jews got relief from their enemies, and as the month that had been turned for them from sorrow into gladness" (9:22).
8. "For Mordecai the Jew was second in rank to King Ahasuerus… seeking the welfare of his people and speaking peace to all his people" (10:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of the book is a great reversal. What was meant for evil is turned to good. The day appointed for the destruction of the Jews becomes a day of their deliverance. The man who sought the throne's favor hangs on his own gallows. The man who would have been executed wears the king's ring. Mourning becomes feasting. Fear falls on the enemies.

The Jews are allowed to defend themselves, which they do. The text insists that they "laid no hand on the plunder," emphasizing that they were not seeking gain, in contrast to the Amalekite conflict where Saul kept the spoil. This time, the enemy of God's people is finished, and the people do what Saul failed to do.

Purim, from "pur," the lot, is established as a perennial reminder. "The month that had been turned for them from sorrow into gladness." The feast would include sending gifts to one another and to the poor. The memory of deliverance becomes an act of generosity.

Why is God never named? Many see a theological point. The book is written for the diaspora, the Jews who stayed behind. They would have to live by faith without temple or prophet. Esther shows them that God's providence is not limited to Jerusalem. He works through palaces, sleepless nights, banquets, and edicts. He keeps his promise to preserve the line of Abraham, through which the Messiah would come. The Jewish people cannot be wiped out, because the seed of the woman must come.

The last verse describes Mordecai as one who "sought the welfare of his people and spoke peace to all his people." It is a picture of faithful service in a foreign court, much like Joseph and Daniel before him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:31: "If God is for us, who can be against us?" Isaiah 61:3 promises a garland instead of ashes. John 16:20: "Your sorrow will turn into joy." Psalm 30:11: "You have turned for me my mourning into dancing." Jeremiah 29:7 told the exiles to seek the welfare of the city. Galatians 4:4: "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son." The preservation of the Jews led to the birth of Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Think about a situation that seems hopeless. Ask God for the "reversal" he can bring.

Practice the spirit of Purim: send a gift to a friend and to someone in need.

Seek the welfare of your city or workplace, as Mordecai did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for turning sorrow into gladness.
- Thank him for preserving his people when his name is unseen.
- Ask him to make you glad and generous.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

“And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?”

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 516 · WEEK 74

Psalm 145

I will extol you, my God and King

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 145. This is the last psalm of David in the Psalter, and the only one labeled "A Praise." Read it as a response to the book of Esther, which never mentions God, by a psalm that does nothing else.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 145 is an acrostic, with each verse beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet, covering praise from A to Z. It sets the tone for the final five psalms, which are full of hallelujahs. After reading Esther, where God's name is hidden, Psalm 145 shows that God's character is plain: he is great, good, near, and faithful.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will extol you, my God and King, and bless your name forever and ever" (v. 1).
2. "Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised, and his greatness is unsearchable" (v. 3).
3. "One generation shall commend your works to another, and shall declare your mighty acts" (v. 4).
4. "The LORD is gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love" (v. 8).
5. "The LORD is good to all, and his mercy is over all that he has made" (v. 9).
6. "Your kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and your dominion endures throughout all generations" (v. 13).
7. "The eyes of all look to you, and you give them their food in due season" (v. 15).
8. "The LORD is near to all who call on him, to all who call on him in truth" (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a sustained song of delight in God. David starts with a personal vow to praise every day, forever. But his praise is not private. “One generation shall commend your works to another.” The faith is passed along by telling.

The center of the psalm is verse 8, which echoes God’s self-revelation to Moses in Exodus 34:6: “gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love.” This phrase recurs throughout the Old Testament as the summary of God’s character. You have met it in Nehemiah 9 and will find it in Joel and Jonah. David builds on it: God is good to all, and his mercy is over all he has made.

The psalm then celebrates his kingdom, which is everlasting. Human kingdoms rise and fall: Babylon, Persia, and so on. But God’s reign does not end. And yet this great King is near. He upholds all who are falling, raises those who are bowed down, and opens his hand to satisfy the desire of every living thing.

Verses 17 to 20 speak about God’s nearness and justice. “The LORD is near to all who call on him in truth. He fulfills the desire of those who fear him; he also hears their cry and saves them.” This is the answer for the diaspora. Even when God’s name is not on the page, he is near.

The psalm ends with the promise that the wicked will be destroyed, and the call for all flesh to bless his holy name forever. There is a stunning phrase in the Hebrew Bible: there is no verse starting with the letter “nun” in the standard Hebrew text, though some ancient copies have one. Even the most careful praise is not complete; there is always more to say.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 is the source of the phrase in verse 8. Matthew 5:45 says that God makes his sun rise on the evil and the good. Matthew 6:33 promises that those who seek first the kingdom will be provided for. Luke 1:33 says of Jesus, “Of his kingdom there will be no end.” James 4:8: “Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you.” Revelation 4:11 praises the Lord for creating all things.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud as your morning praise. Let each verse draw you into worship.

Tell a younger person about something God has done for you. “One generation shall commend your works to another.”

Memorize verse 18, and pray it when you feel far from God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Extol God as King, in your own words.
- Tell him one thing he has done that you want to commend to another generation.
- Thank him that he is near to all who call on him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 517 · WEEK 74

Psalm 149; Psalm 150

Sing a new song; let everything that has breath praise

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalms 149 and 150. These are the final two psalms in the Psalter, and they close the book with praise. You will read them again in Unit 24. Read them now as the response to Esther's deliverance and the dedication of the wall.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 149 calls the people to sing a new song, with dancing and with a two-edged sword in hand. Psalm 150 is the grand finale, naming where, why, and with what to praise God. The Psalter began with Psalm 1, the blessed man who meditates on the law. It ends with every breath praising the LORD.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Sing to the LORD a new song, his praise in the assembly of the godly!" (149:1).
2. "Let Israel be glad in his Maker; let the children of Zion rejoice in their King!" (149:2).
3. "For the LORD takes pleasure in his people; he adorns the humble with salvation" (149:4).
4. "Let the high praises of God be in their throats and two-edged swords in their hands" (149:6).
5. "This is honor for all his godly ones. Praise the LORD!" (149:9).
6. "Praise God in his sanctuary; praise him in his mighty heavens!" (150:1).
7. "Praise him for his mighty deeds; praise him according to his excellent greatness!" (150:2).
8. "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD! Praise the LORD!" (150:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 149 begins with a new song. Throughout the Psalms, a "new song" is sung when God does something new. For the returned community, it means the new thing God has done in bringing them back, rebuilding, and keeping them safe. Praise includes dancing and music with tambourine and lyre.

Verse 4 is wonderful: "The LORD takes pleasure in his people; he adorns the humble with salvation." God is not only worshiped but delights in the worshipers. The humble, those who do not rely on themselves, are crowned with salvation.

Then the psalm takes a surprising turn: "two-edged swords in their hands, to execute vengeance on the nations." This has been read in many ways. In its Old Testament setting, it refers to God's people participating in his justice. The people of God are not passive. In the New Testament, the sword of the Spirit is the word of God (Ephesians 6:17; Hebrews 4:12). The final victory belongs to the Lord, and his people stand with him.

Psalm 150 is the climax. It answers four questions. Where? In his sanctuary and in the mighty heavens, which is everywhere. Why? For his mighty deeds and his excellent greatness. How? With trumpet, harp, lyre, tambourine, strings, pipe, and loud clashing cymbals. Praise is wholehearted and full of sound. Who? "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD." That includes you.

The five books of the Psalter each end with a doxology, and the fifth book ends with this final one that is itself the doxology of the whole. After 150 psalms of laments, confessions, complaints, and hope, the book ends in praise. It tells us where all prayer is meant to end.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 6:17 identifies the sword of the Spirit as the word of God. Hebrews 4:12: "The word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword." Revelation 5:9 speaks of the new song sung to the Lamb. Colossians 3:16 says to sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs with thankfulness. Luke 19:40: if the people were silent, the stones would cry out. Revelation 19:1-6 is the hallelujah of the multitude.

STEP 6

Application

Use Psalm 150 as a morning prayer for a week. Praise with your breath, your voice, and your body.

Sing or listen to a hymn or song that is new to you.

Ask: where is God doing something new that deserves a new song?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing or speak a new song to God, and let it be yours.
- Thank him that he takes pleasure in his people.
- Let everything that has breath praise him, and add your own.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

“And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?”

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 518 · WEEK 74

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Esther 4:14 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

REST

Meditation

This question was asked by an older cousin to a frightened young queen. It is a question, not a command, and that is part of its power.

"Who knows." Mordecai does not claim certainty. He cannot see the future. He is asking Esther to consider a possibility. God's purposes are often hidden, and we act without a guarantee. Faith lives in the space between what we know and what we hope.

"Whether you have not come to the kingdom." Esther did not choose to be queen. She was taken to the palace by force, hidden her identity, and lived in a gilded cage. Everything that happened to her could have looked like loss. Mordecai invites her to see a different story. Her position was not an accident.

“For such a time as this.” This is a call to the present. Esther was not asked to be queen in some other age. She was asked to act now. Our callings are tied to particular moments: this family, this job, this friendship, this crisis. We do not choose the time, but we are asked to meet it.

The verse comes just after a sobering warning. If she keeps silent, deliverance will come from another place. God does not need us. But he invites us. The honor is in being used.

Keep this verse near when you face a decision that is uncomfortable. You are where you are for a reason. Ask God what he wants to do through you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Nehemiah and read the book of Esther. You saw the wall dedicated with two choirs and a sound of joy heard far away, and you saw how quickly the people slipped back into their old ways. Nehemiah ended with a prayer: “Remember me, O my God, for good.” Then you moved to Persia and read the story of Esther, in which God’s name never appears and his hand is everywhere. You watched a queen risk her life, a sleepless king, a proud man hanged on his own gallows, and a day of sorrow turned into gladness. In Psalm 145, you praised the God who is near to all who call on him. In Psalms 149 and 150, you sang a new song and let everything that has breath praise the LORD.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Esther was asked to risk her position for others. What position, gift, or influence has God given you that could be used for someone else?

The book of Esther never names God, yet his work is visible. Where do you see his hidden hand in your own story?

Both Nehemiah and Esther point to a people who still need a better deliverer. How does Jesus fulfill what these books long for?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you courage and wisdom for the season you are in.

Thank him for his hidden hand and nearness.

Rest in him.

DAY 519 · WEEK 75

Psalm 115

Not to us, O LORD, not to us, but to your name give glory

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 115. This psalm contrasts the living God with lifeless idols. Read it as the song of a small, exposed community in a land full of other gods.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 115 was probably used in the second temple period. It begins with a famous line: "Not to us, O LORD." The nations ask, "Where is their God?" That question could be asked of the returned exiles, a small people under Persian rule. The psalm's answer is that God is in heaven and does as he pleases, while the gods of the nations are silver and gold, made by human hands.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Not to us, O LORD, not to us, but to your name give glory, for the sake of your steadfast love and your faithfulness!" (v. 1).
2. "Why should the nations say, Where is their God?" (v. 2).
3. "Our God is in the heavens; he does all that he pleases" (v. 3).
4. "Their idols are silver and gold, the work of human hands" (v. 4).
5. "They have mouths, but do not speak; eyes, but do not see" (v. 5).
6. "Those who make them become like them; so do all who trust in them" (v. 8).
7. "O Israel, trust in the LORD! He is their help and their shield" (v. 9).
8. "The heavens are the LORD's heavens, but the earth he has given to the children of man" (v. 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a humble prayer. “Not to us.” The people had just been through exile, return, and rebuilding, and they could easily have taken pride in their achievements. They deflect the glory. It belongs to God’s name, for the sake of his steadfast love and faithfulness.

The taunt of the nations is real: “Where is their God?” Israel has no king, no army, no visible image of their God. The answer is bold. Our God is in heaven and does whatever he pleases. He is not an object to be carried around. He is free and sovereign.

Then comes a sharp description of idols. They have mouths but cannot speak, eyes but cannot see, ears but cannot hear, noses but cannot smell, hands that cannot feel, feet that cannot walk. They are lifeless things dressed as persons. And the verdict in verse 8 is chilling: “Those who make them become like them.” What we worship shapes us. Whoever puts trust in something dead becomes deadened. Whoever worships power becomes hard; whoever worships money becomes cold. We become what we love.

The next section calls three groups to trust: Israel, the house of Aaron, and those who fear the LORD. Three times: “He is their help and their shield.” The refrain is a reminder that trust is a communal act.

The psalm closes with a blessing. “May the LORD give you increase, you and your children.” And with a promise of praise: “The dead do not praise the LORD… But we will bless the LORD from this time forth and forevermore.” Life is for praise.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 44:9-20 is a satirical description of idol-making. Romans 1:21-23 says people exchanged the glory of the immortal God for images. 1 John 5:21: “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.” 2 Corinthians 3:18: we are being transformed into the image of the Lord from one degree of glory to another. Colossians 3:5 says that covetousness is idolatry. John 8:50 shows Jesus seeking not his own glory.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you might be becoming like. What do you give your attention and trust to most?

When you succeed at something, pray “Not to us, O LORD” before accepting the praise.

Identify one modern idol (money, image, comfort, control) and renounce it in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give God the glory for something you were tempted to take credit for.
- Confess any trust in idols.
- Ask him to bless those who trust him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 520 · WEEK 75

Psalm 71

In you, O LORD, do I take refuge, the prayer of the aging saint

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 71. This is the prayer of an old believer, looking back on a lifetime of God's faithfulness and forward to the end. Read it slowly, as if praying it for a grandparent, or for yourself in forty years.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 71 has no title, but it follows Psalm 70 and reads like a continuation. The writer has trusted God from youth and now faces old age and enemies. Many in the second temple community, old men who had seen the first temple, would have prayed it. It is the great psalm of lifelong faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame!" (v. 1).
2. "Be to me a rock of refuge, to which I may continually come" (v. 3).
3. "For you, O Lord, are my hope, my trust, O LORD, from my youth" (v. 5).
4. "Do not cast me off in the time of old age; forsake me not when my strength is spent" (v. 9).
5. "But I will hope continually and will praise you yet more and more" (v. 14).
6. "O God, from my youth you have taught me, and I still proclaim your wondrous deeds" (v. 17).
7. "So even to old age and gray hairs, O God, do not forsake me, until I proclaim your might to another generation" (v. 18).

8 “You who have made me see many troubles and calamities will revive me again; from the depths of the earth you will bring me up again” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is an elder’s prayer. The speaker has relied on God since birth: “Upon you I have leaned from before my birth; you are he who took me from my mother’s womb.” God has been faithful through every season. Yet old age brings new fears: “Do not cast me off in the time of old age.” Strength is ebbing, and enemies see weakness as an opportunity: “God has forsaken him; pursue and seize him.”

The psalmist’s answer is not despair but renewed praise. “I will hope continually and will praise you yet more and more.” Hope grows rather than fades. His mouth will tell of God’s righteous acts all day long, “for their number is past my knowledge.” He cannot count them all.

The center of the psalm is verse 18. The old man asks for continued life with a purpose: “until I proclaim your might to another generation, your power to all those to come.” This is what old age is for. The aim of long life is not comfort but testimony. Those who have walked with God for decades are a treasure to the church. They have seen troubles and calamities, and they can say, “God brought me through.”

The psalm ends with confidence: “You will revive me again.” The one who made him see many troubles will bring him up from the depths. There is a note here that reaches beyond this life, toward resurrection. And the final word is praise, with harp, lyre, and lips that shout for joy.

For the young, the psalm is a challenge: build a life of trust now, so that you can pray this in old age. For the old, it is a comfort.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 46:4: “Even to your old age I am he, and to gray hairs I will carry you.” Titus 2:2-5 charges older believers to teach the younger. 2 Corinthians 4:16: “Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day.” Psalm 92:14: the righteous “still bear fruit in old age.” 2 Timothy 4:7-8: “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race.” Deuteronomy 6:7: teach your children.

STEP 6

Application

Call or visit an older believer and ask them to tell you how God has been faithful to them.

If you are older, write down three stories of God's faithfulness to pass on.

Pray verse 18 for yourself: "Let me proclaim your might to another generation."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for being your hope from youth.
- Ask him not to cast you away when you are old or weak.
- Pray for the generation that comes after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 521 · WEEK 75

Psalm 144

Blessed be the LORD, my rock, a new song for restoration

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 144. This is a psalm of David asking for deliverance from enemies, and it ends with a vision of a blessed people. Read the first half as a war prayer and the second half as a prayer for peace.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 144 is attributed to David and combines several earlier psalms. It begins with praise to God as the trainer of his hands for battle and ends with a vision of a prosperous society. It sits well here in the unit because the returned exiles lived under constant threat. They longed for the kind of safety and blessing that the final verses describe.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed be the LORD, my rock, who trains my hands for war, and my fingers for battle” (v. 1).
2. “He is my steadfast love and my fortress, my stronghold and my deliverer, my shield and he in whom I take refuge” (v. 2).
3. “O LORD, what is man that you regard him, or the son of man that you think of him?” (v. 3).
4. “Man is like a breath; his days are like a passing shadow” (v. 4).
5. “I will sing a new song to you, O God” (v. 9).
6. “Rescue me and deliver me from the hand of foreigners, whose mouths speak lies” (v. 11).
7. “May our sons in their youth be like plants full grown” (v. 12).

8 “Blessed are the people to whom such blessings fall! Blessed are the people whose God is the LORD!” (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a remarkable confession. David is a warrior, and he knows his skill is a gift: God “trains my hands for war.” Strength and courage come from God. He lists eight names for him: rock, steadfast love, fortress, stronghold, deliverer, shield, refuge, and the one who subdues peoples. Each is a different image of security.

Then comes a note of wonder: “O LORD, what is man that you regard him?” It is a smaller echo of Psalm 8. Man is a breath, a shadow. And yet God notices. The contrast between our frailty and God’s attention is the basis for the plea that follows: “Bow your heavens, O LORD, and come down.” The psalmist asks for the kind of divine intervention seen at Sinai, with mountains smoking and lightning flashing.

The second half moves from threat to peace. The prayer is for sons like full-grown plants, daughters like carved pillars, barns full, flocks multiplying, no breach in the walls and no cry in the streets. This is a picture of shalom: safe homes, thriving families, plentiful provision. It is what the returned exiles hoped for, with a rebuilt wall and a re-established covenant community.

The last line is profound: “Blessed are the people whose God is the LORD!” The blessing is not just the peace and plenty. It is having the LORD as God. If the barns are empty and the sons are weak, the people are still blessed because they have him. If everything else were provided and he were missing, they would have nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 8:4 is the source of the question about man. Hebrews 2:6-9 applies it to Jesus, who tasted death for everyone. James 4:14: “You are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes.” Ephesians 6:10-17 describes spiritual warfare and armor. Matthew 5:3-12 gives the blessings of the kingdom. Revelation 21:3: “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.”

STEP 6

Application

Name eight ways God is your security, as David did in verse 2.

Pray for peace and flourishing for the families of your church and neighborhood.

Ask yourself whether you count yourself blessed because of what God gives, or because he is your God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as your rock, fortress, and refuge.
- Ask him to teach your hands and bless your people.
- Tell him you want to sing a new song.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 522 · WEEK 75

1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55

Genealogies from Adam through Judah's line [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 109 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55. This is a survey reading, so do not try to study every name. Read it as the opening of a story: the line from Adam to Abraham to Israel to Judah. Watch where the genealogy slows down.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chronicles was written for the returned community, probably after 400 BC, to answer a pressing question: are we still the people of God? The first book begins with nine chapters of genealogies, a surprising start. But to a people who had lost their kingdom, temple, and land, these lists said: you belong. The line from Adam never broke. Chronicles retells the history of Israel from Adam to the decree of Cyrus, focusing on David, the temple, and the hope of restoration. It is a different perspective from Samuel and Kings, which were written in exile.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Adam, Seth, Enosh" (1:1).
2. "The sons of Noah: Shem, Ham, and Japheth" (1:4).
3. "Abraham, that is, Abraham" (1:27).
4. "The sons of Abraham: Isaac and Ishmael" (1:28).
5. "These are the sons of Israel: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun" (2:1).
6. "The sons of Judah: Er, Onan, and Shelah" (2:3).
7. "Achan, the troubler of Israel, who broke faith in the matter of the devoted thing" (2:7).
8. "Jesse fathered Eliab his firstborn… David the seventh" (2:13-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The genealogy begins with Adam and moves quickly through the nations of the world. The Chronicler wants his readers to see that Israel's story is part of the world's story. All nations descend from Adam and Noah, and Israel is chosen out of them. Then the lists narrow: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and the twelve sons.

Then the writer slows down on Judah, listing his sons and their descendants. Judah is the line of the king, and the lists lead toward David. The genealogy is not neutral. It is shaped to tell a story of promise. Even in the lists, we see grace: Tamar, who was wronged and acted, is named. Rahab, once a Canaanite prostitute, is in the line of Judah. Even Achan, the troubler, is remembered, a reminder that failure is part of the story.

Why include these names? In the ancient world, a genealogy was a kind of identity card. To the returned exiles, the names proved that they were not forgotten. Every name stands for a person known to God. The Chronicler's point is that the promises to Abraham and David were still alive.

There is also a subtle emphasis on God's choice. David is the seventh son of Jesse, the youngest, not the oldest. The one who was passed over by his own family is the one God chose. Throughout the Chronicles, the surprising pattern appears again and again: God chooses the unexpected.

As you read, do not feel lost in the names. Treat them like a family photo album. You do not need to know everyone in it, but you can feel that you belong to a story much bigger than yourself.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:1-17 opens the New Testament with a genealogy of Jesus, including Tamar, Rahab, and Ruth. Luke 3:23-38 traces Jesus back to Adam. Luke 10:20 says to rejoice that your names are written in heaven. Philippians 4:3 speaks of names in the book of life. Revelation 21:27 mentions the Lamb's book of life. Acts 17:26 says that God made from one man every nation.

STEP 6

Application

Take a few minutes to write the names of three generations of your family. Thank God for each.

Remember that you are known by name. Read Luke 10:20 aloud.

Notice God's surprising choices, in Scripture and in your life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that your name is known to him.

Thank him that no one is forgotten in his plan.

Ask him to keep you faithful to your place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 523 · WEEK 75

1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26

David's descendants; Levi, Reuben, Gad, half-Manasseh [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26. This is another survey reading. Look for the royal line of David, the prayer of Jabez, and the notes about warriors who cried out to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The next section lists David's sons, the kings of Judah to the exile, and then the genealogies of the remaining tribes. Chapter 3 ends with the line of David continuing after the exile through Jehoiachin and Zerubbabel. The Chronicler is saying that the Davidic line did not die in Babylon. Scattered through the lists are brief stories, little windows into lives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "These were the sons of David who were born to him in Hebron" (3:1).
2. "The sons of Jeconiah, the captive: Shealtiel his son… Zerubbabel" (3:17-19).
3. "Jabez was more honorable than his brothers; and his mother called his name Jabez, saying, Because I bore him in pain" (4:9).
4. "Jabez called upon the God of Israel, saying, Oh that you would bless me and enlarge my border" (4:10).
5. "And God granted what he asked" (4:10).
6. "For they cried out to God in the battle, and he granted their urgent plea because they trusted in him" (5:20).
7. "But they broke faith with the God of their fathers, and whored after the gods of the peoples of the land" (5:25).
8. "So the God of Israel stirred up the spirit of Pul king of Assyria" (5:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The royal line is carefully traced. David's sons are listed, including Solomon, and then the long line of the kings of Judah. After the exile, the line continues: Jehoiachin, Shealtiel, and Zerubbabel, who led the first return. This is deliberate. Chronicles says that the house of David did not end. God's covenant with David stands, even though there is no king on the throne at the time of writing.

In the middle of the genealogies, we find a short story of a man named Jabez. His name means "pain," because his mother bore him in sorrow. He could have lived under the weight of that name. Instead, he cried out to God. He asked for blessing, for enlarged borders, for God's hand to be with him, and to be kept from harm. "And God granted what he asked." The story tells us that our origins do not determine our future. A person with a painful beginning can pray boldly and be heard. But note the point is not a formula for prosperity. It is trust in God's ability to bless.

Chapter 5 includes another telling detail about the tribes east of the Jordan, who "cried out to God in the battle, and he granted their urgent plea because they trusted in him." Victory is credited to trust, not strength. But by the end of the chapter, those same tribes broke faith and were exiled. This is the Chronicler's pattern: faith leads to blessing, and unfaithfulness leads to loss, but prayer is always open.

Notice also the ending: "The God of Israel stirred up the spirit of Pul king of Assyria." Even the exile is seen as God's hand at work. The same phrase, "stirred up the spirit," appeared in Ezra 1:1 for Cyrus. God stirs up both judgment and restoration.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:12-13 includes Zerubbabel in the line of Jesus. Luke 11:9-10 says to ask, seek, and knock. James 4:2: "You do not have, because you do not ask." Ephesians 3:20 says God is able to do far more than all we ask or think. Psalm 34:6: "This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him." John 16:24: "Ask, and you will receive, that your joy may be full."

STEP 6

Application

If you carry a painful name or beginning, offer it to God, and ask him to rename your future.

Pray a bold, specific prayer today, in line with God's character and purposes.

When facing a battle, practice crying out to God first.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God about where your beginnings were painful.
- Ask him to bless you and enlarge your borders for his purpose.
- Thank him for hearing those who cry out.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 524 · WEEK 75

1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44

Levitical genealogies; Jerusalem after the exile [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 124 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44. This is the last survey reading from the genealogies. Pay attention to the Levites, who serve in worship, and to the people who returned to Jerusalem at the end of chapter 9.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler gives special attention to the tribe of Levi, because the temple and its worship were central for the returned community. Chapter 6 lists the priestly line from Aaron and the singers appointed by David. Chapter 9 ends the genealogies with a roll call of those who returned from exile and lived in Jerusalem. The introduction is over, and the story of David begins in chapter 10.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “These are the men whom David put in charge of the service of song in the house of the LORD” (6:31).
2. “And they ministered with song before the tabernacle of the tent of meeting” (6:32).
3. “But Aaron and his sons made offerings on the altar of burnt offering” (6:49).
4. “All these, chosen as gatekeepers at the thresholds, were 212” (9:22).
5. “Now the first to dwell again in their possessions in their cities were Israel, the priests, the Levites, and the temple servants” (9:2).
6. “And some of the sons of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh lived in Jerusalem” (9:3).
7. “Some of them had charge of the vessels of service” (9:28).

8 “They were in the singers, the heads of fathers” houses of the Levites, dwelling in the chambers of the temple, free from other service, for they were on duty day and night’ (9:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Levites are given a large place for a reason. The Chronicler wanted the community to remember that worship is not an afterthought. After the exile, with no king, the temple and its worship were the center of national life. Levi’s line is listed in detail: the gatekeepers, the singers, and the priests. Even the musicians are named. David appointed men to the service of song, and they “ministered with song” before the tabernacle until Solomon built the temple.

This is one of the Chronicler’s emphases. Music is ministry. Those who sang were serving in the house of the LORD, just as those who offered sacrifices. The worship of God deserves skill, order, and care. Chapter 9 says some singers were “on duty day and night.” There was constant praise.

Chapter 9 ends with the list of those who settled in Jerusalem after the exile. It mirrors the lists in Nehemiah 11. After the long genealogy, we arrive at the present: the people are back, the city is occupied, the work of worship resumes. The genealogy is not an empty record. It leads to the community that is reading it.

Then the chapter ends with a reminder of King Saul’s genealogy, and immediately chapter 10 will tell of his death. The mood shifts. The introduction is over. The Chronicler has given us a map of the people. Now he will tell the story.

Do not be discouraged if these chapters feel dry. They are the foundation. Everything that follows, the story of David’s kingdom and the temple, rests on the belief that God knows his people by name and has a place for each.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Peter 2:9 calls the church a royal priesthood. Hebrews 4:14-16 names Jesus as our great high priest. Revelation 1:6 says he made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father. Ephesians 5:19 says to sing and make melody to the Lord with your heart. Colossians 3:16 mentions teaching one another with psalms and hymns. Romans 12:1 invites us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice.

STEP 6

Application

Think about those who serve behind the scenes in your church, such as musicians, ushers, and volunteers. Thank one of them.

If you have a musical or creative gift, ask how God might use it in worship.

Practice offering your ordinary work as service to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has a place for each person in his work.

Thank someone who serves behind the scenes.

Ask him to show you your place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 525 · WEEK 75

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Chronicles 16:34 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

REST

Meditation

This verse comes from the song David gave to Asaph and his brothers on the day the ark was brought to Jerusalem. You will read the whole song in a few days, in 1 Chronicles 16. It is a verse that bridges the Chronicler's world and yours.

"Oh give thanks to the LORD." This is a command in the form of an invitation. The word for thanks means to acknowledge, to confess, to give credit where it is due. Thanks is not just a feeling but a public statement. We say out loud who God is and what he has done.

"For he is good." The reason for thanks is God's character. He is good in himself. Not just good to us when things go well, but good in his nature. Jesus said, "No one is good except God alone" (Mark 10:18). All goodness comes from him.

“For his steadfast love endures forever.” The Hebrew word is hesed, covenant love, loyal love. It is the love that sticks. The word “endures” says that it does not run out. After the exile, the returned community needed this assurance. They had seen the covenant curses fall. And yet his love was still there.

The verse recurs again and again in the Bible: in Ezra 3:11, in Psalm 136, and in Jeremiah 33:11. When something appears so many times in Scripture, God is telling us to remember it. It was the song of the people at every major moment: bringing the ark, dedicating the temple, laying the foundation. It can be your song too, at every turning point in your life.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Chronicles with the great genealogies. You moved from Adam through Noah, Abraham, Israel, and Judah, and saw the royal line of David continue past the exile to Zerubbabel. You met Jabez, whose painful name did not decide his future, and the eastern tribes who cried out in battle and were heard. You read about the Levites, singers, and gatekeepers who served in worship, and you saw the list end with those who returned to Jerusalem. Along the way, you prayed three psalms: Psalm 115, against idols and for God’s glory alone; Psalm 71, the prayer of the aged believer; and Psalm 144, a prayer for deliverance and for a blessed people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Chronicler’s lists told the exiles that they belonged. Where do you find assurance that you belong to God’s people?

Jabez prayed boldly for blessing. What bold prayer, consistent with God’s will, might you offer this week?

Jesus appears in a genealogy that includes sinners and outsiders. How does that shape the way you see your own family story?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is good and his steadfast love endures forever.

Thank him for your place in his story.

Rest in him.

DAY 526 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14

Saul's death; David made king; the ark journey

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14. Chronicles passes over Saul's life and tells only his death, then moves quickly to David's anointing as king over all Israel. Read for what the Chronicler chooses to emphasize.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler's story begins with the death of Saul, which he gives a theological explanation: Saul died for his unfaithfulness. Then, in a single move, "all Israel" gathers at Hebron to make David king. The Chronicler skips David's years as a fugitive and his seven-year reign over Judah. He wants to show a unified nation under God's chosen king, with David's first act being to capture Jerusalem and bring the ark there.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So Saul died for his breach of faith. He broke faith with the LORD in that he did not keep the command of the LORD" (10:13).
2. "And he did not seek guidance from the LORD. Therefore the LORD put him to death" (10:14).
3. "Then all Israel gathered to David at Hebron and said, Behold, we are your bone and flesh" (11:1).
4. "And the LORD your God said to you, You shall be shepherd of my people Israel" (11:2).
5. "And David became greater and greater, for the LORD of hosts was with him" (11:9).
6. "These were the chiefs of David's mighty men, who gave him strong support in his kingdom" (11:10).

7. “And David said to all the assembly of Israel, If it seems good to you, and from the LORD our God… let us bring again the ark of our God to us” (13:2-3).

8. “And Uzzah put out his hand to take hold of the ark… and God struck him down because he put out his hand to the ark” (13:9-10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler’s judgment on Saul is one sentence: he broke faith and he did not seek the LORD. That is the key. The central question of Chronicles is whether the kings “sought the LORD.” This phrase recurs throughout the books and is the test of every reign. Saul did not. David did.

The story shifts to David at Hebron, where all the tribes come together. Notice the key phrase: the LORD said, “You shall be shepherd of my people.” David’s reign is a gift from God. Jerusalem is taken, and the Chronicler stresses that David’s power grew because “the LORD of hosts was with him.” The list of mighty men follows, each of whom contributed to the kingdom. Chapter 12 describes the soldiers who came from all the tribes: “all of one mind to make David king.” Unity around God’s king is a major theme.

Then David consults with the leaders about the ark, which had been neglected since the days of Eli. “Let us bring again the ark of our God to us, for we did not seek it in the days of Saul.” The ark was the symbol of God’s presence, and bringing it to Jerusalem would make the city the spiritual center.

But the first attempt fails. They put the ark on a new cart, as the Philistines had done, rather than carry it on the shoulders of Levites as the law prescribed. When the oxen stumble, Uzzah reaches out to steady the ark and dies on the spot. It is a shocking moment. David is angry and afraid. The lesson is that good intentions are not enough. God’s presence is holy, and it must be approached on his terms. The ark is left at the house of Obed-edom for three months, and that house is blessed.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:28-29 says our God is a consuming fire, and we should offer acceptable worship with reverence and awe. John 4:24 says true worshipers worship in spirit and truth. Matthew 2:6 quotes Micah on the shepherd of Israel, and John 10:11 says Jesus is the good shepherd. Ephesians 4:3-6 urges unity of the Spirit. Leviticus 10:1-3 and Numbers 4:15 show the holiness of sacred things. 1 Samuel 13:13-14 records Saul’s disobedience.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself how you seek the LORD in your decisions, not after the fact but before.

Think about approaching God with reverence. Is there any casualness in your worship that needs correcting?

Pray for unity among believers around Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you one who seeks him, as David did.
- Confess where you have gone your own way.
- Ask for his presence.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 527 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27

David's victories; the ark in Jerusalem; the covenant

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27. The ark comes to Jerusalem with joy, David sings a great psalm of thanksgiving, and God makes his covenant with David. Read chapter 16 as worship and chapter 17 as promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the failure of the first attempt, David prepares a tent for the ark and has the Levites carry it properly. The procession is a feast of music and dancing. David then appoints Asaph and his brothers to give thanks daily before the ark. Then David, living in a house of cedar, wants to build a house for God, and God responds with a covenant that is the pivot of the whole Bible: God will build David a house.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For none but the Levites may carry the ark of God" (15:2).
2. "Thus all Israel brought up the ark of the covenant of the LORD with shouting, to the sound of the horn, trumpets, and cymbals, and made loud music on harps and lyres" (15:28).
3. "On that day David first appointed that thanksgiving be sung to the LORD by Asaph and his brothers" (16:7).
4. "Oh give thanks to the LORD; call upon his name; make known his deeds among the peoples!" (16:8).
5. "Sing to the LORD, all the earth! Tell of his salvation from day to day" (16:23).
6. "Moreover, I declare to you that the LORD will build you a house" (17:10).

7. “I will raise up your offspring after you… and I will establish his kingdom” (17:11).
8. “I will establish his throne forever” (17:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This time David does it right. The Levites carry the ark on their shoulders, as the law prescribed. The music and sacrifices are offered. David even dances in joy, which his wife Michal despises, though the Chronicler does not dwell on it. The ark is placed in the tent David prepared, and then David delivers a psalm that is a compilation of what we know as parts of Psalms 105, 96, and 106. It is a missionary hymn: “Make known his deeds among the peoples! Sing to the LORD, all the earth! Declare his glory among the nations.” David was not satisfied with a local, tribal religion. His praise reached to all peoples.

The psalm ends with the refrain that you memorized at the weekly rest: “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever.” Then comes the daily ministry of the Levites. The worship of Israel was constant.

Then comes chapter 17, the greatest moment. David says, “I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of the covenant of the LORD is under a tent.” He wants to build a house for God. God, through Nathan, turns it around: you will not build a house for me, but I will build a house for you. A dynasty. “I will raise up your offspring after you, one of your own sons, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for me, and I will establish his throne forever.” Solomon will build the temple, but the promise reaches farther. The Chronicler, writing after the monarchy ended, holds on to this promise. The throne of David will be established forever, and that can only be fulfilled in someone greater than any of David’s sons.

David’s response is a model prayer: “Who am I, O LORD God, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far?” It is humility before grace.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:32-33: the angel says that the Lord God will give Jesus the throne of his father David, and “of his kingdom there will be no end.” Hebrews 1:5 quotes “I will be to him a father” from this chapter. Acts 13:22-23 connects David and Jesus. Matthew 28:19 sends the church to all nations. Romans 15:9-11 shows the nations praising God. Psalm 89:3-4 recalls the covenant with David.

STEP 6

Application

Make the praise of 16:8-36 your own. Read it aloud and mention God’s deeds in your life.

Ask: who might I tell about God's deeds this week? Make known his deeds among the peoples.

Pray David's prayer: "Who am I, O LORD God, that you have brought me thus far?"

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God and call upon his name.
- Ask him to help you make known his deeds among the nations.
- Thank him for the covenant he made with David.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 528 · WEEK 76

Psalm 96

Sing to the LORD a new song, David's psalm at the ark

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 96. You read this in Unit 3 as a song of the nations. Notice that much of it is quoted in 1 Chronicles 16, where David first gave it to Asaph, and read it now as the missionary song of the returned people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 96 appears almost word for word in 1 Chronicles 16:23-33. The Chronicler included it because it captures the heart of David's worship: a song that sends praise to the whole earth. A small, fragile community, rebuilding in a corner of the Persian empire, still sang that God is king over all nations. That is the faith of the returned exiles. They did not shrink their God to fit their circumstances.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day" (v. 2).
3. "Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!" (v. 3).
4. "For great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; he is to be feared above all gods" (v. 4).
5. "For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols, but the LORD made the heavens" (v. 5).
6. "Ascribe to the LORD, O families of the peoples, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength" (v. 7).
7. "Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!" (v. 10).

8 “He will judge the world in righteousness, and the peoples in his faithfulness” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a missionary hymn. Its first three verses are a chain of commands: sing, bless, tell, declare. The song is not meant to stay in the temple. The goal is to tell the nations. This was an extraordinary thing for a small people to say. They had nothing to boast about: no army, no king, no wall until recently. And yet they said, “Declare his glory among the nations.”

The reason is who God is. He is great and above all gods. The gods of the peoples are “worthless idols,” a word that plays on “elilim,” meaning “nothings.” But the LORD made the heavens. The contrast is between nothing and the Maker. Having heard Psalm 115 only a few days ago, you recognize the theme.

Then the psalm calls the “families of the peoples” to ascribe glory to the LORD and to bring an offering and come into his courts. The nations are not simply an audience; they are invited to worship. This is the vision first given to Abraham: “In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.”

The announcement at the center is the best news: “Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!” The heavens rejoice, the earth is glad, the sea roars, the fields exult, and the trees of the forest sing for joy. All creation celebrates because he is coming to judge. The judgment is good news: it means that wrongs will be set right, the oppressed will be vindicated, and the world will finally be put in order. He will judge “in righteousness” and “in his faithfulness.”

You read this in Unit 3 as an invitation. Today, remember that the people who sang it were few and weak. And God used them.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:3 promises that all families of the earth will be blessed through Abraham. Matthew 28:19-20 sends the disciples to make disciples of all nations. Acts 17:30-31 says God will judge the world in righteousness by a man he has appointed. Revelation 7:9-10 shows people from every nation praising God. Romans 10:14-15 asks how people will hear without a preacher. Revelation 11:15: “The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

Tell someone this week one thing about God that you believe is good news for them.

Pray for a missionary or a people group that has not heard.

Sing or read the psalm aloud outdoors, joining the trees of the forest.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing to the LORD a new song, in your own words.

Tell him he is greater than every other thing you are tempted to rely on.

Ask him to help you declare his glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 529 · WEEK 76

Psalm 105:1-15

Give thanks to the LORD; remember his covenant

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:1-15. You read this in earlier units as a recital of God's covenant faithfulness. The first fifteen verses were also part of David's song in 1 Chronicles 16. Notice how the song uses the covenant with Abraham as a ground for present thanks.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 is a long historical psalm, recounting God's care of Israel from Abraham to the conquest. The first fifteen verses were sung on the day the ark came to Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 16:8-22). They set out the call to remember and then the heart of what they were to remember: the covenant. The returned exiles were reading this in a time when the land was again precarious. It reminded them that the promise to Abraham did not depend on their strength.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh give thanks to the LORD; call upon his name; make known his deeds among the peoples!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to him, sing praises to him; tell of all his wondrous works!" (v. 2).
3. "Let the hearts of those who seek the LORD rejoice!" (v. 3).
4. "Seek the LORD and his strength; seek his presence continually!" (v. 4).
5. "Remember the wondrous works that he has done, his miracles, and the judgments he uttered" (v. 5).
6. "He is the LORD our God; his judgments are in all the earth" (v. 7).

7. “He remembers his covenant forever, the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations” (v. 8).
8. “When they were few in number, of little account, and sojourners in it” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a string of imperatives, nine in a row: give thanks, call, make known, sing, sing praises, tell, glory, rejoice, seek. Worship in Scripture is active, public, and full of verbs. Notice verse 3: “Let the hearts of those who seek the LORD rejoice.” Seeking, which is often hard, is joyful.

Verse 5 gives the central command: remember. “Remember the wondrous works that he has done.” The main work of faith is memory. We forget so easily. The returned exiles had been through trauma, and remembering God’s past acts was how they kept hope alive. For you too, remembering is a spiritual discipline. Keep a journal, mark anniversaries, tell stories.

The heart of the psalm is verses 8 to 11: God “remembers his covenant forever.” Not just for one or two generations, but “for a thousand generations.” The covenant given to Abraham, repeated to Isaac and Jacob, includes the promise of Canaan. That promise was kept even though Israel was “few in number, of little account, and sojourners.” The people were small, weak, and wandering, yet God protected them: “He allowed no one to oppress them; he rebuked kings on their account.” Pharaoh and Abimelech are the examples. God said of the patriarchs, “Touch not my anointed ones, do my prophets no harm.”

For the post-exilic community, the phrase “few in number, of little account” described them exactly. And the psalm tells them that their smallness did not matter to God. The covenant he made held them. This is a major part of the Chronicler’s message: you are small, but you are the people to whom God made promises, and he will keep them.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 22:19: “Do this in remembrance of me.” Deuteronomy 7:7-9 says God did not set his love on Israel because they were many, but because he loved them and kept his oath. 1 Corinthians 1:26-29 says God chooses the weak and lowly. Galatians 3:29: “If you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s offspring.” Luke 1:72-73 says God remembered his holy covenant. Matthew 28:20: “I am with you always.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of ten “wondrous works” of God in your life. Read it aloud this week.

Take the Lord's Supper, or think about it if you are not able, and remember Christ's work.

Seek the LORD's presence continually: set a time each day to be still with him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks and remember his wondrous works, naming one.
- Thank him that he remembers his covenant forever.
- Ask him to let you seek his face always.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 530 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19

David's victories; the census; preparing for the Temple

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 109 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19. David's victories are summarized, and the book tells of his census sin and the choice of the temple site. David then prepares for the temple he will not build. Notice what the Chronicler leaves out.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler summarizes David's wars in a single chapter or two, and he leaves out the story of Bathsheba and Uriah entirely. This is not a cover-up, since the readers knew Samuel and Kings. His purpose is different. He wants to show the faithful side of David and focus on the temple. The one sin he does include is the census, because it led to the site of the temple.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the LORD gave victory to David wherever he went" (18:6).
2. "Satan stood against Israel and incited David to number Israel" (21:1).
3. "But the king's word prevailed against Joab" (21:4).
4. "And God was displeased with this thing, and he struck Israel" (21:7).
5. "I have sinned greatly in that I have done this thing. But now, please take away the iniquity of your servant, for I have acted very foolishly" (21:8).
6. "Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is very great, but let me not fall into the hand of man" (21:13).
7. "But I will buy it for the full price. I will not take for the LORD what is yours, nor offer a burnt offering that costs me nothing" (21:24).

8 “Here shall be the house of the LORD God and here the altar of burnt offering for Israel” (22:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler selects. He tells us about David’s victories and his order of mighty men, but not about the affair with Bathsheba. He includes the census, a sin that brought a plague upon Israel and killed 70,000 people. Why this one? Because the story ends with David buying the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite, where he sees the angel of the LORD stand with a drawn sword. That place becomes the site of the temple. Out of the worst moment of David’s reign, God brings forth the place where sacrifices will be offered for the sin of the people.

It begins in a surprising way: “Satan stood against Israel and incited David.” The parallel in 2 Samuel 24 says the anger of the LORD incited David. The Chronicler preserves both: God allows the adversary to test, and God’s purposes are served. David’s sin is pride in numbers: he is relying on his army, not on God. When he recognizes his guilt, he confesses honestly. He does not blame Joab, who objected. And when given the choice of punishments, David says, “Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is very great.” Even in judgment, he trusts God’s character more than any human hand.

At the threshing floor, Ornan offers to give the land free. But David says, “I will not offer a burnt offering that costs me nothing.” Real worship costs. David pays full price. And the fire from heaven answers his offering.

Chapter 22 shows David preparing materials for the temple, though God says Solomon, a man of rest, will build it because David has shed much blood. David accepts it. He gathers gold, silver, iron, bronze, and timber “in great quantities” for the son who will build. This is a picture of a person who works for what he will not see finished.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 10:1-14 says the repeated sacrifices could not take away sin, but Christ offered himself once for all. 2 Samuel 24:24 is the parallel verse about costly offerings. Romans 12:1 says to present our bodies as a living sacrifice. 1 Peter 1:18-19 says we were ransomed with the precious blood of Christ. Matthew 6:21: where your treasure is, there your heart will be. Genesis 22:2 mentions Mount Moriah, linked to this site in 2 Chronicles 3:1.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any of your giving or service “costs you nothing.” What would it look like to give something that costs?

Remember David’s choice: when you fail, fall into the hands of the LORD, for his mercy is great.

Prepare for something you will not see completed, a ministry, a legacy, or a gift for the next generation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess sin to God honestly and ask him to take away your iniquity.
- Tell him you trust his mercy.
- Thank him for the altar and the sacrifice.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

“Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever.”

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 531 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32

The Levites organized; the courses of priests

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 105 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32. This is another survey reading. David organizes the Levites, priests, singers, and gatekeepers for the temple. Look for what the lists say about worship and service.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David, old and full of days, makes Solomon king and then organizes the worship of the future temple. He assigns the Levites to duties, divides the priests into twenty-four divisions, assigns singers by lot, and sets the gatekeepers and treasurers. These chapters may feel technical. The point is that worship in God's house is meant to be ordered, skilled, and shared.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When David was old and full of days, he made Solomon his son king over Israel" (23:1).
2. "For David said, The LORD, the God of Israel, has given rest to his people, and he dwells in Jerusalem forever" (23:25).
3. "And the Levites no longer need to carry the tabernacle" (23:26).
4. "And they are to stand every morning, thanking and praising the LORD, and likewise at evening" (23:30).
5. "David and the chiefs of the service also set apart for the service some of the sons of Asaph, and of Heman, and of Jeduthun, who prophesied with lyres, with harps, and with cymbals" (25:1).

6. “They were all under the direction of their father in the music in the house of the LORD” (25:6).
7. “All these were trained and skillful, 288” (25:7).
8. “And they cast lots for their duties, small and great, teacher and pupil alike” (25:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Levites’ duties change. With the ark at rest in the temple, they no longer need to carry the tabernacle. Instead, they serve in the work of the house: assisting the priests, keeping the courts, cleaning, preparing the showbread, and standing every morning and evening to thank and praise the LORD. Praise was part of their daily work.

The singers receive special attention. Chapter 25 says they “prophesied with lyres, harps, and cymbals.” Music and prophecy are connected. They were trained and skillful, 288 of them, and the lots were cast fairly, “small and great, teacher and pupil alike.” Everyone had a place. Notice the family: “all under the direction of their father.” Their gifts were exercised in families.

In chapter 26, the gatekeepers and treasurers are listed. Those who guarded the doors and kept the treasuries were also Levites. Some were mighty men of valor. The care of the temple’s gifts was a holy trust. Even the doorkeepers had a calling: “I would rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God” (Psalm 84:10).

Why does the Chronicler give such attention to these matters? Because after the exile, the community needed to rebuild worship on the pattern that God had given. They were to base it not on their own creativity but on what David had commanded “by the word of the LORD.” At the same time, there is freedom: David reorganized the Levites for new circumstances. Order serves worship.

This section teaches that God cares about the practical details of worship and service: who sings, who guards, who keeps the books. Nothing in his house is too small.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Corinthians 14:40 says that all things should be done decently and in order. Romans 12:4-8 describes different gifts in the body. 1 Peter 4:10 says that each has received a gift to serve one another. Ephesians 4:11-12 says Christ gave gifts to equip the saints for the work of ministry. Psalm 84:10 values being a doorkeeper in God’s house. Matthew 25:21: “Well done, good and faithful servant.”

STEP 6

Application

Think of your gift. Ask how it can serve in your local church.

Thank someone who does a quiet or behind-the-scenes task in your community.

Bring order and care to a part of your worship life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gifts he has given you for his people.

Ask him to show you where to use them.

Ask him to keep you from envying others' gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 532 · WEEK 76

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Chronicles 17:27 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

REST

Meditation

This is the last line of David's prayer after God made the covenant with him. It is a prayer of someone who has just been handed an astonishing promise and is still catching his breath.

"Now you have been pleased to bless." David begins with God's pleasure. God was not forced to bless. He chose to, and he took pleasure in it. The blessing flowed from his good will. It was not earned.

"The house of your servant." David calls himself a servant, though he is the king. His house is not a palace of his own making but a household that God has chosen to bless. Notice that God's promise reached beyond David to his descendants. We are blessed, and so are our children after us.

“That it may continue forever before you.” David asks for the promise to endure. He knows that it will outlast him. The Chronicler wrote these words when there was no king in David’s line on the throne, and so this prayer was an act of hope. The promise had not failed. It was waiting for its fulfillment.

“For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever.” This is the final confidence. The promise rests on the God who made it. David is not bragging about his future. He is resting in God’s word. If God has said it, it will happen.

As a Christian, you can pray this verse with joy. The promise to David is fulfilled in Jesus, and through him we too are blessed forever. When you are tempted to doubt that God will finish what he started, say this verse.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the heart of David’s story according to the Chronicler. You saw how the Chronicler passes quickly over Saul’s death and gathers all Israel to David. You watched the first attempt to move the ark fail with Uzzah, and the second attempt succeed with joyful music. You read David’s psalm of thanksgiving and God’s great covenant promise: “I will establish his throne forever.” You also saw David’s sin in the census and his choice to fall into the hand of the LORD, whose mercy is great, and his refusal to offer a sacrifice that cost him nothing. Then you read about the careful ordering of the Levites, singers, and gatekeepers. In Psalm 96 and the opening of Psalm 105, you sang the songs David gave to Asaph.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David refused to offer a sacrifice that cost him nothing. What is a cost you are willing to bear for the sake of worship or service?

The promise to David finds its fulfillment in Jesus, the Son of David whose kingdom has no end. How does that give you confidence in God’s promises?

David prepared for a temple that Solomon would build. What are you preparing for the next generation that you may never see completed?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being pleased to bless his servant.

Thank him for the promise fulfilled in Christ.

Rest in his faithfulness.

DAY 533 · WEEK 77

1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30

Military and civil officers; David's final assembly

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30. David organizes the kingdom, charges Solomon and the people, and gives toward the temple from his own treasure. Then he prays one of the great prayers of the Bible. Read 29:10-20 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the end of 1 Chronicles. David is old, and the transition to Solomon is a formal public event. After listing the officers of the kingdom, the Chronicler records David's final address to the assembly. He gives the plans for the temple to Solomon, urges the leaders to give, and then leads the people in blessing God. Solomon is made king a second time, and David dies "in a good old age, full of days, riches, and honor."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now therefore in the sight of all Israel, the assembly of the LORD, and in the hearing of our God, observe and seek out all the commandments of the LORD your God" (28:8).
2. "And you, Solomon my son, know the God of your father and serve him with a whole heart and with a willing mind" (28:9).
3. "If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will cast you off forever" (28:9).
4. "Be strong and courageous and do it. Do not be afraid and do not be dismayed, for the LORD God, even my God, is with you" (28:20).
5. "Who then is willing to offer willingly, consecrating himself today to the LORD?" (29:5).

6. “Then the people rejoiced because they had given willingly, for with a whole heart they had offered freely to the LORD” (29:9).
7. “Yours, O LORD, is the greatness and the power and the glory and the victory and the majesty” (29:11).
8. “For all things come from you, and of your own have we given you” (29:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s charge to Solomon is among the finest pieces of fatherly advice in Scripture. “Know the God of your father and serve him with a whole heart and with a willing mind.” Knowledge comes first, then service. The heart must be whole, undivided, and the mind willing. Then the sober promise: “If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will cast you off forever.” This is the Chronicler’s whole theology in one verse. Seek and find; forsake and lose.

David then gives the plans for the temple, which he received “by the Spirit,” and a mass of gold and silver from his own treasure. He challenges the leaders: “Who then is willing to offer willingly?” They respond, and the giving is joyful. The key note is voluntary generosity. “The people rejoiced because they had given willingly.” Giving is meant to be a joy.

Then comes David’s prayer. It begins with praise: “Yours, O LORD, is the greatness and the power and the glory and the victory and the majesty, for all that is in the heavens and in the earth is yours.” It is the source of the line often used in the doxology of the Lord’s Prayer. Then comes the great humility: “Who am I, and what is my people, that we should be able to give thus willingly? For all things come from you, and of your own have we given you.” Nothing we give is ours. We hand back what was lent.

He also prays for the people’s hearts: “Keep this forever in the intentions of the thoughts of the heart of your people, and direct their hearts toward you.” David knows that the heart is the key and that only God can keep it.

The book ends with David’s death and the note that his acts are “written in the chronicles.” The great king is gone, but the work continues.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 6:13 (in some manuscripts) ends the Lord’s Prayer with “For yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever.” 2 Corinthians 9:7: “God loves a cheerful giver.” 1 Corinthians 4:7: “What do you have that you did not receive?” Acts 20:35: “It is more blessed

to give than to receive." 2 Timothy 1:5 mentions faith passed down. Proverbs 4:23: guard your heart.

STEP 6

Application

Pray David's prayer about giving: ask God to help you give willingly and joyfully.

Think about who you are charging to "know the God of your father." Pray for them by name.

Write a letter or blessing for a younger person about what you have learned of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that everything you have comes from him.
- Offer him something willingly and with joy.
- Ask him to keep your heart loyal to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 534 · WEEK 77

2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22

Solomon's wisdom; the Temple built

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22. Solomon asks for wisdom and begins to build the temple. Read the account of the building as a picture of heaven on earth, and watch for where the Chronicler says the temple was built.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

2 Chronicles begins with Solomon's reign. The Chronicler tells the story with an emphasis on the temple and on Solomon's early faithfulness, leaving out his later failures. Solomon goes to Gibeon to sacrifice, and God appears to him in a dream. Then the building begins on Mount Moriah, the site David purchased.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And Solomon the son of David established himself in his kingdom, and the LORD his God was with him and made him exceedingly great" (1:1).
2. "Give me now wisdom and knowledge to go out and come in before this people" (1:10).
3. "Wisdom and knowledge are granted to you. I will also give you riches, possessions, and honor" (1:12).
4. "Behold, I am about to build a house for the name of the LORD my God" (2:4).
5. "But who is able to build him a house, since heaven, even highest heaven, cannot contain him?" (2:6).
6. "Then Solomon began to build the house of the LORD in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah" (3:1).
7. "And he overlaid the house with gold" (3:7).

8 “And he made the veil of blue and purple and crimson fabrics and fine linen, and he caused cherubim to be embroidered on it” (3:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Solomon’s request for wisdom shows a humble heart. God offers anything, and Solomon asks not for riches or long life but for wisdom to govern God’s people. God grants it and adds the riches he did not ask for. There is a lesson: seek first what matters, and the rest is added.

The Chronicler lingers over the temple. He ties it to the past: it is built on Mount Moriah, “where the LORD had appeared to David his father,” the same site where Abraham offered Isaac in Genesis 22. The significance is that this place, associated with sacrifice and provision, is where God’s presence will dwell.

Solomon’s message to Hiram of Tyre contains a profound statement: “Heaven, even highest heaven, cannot contain him.” The temple is not meant to hold God. It is a place for his name, where he promises to meet his people. Solomon knows the paradox: the infinite God condescends to dwell among humans.

The building is described in lavish detail. Gold overlays the walls. Two great cherubim stand in the Most Holy Place. Two bronze pillars stand at the entrance, named Jachin and Boaz. The bronze altar, the molten sea, the lampstands, and the tables are all made by skilled workmen. The craftsmanship and beauty were part of the worship. God is worthy of the best.

To the returned exiles, the description of the first temple meant something. They had built a smaller one, and the old men wept. But the Chronicler tells them about Solomon’s temple to say, “This is the pattern. This is who God is. His presence once dwelled here, and he will come again.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 2:19-21 says Jesus spoke of the temple of his body. 1 Corinthians 3:16 says “you are God’s temple and God’s Spirit dwells in you.” Ephesians 2:21-22 says the church is a holy temple in the Lord. James 1:5 promises wisdom to those who ask. Colossians 2:3: in Christ are hidden all the treasures of wisdom. Acts 7:48: the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands. Revelation 21:22: no temple, for the Lord is its temple.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Solomon’s prayer for wisdom for a specific decision you face.

Remember that you are now a temple of the Spirit. Think about how you care for your body and your thoughts.

Offer your best skills to God, whatever they are.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for wisdom to lead those he has given you.
- Marvel that heaven cannot contain him and yet he hears you.
- Ask him to teach you to honor him in your work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 535 · WEEK 77

2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22

The Temple dedicated; the glory fills the house

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22. The ark is brought into the temple, the glory cloud fills the house, Solomon prays, and fire falls from heaven. Then God answers with a promise and a warning. Pay special attention to 7:14.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The temple is complete, and the ark is brought in. The Levite singers stand with cymbals, harps, and lyres, along with 120 priests blowing trumpets. At the moment they begin to praise, God's glory fills the house. Solomon then dedicates the temple with a long prayer. God appears again and gives a conditional promise to Israel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It was the duty of the trumpeters and singers to make themselves heard in unison in praise and thanksgiving to the LORD" (5:13).
2. "For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever" (5:13).
3. "The house, the house of the LORD, was filled with a cloud" (5:13).
4. "The glory of the LORD filled the house of God" (5:14).
5. "But will God indeed dwell with man on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house that I have built!" (6:18).
6. "And listen to the pleas of your servant and of your people Israel, when they pray toward this place" (6:21).
7. "When the people of Israel… fire came down from heaven and consumed the burnt offering and the sacrifices" (7:1).

8 “If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land” (7:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The dedication scene is built on musical praise and visible glory. At the moment the singers sound as “one voice” praising the LORD with the refrain, “For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever,” the cloud fills the house. The priests could not stand to minister because of the glory. This repeats the experience at the tabernacle in Exodus 40. God accepts the house.

Solomon’s prayer is among the longest in the Bible. He begins with praise, recalls the promise to David, and then asks the central question: “Will God indeed dwell with man on the earth?” He knows the paradox. Then comes a series of petitions: when someone wrongs a neighbor, when the nation is defeated, when there is drought, famine, or plague, when a foreigner comes to pray, when the people go to war, and when they sin and are exiled. For each, Solomon asks: “Hear from heaven.” The temple is a place of prayer for every need. And for the exile, he prays: “If they repent… and pray toward this land, which you gave to their fathers, then hear from heaven.”

That petition is directly answered in chapter 7. Fire falls from heaven, and the people bow and worship. Then, at night, God appears to Solomon and gives the promise that returned exiles needed most: “If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land.” This verse is often quoted out of context, as though about a modern nation. In its original context, it was spoken to Israel about the temple and the land, and it gives the pattern for restoration: humility, prayer, seeking, and repentance. God’s promise is certain. But a warning follows: if they turn away and serve other gods, the temple itself will become a byword.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 9:11-12 says Christ entered once for all into the holy places, by means of his own blood. Matthew 18:20: “Where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them.” Acts 2:1-4 describes the Spirit filling the believers like fire. 1 John 1:9: if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive. James 4:6-10 says to humble yourselves before the Lord. Luke 11:2: “Hallowed be your name.”

STEP 6

Application

Practice the four steps of 7:14: humble yourself, pray, seek his face, and turn from sin.

Pray Solomon's "Hear from heaven" for specific needs of your church and community.

Ask God to fill your gatherings with his presence, not just your plans.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks that his steadfast love endures forever.
- Ask him to fill his house, your church, with his glory.
- Ask him to hear from heaven when you pray.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 536 · WEEK 77

Psalm 132

Remember, O LORD, in David's favor

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 132. This psalm recalls David's oath to find a dwelling place for the LORD and the LORD's oath to establish David's line. It echoes 2 Chronicles 6 and 7. Read the two oaths side by side.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 132 is a Song of Ascents, sung by pilgrims on the way up to Jerusalem. It recalls the bringing of the ark to Zion. Verses 8 to 10 are quoted in Solomon's prayer in 2 Chronicles 6:41-42, so it is easy to connect with this week's reading. It celebrates two oaths: David's oath to God, and God's oath to David.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Remember, O LORD, in David's favor, all the hardships he endured" (v. 1).
2. "How he swore to the LORD and vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob" (v. 2).
3. "I will not enter my house or get into my bed, I will not give sleep to my eyes... until I find a place for the LORD" (vv. 3-5).
4. "Let us go to his dwelling place; let us worship at his footstool!" (v. 7).
5. "Arise, O LORD, and go to your resting place, you and the ark of your might" (v. 8).
6. "The LORD swore to David a sure oath from which he will not turn back" (v. 11).
7. "One of the sons of your body I will set on your throne" (v. 11).
8. "This is my resting place forever; here I will dwell, for I have desired it" (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with David's passion. He could not rest until God had a place. The word "find" suggests a long search; the ark had been scattered for years. This longing for God's presence is the engine of the psalm. For David, a house for himself was nothing if the ark of God remained in a tent.

The pilgrims then go to the place: "Let us go to his dwelling place." They sing, "Arise, O LORD, to your resting place." This was probably sung at the entrance of the ark into the temple. They ask for the priests to be clothed with righteousness and the saints to shout for joy.

Then the psalm turns to God's oath, which is the center. "The LORD swore to David a sure oath from which he will not turn back." God's promise is not a negotiation. It is sworn, which means it does not depend on the performance of David's descendants. Yet it comes with a condition for them: if your sons keep my covenant, their sons will also sit on the throne. The Davidic promise is both unconditional in its ultimate fulfillment and conditional in its enjoyment by each generation. This is exactly the tension the Chronicler resolves: the line may fail, but the promise will not.

Then God speaks about Zion: "This is my resting place forever; here I will dwell, for I have desired it." God desires to dwell with his people. And he promises food for the poor, salvation for the priests, and joy for the saints. The final image is stunning: "There I will make a horn to sprout for David; I have prepared a lamp for my anointed." The horn is a symbol of strength, the lamp of continuing life. The line looks dark, but the lamp is lit. The Chronicler's readers would see it as a promise: a king will come.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:69 says God has raised up a horn of salvation in the house of David. John 8:12: "I am the light of the world." Acts 2:30 says David knew God had sworn an oath to set one of his descendants on his throne. Revelation 21:3: the dwelling place of God is with man. Matthew 11:28: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of a Sabbath rest for the people of God.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you long for God's presence as David did. What are you willing to give up for it?

Sing or pray verses 8 to 9 as part of your worship, as the pilgrims did.

Thank God for the "sure oath" of the gospel, which does not depend on your performance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to remember his covenant.
- Ask him to clothe his priests with righteousness.
- Thank him for making his home among his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 537 · WEEK 77

Psalm 135

Praise the name of the LORD in his house

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 135. You read this psalm on Day 488 beside Daniel's idols. Read it now as a hymn of the returned community, who sang it in the rebuilt temple, calling the servants of the LORD to praise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 135 is made largely of quotations from other parts of Scripture: Exodus, Deuteronomy, and the Psalms. It was a worship song for the second temple, calling the priests and Levites "who stand in the house of the LORD" to praise. It celebrates God's greatness in creation and in history, and it ridicules idols. On Day 488 you read it beside the idols of Babylon. Today, notice how it pulls together the Chronicler's themes: the temple, the Levites, God's choice, and God's mighty acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise the name of the LORD, give praise, O servants of the LORD, who stand in the house of the LORD" (vv. 1-2).
2. "For the LORD has chosen Jacob for himself, Israel as his own possession" (v. 4).
3. "For I know that the LORD is great, and that our Lord is above all gods" (v. 5).
4. "Whatever the LORD pleases, he does, in heaven and on earth" (v. 6).
5. "He it was who struck down the firstborn of Egypt" (v. 8).
6. "Your name, O LORD, endures forever, your renown, O LORD, throughout all ages" (v. 13).
7. "Those who make them become like them, so do all who trust in them" (v. 18).

8 “O house of Israel, bless the LORD! O house of Aaron, bless the LORD! O house of Levi, bless the LORD!” (vv. 19-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a collage of Scripture, and that is its point. The worshipers of the second temple did not invent new words. They drew on the Torah and the earlier Psalms, weaving them into a new song. This is how worship grows: from the word of God into the heart of the people.

The first section calls the servants of the LORD to praise. The reason is that the LORD has chosen Jacob. The word “possession” is a treasure, a special possession. Israel is not great, but God chose them, and this is the ground of their joy.

The psalm then looks at God’s power in creation and at his deeds in Egypt. “Whatever the LORD pleases, he does.” He sends lightning with the rain, brings the wind from his storehouses, and strikes down the firstborn of Egypt. He gave Israel the land as a heritage. These are not abstractions but stories, and they are told in order to say: our God acts.

At the center is the contrast with the idols, as in Psalm 115. The language is almost the same, which tells us how deep it ran in the memory of the community. Idols are silver and gold. They have mouths, eyes, ears, but no breath. “Those who make them become like them.” The community that remembered Babylon’s idols had a vivid sense of how empty they were.

The psalm ends by calling the whole community by name: house of Israel, house of Aaron, house of Levi, and “you who fear the LORD.” Each group is told to bless the LORD. It ends where it began: “Blessed be the LORD from Zion, he who dwells in Jerusalem! Praise the LORD!” The point is that the people who worship the living God are alive to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19:5-6 says Israel is God’s treasured possession. 1 Peter 2:9 applies it to the church: “a people for his own possession.” Ephesians 1:4 says he chose us in him before the foundation of the world. Isaiah 44:9-20 mocks idols. Revelation 4:11 says all things were created by his will. Psalm 115:3-8 parallels verses 15 to 18. Colossians 3:16: let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, singing.

STEP 6

Application

Compose a short prayer of praise using only words from Scripture, as the psalmist did.

Thank God that he chose you, not because of anything in you, but out of love.

Notice what in your life might be shaping you into its image. Are you becoming like what you worship?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for choosing you as his own possession.
- Thank him that he is above all gods.
- Ask him to keep you from idols.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 538 · WEEK 77

Psalm 136

His steadfast love endures forever

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 136. You read this on Day 489 as a liturgy of God's love beside Daniel's trials. Read it now aloud with a partner if you can, one reading the first line of each verse and the other answering with the refrain. It was probably sung at the temple's dedication.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 136 is the refrain psalm: twenty-six verses, each ending "for his steadfast love endures forever." It is the refrain sung in 2 Chronicles 5:13, 7:3, and 7:6 at the dedication of the temple, and in Ezra 3:11 when the second temple's foundation was laid. This week, you have met the refrain at nearly every turn. Today you read the whole song. On Day 489 you read it against exile. Now read it as the temple's song.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever" (v. 1).
2. "To him who alone does great wonders, for his steadfast love endures forever" (v. 4).
3. "To him who by understanding made the heavens" (v. 5).
4. "To him who spread out the earth above the waters" (v. 6).
5. "To him who struck down the firstborn of Egypt" (v. 10).
6. "And brought Israel out from among them" (v. 11).
7. "It is he who remembered us in our low estate" (v. 23).
8. "He who gives food to all flesh" (v. 25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a story told in a chorus. The first lines call for thanks to the God of gods and Lord of lords. Then it narrates creation: heavens, earth, sun, moon, and stars. Then it moves to the exodus: striking the firstborn of Egypt, dividing the Red Sea, leading the people through the wilderness. Then the conquest: striking down great kings and giving their land as a heritage. Then the final line: "It is he who remembered us in our low estate." The psalm covers creation, redemption, and conquest in a pattern of repeated assurance.

The most important feature is the repetition. "His steadfast love endures forever" appears twenty-six times. A modern reader might wonder why. But the people were not reading silently. They were singing, and one group sang the line while another answered. The refrain became a habit of the heart. Hearing it again and again taught them something that could not be taught in one sentence: God's love does not wear out.

Notice the surprising items in the list of God's deeds. The striking of Egypt's firstborn is in the same breath as creation. For Israel, God's love included his judgment on those who oppressed them. His love is not sentimental. It rescues, and rescue sometimes means defeating the enemy.

Verse 23 is for the exiles: "He remembered us in our low estate." They knew what "low estate" meant. They had been in Babylon and then returned to a small, ruined city. And God remembered. "And rescued us from our foes." The last verse reaches out to all creation: "He who gives food to all flesh." His love covers the whole world.

For the dedication of the temple, no better song could have been chosen. Every item in the list pointed back to the one truth that had held them through everything.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:35-39 asks what can separate us from the love of Christ. 1 John 4:10: "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son." Lamentations 3:22-23 says the steadfast love of the LORD never ceases. Ephesians 3:17-19 prays that we may know the love of Christ. John 3:16 gives the greatest expression of that love. Psalm 103:11: as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his steadfast love.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud with someone, and let the refrain sink in.

Write your own “Psalm 136”: a list of ten things God has done for you, each ending with “for his steadfast love endures forever.”

When you struggle with doubt, repeat the refrain.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for his steadfast love, line by line, in your own words.

Thank him for his great wonders.

Thank him for what he has done in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

“If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land.”

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 539 · WEEK 77

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Chronicles 7:14 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

REST

Meditation

This is one of the most quoted verses in the Old Testament, and it is easy to misuse. So begin with its setting. God is speaking to Solomon, at night, after the temple is dedicated. He is speaking about Israel, the land, and the temple. In its original context, the "land" is the land of Israel. We should not simply apply it to any modern nation, but we can learn the pattern, which is repeated across Scripture.

"If my people who are called by my name." The promise is for a particular people: those who bear God's name. The church is also called by his name. God's concern is first with his own people.

"Humble themselves." This is the first step. The problem is not mainly outside; it begins with pride. Humility is the beginning of any restoration.

“And pray and seek my face.” Prayer is asking. To seek his face is to want God himself, not just his gifts. It is looking for his presence and his favor.

“And turn from their wicked ways.” Repentance is not only sorrow but change. There is a turning around.

“Then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land.” God’s response is threefold: he hears, he forgives, and he heals. Every verb is his gift. We do not heal the land; he does. Our part is to humble, pray, seek, and turn.

Remember that this passage was fulfilled in part under Hezekiah and Josiah. It points toward the greater turning that Christ makes possible. Pray this verse for your church first, then for your community. Begin with yourself.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of David’s reign and the beginning of Solomon’s according to the Chronicler. You heard David’s charge to Solomon, “Know the God of your father and serve him with a whole heart,” and his great prayer, “All things come from you, and of your own have we given you.” You watched Solomon ask for wisdom, build the temple on Mount Moriah, and dedicate it as God’s glory filled the house. You heard God’s answer to Solomon’s prayer in 7:14. In Psalm 132, you read the two oaths, David’s to God and God’s to David. In Psalms 135 and 136, you sang the songs of the second temple: the God who chose Israel, who is above all idols, and whose steadfast love endures forever.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David said, “All things come from you, and of your own have we given you.” How does that change the way you think about your money, time, and talents?

2 Chronicles 7:14 gives four responses: humble, pray, seek, turn. Which is hardest for you right now?

Solomon’s temple is fulfilled in Jesus and in his people. How does it change your daily life to know that God’s Spirit dwells in you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Humble yourself before God and ask him to hear from heaven.

Ask him to forgive sin and heal what is broken.

Thank him for Christ, the true temple.

DAY 540 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16

Solomon's reign; the kingdom divides; Rehoboam

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16. Solomon's reign ends, the kingdom divides, and Rehoboam, humbled by Shishak's invasion, repents for a moment. Read for the Chronicler's pattern: seek the LORD and prosper; forsake him and suffer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler gives Solomon's reign a glowing finish, with the visit of the queen of Sheba, and omits his sin with foreign wives. He wants his readers to remember the golden age. Then the story turns on Rehoboam, who rejects wise counsel, and the northern tribes break away. From this point, the Chronicler largely follows the kings of Judah, the line of David, and ignores the northern kingdom except where it touches Judah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the queen of Sheba said, The report was true that I heard in my own land of your words and of your wisdom" (9:5).
2. "Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you and set you on his throne" (9:8).
3. "But he abandoned the counsel that the old men gave him" (10:8).
4. "So Israel has been in rebellion against the house of David to this day" (10:19).
5. "The priests and Levites who were in all Israel presented themselves to him from all places" (11:13).
6. "And those who set their hearts to seek the LORD God of Israel came after them from all the tribes of Israel" (11:16).

7. “When Rehoboam had established his kingdom and was strong, he abandoned the law of the LORD, and all Israel with him” (12:1).

8. “And when he humbled himself the wrath of the LORD turned from him, so as not to make a complete destruction” (12:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler gives the pattern that will recur in every reign. The king and the people either seek the LORD or abandon him, and the results follow. Solomon’s wisdom draws the queen of Sheba from afar. She marvels, and she blesses the LORD. The glory of Solomon’s reign points beyond itself.

Rehoboam shows the reverse. He asks for advice from the elders, who counsel gentleness, and from his young friends, who counsel harshness. He chooses the young men’s counsel and answers the people roughly. The kingdom splits. Notice that the Chronicler says it was “a turn of affairs brought about by God,” to fulfill his word. Even human folly is under God’s rule.

The Levites and priests leave the north, and many from all the tribes who “set their hearts to seek the LORD” come to Jerusalem. This is a key idea: the true Israel was where God’s worship was. Jeroboam had appointed his own priests for the high places and golden calves. The faithful choose to follow God and leave their land and property behind.

When Rehoboam is established and strong, he forsakes the law, and Egypt’s Shishak comes up against Jerusalem. A prophet explains: “You abandoned me, so I have abandoned you.” The leaders humble themselves, saying, “The LORD is righteous.” God relents in part. Judah will serve Shishak “that they may know the difference between serving me and serving the kings of the countries.” The chapter ends with a verdict: Rehoboam “did evil, for he did not set his heart to seek the LORD.”

Contrast this with Ezra, who “set his heart to study the law.” The heart is the central matter.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 12:42 says the queen of the South will rise at the judgment, “for she came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon, and behold, something greater than Solomon is here.” Proverbs 11:14: in an abundance of counselors there is safety. James 4:6: God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble. Hebrews 11:25 notes Moses choosing to share ill-treatment with God’s people. 1 Kings 12 records the split.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to take the advice that is easy instead of the advice that is wise. Seek counsel from someone older and wiser.

Notice the “set your heart to seek the LORD” language and ask whether your heart is set.

When you fail, remember Rehoboam’s brief humbling and God’s mercy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to set your heart to seek him.
- Ask him to give you humility to listen to wise counsel.
- Ask him to help you return when you fail.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

“For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him.”

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 541 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14

Abijah, Asa, Chronicles' portrait of reform

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14. Abijah speaks to Jeroboam, Asa seeks the LORD and has peace, and then Asa relies on Syria and on physicians and not the LORD. Watch how his story changes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abijah, king of Judah, faces Jeroboam's much larger army. Then his son Asa begins a long reign with a great reform and thirty-five years of peace. But in his later years, he trusts in a human alliance instead of God, rejects the prophet, and dies after seeking help from physicians only. The Chronicler makes him an example of a good start and a poor finish.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is with us at our head, and his priests with their battle trumpets to sound the call to battle against you" (13:12).
2. "And the men of Judah cried out. And when the men of Judah shouted, God defeated Jeroboam" (13:15).
3. "Thus the men of Israel were subdued at that time, and the men of Judah prevailed, because they relied on the LORD" (13:18).
4. "And Asa did what was good and right in the eyes of the LORD his God" (14:2).
5. "LORD, there is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak. Help us, O LORD our God, for we rely on you" (14:11).
6. "The LORD is with you while you are with him. If you seek him, he will be found by you" (15:2).

7. “For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him” (16:9).

8. “Yet even in his disease he did not seek the LORD, but sought help from the physicians” (16:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler tells the stories as case studies in dependence. Abijah is outnumbered two to one and ambushed. But he stands on a hill and speaks to Jeroboam, reminding him of God’s covenant with David and of Jeroboam’s golden calves. When the battle is joined, Judah cries out to the LORD, the priests blow trumpets, and God routs the enemy. “They relied on the LORD.” The word means to lean.

Asa’s first years are the model. He removes the foreign altars and high places, commands Judah to seek the LORD, and gets peace. When a million Ethiopians come against him, he prays one of the best prayers of the Bible: “LORD, there is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak.” God gives victory.

The prophet Azariah then gives the principle that summarizes the Chronicler’s theology: “The LORD is with you while you are with him. If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will forsake you.” Asa and the people enter a covenant to seek the LORD with all their heart and soul, and “he was found by them.” He even deposes his own grandmother for idolatry.

But in the thirty-sixth year, Baasha of Israel comes against him, and Asa takes the temple’s silver and gold to hire the king of Syria. It works, politically. Then the seer Hanani rebukes him: “Because you relied on the king of Syria, and did not rely on the LORD your God… the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless.” Asa’s response is to throw the prophet into prison and oppress some of the people.

The saddest note: when he is diseased in his feet, he “did not seek the LORD, but sought help from the physicians.” The point is not that doctors are wrong, but that he sought only them. He had lost the habit of dependence.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 3:5-6: “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding.” Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts those who trust in man with those who trust in the LORD. 2 Corinthians 12:9: “My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in

weakness." Philippians 3:13-14 speaks of pressing on. Hebrews 3:14 warns that we share in Christ if we hold our original confidence firm to the end. John 15:5: "Apart from me you can do nothing."

STEP 6

Application

Pray Asa's prayer: "There is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak."

Think about a place in your life where you rely on human solutions only. Bring God into it.

Pray for finishing well. Ask God to keep you dependent on him in the later seasons of life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that you rely on him, not on your own strength.
- Thank him that there is none like him to help the weak.
- Ask him to keep you from turning to others first.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 542 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37

Jehoshaphat, faithfulness and compromise

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37. Jehoshaphat sends teachers throughout Judah, makes an unwise alliance with Ahab, and then, when a vast army comes, leads the nation in prayer. Read 20:1-30 closely.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jehoshaphat is one of the Chronicler's favorite kings. He sends officials, Levites, and priests with the Book of the Law to teach in every city of Judah. He appoints judges. But he also allies himself with the wicked Ahab. When Moab, Ammon, and others come against him, he proclaims a fast and leads Judah in a great prayer. The result is one of the most remarkable victories in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And they taught in Judah, having the Book of the Law of the LORD with them" (17:9).
2. "Should you help the wicked and love those who hate the LORD?" (19:2).
3. "Consider what you do, for you judge not for man but for the LORD" (19:6).
4. "Then Jehoshaphat was afraid and set his face to seek the LORD, and proclaimed a fast throughout all Judah" (20:3).
5. "O our God, will you not execute judgment on them? For we are powerless against this great horde that is coming against us. We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you" (20:12).
6. "Do not be afraid and do not be dismayed at this great horde, for the battle is not yours but God's" (20:15).

7. “Believe in the LORD your God, and you will be established; believe his prophets, and you will succeed” (20:20).
8. “And when they began to sing and praise, the LORD set an ambush against the men of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir” (20:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jehoshaphat’s best moment is when he sends teachers. Notice the method: officials, Levites, and priests go through the cities “having the Book of the Law of the LORD with them.” Spiritual health comes through teaching God’s word. The result was that the fear of the LORD fell on neighboring kingdoms, and they did not make war against Judah.

His worst moment is his alliance with Ahab. The prophet Micaiah is the one true voice against four hundred false prophets, and Jehoshaphat sees the king of Israel struck and nearly dies himself. The prophet Jehu asks, “Should you help the wicked and love those who hate the LORD?” But he adds that there is some good in him. God’s grace works in people with mixed records.

Then the great crisis arrives. A vast army comes from beyond the Dead Sea. The king is afraid, and the fear drives him to God, not away from him. He gathers the whole nation, including “their little ones, their wives, and their children,” and prays. His prayer begins with who God is, “You rule over all the kingdoms of the nations,” recalls God’s promises about the temple, and then admits the truth: “We are powerless… We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you.” That sentence is one of the best prayers a person can pray.

God answers through a Levite named Jahaziel: “The battle is not yours but God’s.” The next morning, Jehoshaphat appoints singers to go before the army, praising “for his steadfast love endures forever.” When they began to sing, God set ambushes, and the enemy destroyed each other. Judah collected plunder for three days and gathered in the Valley of Beracah, “blessing.” The nation returned to Jerusalem with harps, lyres, and trumpets.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 6:12: we do not wrestle against flesh and blood. Romans 8:31: if God is for us, who can be against us? 2 Corinthians 4:8: “We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed… perplexed, but not driven to despair.” Acts 16:25-26 shows Paul and Silas singing in prison. 1 Samuel 17:47: “The battle is the LORD’s.” Isaiah 26:3: you keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you.

STEP 6

Application

Use Jehoshaphat's prayer the next time you face something beyond you: "I do not know what to do, but my eyes are on you."

Try praising God in the middle of a hard situation, before you see the answer.

Be careful with your closest alliances, and ask whether they pull you toward or away from God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you cannot manage, and say, "My eyes are on you."

Thank him that the battle is his.

Ask him to teach you to worship before you see the victory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 543 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27

Jehoram, Athaliah, Joash, the throne preserved

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27. Jehoram and Ahaziah lead Judah into evil, Athaliah usurps the throne, and young Joash is rescued and crowned. Joash starts well under the priest Jehoiada and then falls. Watch how the Chronicler explains the change.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jehoshaphat's alliance with Ahab leads to the marriage of his son Jehoram to Athaliah, Ahab's daughter. The consequence is tragic. Jehoram kills his brothers, Ahaziah is killed, and Athaliah slaughters the royal family except for one baby, Joash. The line of David hangs by a thread. This is the low point of Judah's early history.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And he walked in the way of the kings of Israel, as the house of Ahab had done, for the daughter of Ahab was his wife" (21:6).
2. "Yet the LORD was not willing to destroy the house of David, because of the covenant that he had made with David" (21:7).
3. "Jehosheba… took Joash the son of Ahaziah and stole him away from among the king's sons who were being put to death" (22:11).
4. "Behold, the king's son! Let him reign, as the LORD spoke concerning the sons of David" (23:3).
5. "And Joash did what was right in the eyes of the LORD all the days of Jehoiada the priest" (24:2).

6. “But after the death of Jehoiada the officials of Judah came and paid homage to the king” (24:17).
7. “The Spirit of God clothed Zechariah the son of Jehoiada the priest, and he stood above the people” (24:20).
8. “Thus Joash the king did not remember the kindness that Jehoiada, Zechariah’s father, had shown him, but killed his son” (24:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 21 shows how a bad alliance bears bitter fruit. Jehoram marries Ahab’s daughter and imports Baal worship. He murders his six brothers, and God sends an Edomite revolt and a Philistine and Arab raid. Elijah sends a letter of judgment. He dies in agony of the bowels, and “no one desired his departure.” It is a terrible epitaph.

Yet the Chronicler adds a note of mercy: “The LORD was not willing to destroy the house of David, because of the covenant.” God’s faithfulness to his promise is bigger than the faithlessness of the kings. And at the lowest moment, when Athaliah murders the heirs of David, God has a baby hidden. Jehosheba, the king’s daughter and wife of the priest Jehoiada, saves Joash and hides him in the temple for six years. The promise to David depended on a woman’s courage.

Jehoiada then stages the coup. He gathers the Levites and the commanders, brings out the boy king, and crowns him. The priest makes a covenant between God, the king, and the people. The people rejoice, and the city is quiet. Athaliah is put to death, and the Baal altar is torn down.

Joash starts well, repairing the temple with a collection from the people. But Jehoiada dies at 130, and everything changes. The officials come and persuade the king, and “they abandoned the house of the LORD… and served the Asherim and the idols.” Joash’s faith had been a borrowed faith, propped up by his mentor. When God sends prophets, the king responds by having Zechariah, the priest’s son, stoned in the temple court. “May the LORD see and avenge.”

The tragedy of Joash is that he never made the faith his own. The lesson is to build a faith that stands even when the people who first taught you are gone.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 1:5 praises the faith that dwelt in Timothy's grandmother and mother, and now in him. Matthew 23:35 refers to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the temple and the altar. Hebrews 3:12: "Take care, brothers, lest there be in any of you an evil, unbelieving heart." 2 Corinthians 6:14: do not be unequally yoked. Jude 24: "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling."

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your faith depends on a person or a community more than on your own walk with God. Take a step to own it.

Thank someone who played the role of Jehoiada in your life.

Be a Jehoiada to a young person: protect, teach, and pray.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his faithfulness when his people fail.

Thank him for preserving David's line.

Ask him to keep you from taking his patience for granted.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 544 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27

Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, mixed faithfulness

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27. Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, and Ahaz take the throne in turn. Look for the word “strong,” and for what happens when strength leads to pride.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These four kings cover about 100 years. Amaziah starts well and ends with idolatry. Uzziah is one of the most successful kings, but he oversteps in the temple and is struck with leprosy. Jotham is faithful. Ahaz is among the worst, closing the temple and sacrificing his own children. Isaiah’s early ministry takes place in this period, which you read in Unit 12.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, yet not with a whole heart” (25:2).
2. “The LORD is able to give you much more than this” (25:9).
3. “And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD… And as long as he sought the LORD, God made him prosper” (26:4-5).
4. “And his fame spread far, for he was marvelously helped, till he was strong” (26:15).
5. “But when he was strong, he grew proud, to his destruction” (26:16).
6. “So Jotham became mighty, because he ordered his ways before the LORD his God” (27:6).
7. “For the LORD humbled Judah because of Ahaz king of Israel, for he had made Judah act sinfully” (28:19).
8. “In the time of his distress he became yet more faithless to the LORD” (28:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Amaziah's description is chilling: he did what was right, "yet not with a whole heart." He listens to a prophet when it costs him money, dismissing 100,000 hired soldiers from Israel because "the LORD is able to give you much more than this." But after defeating Edom, he brings home their gods and worships them. When a prophet confronts him, he threatens the prophet. A partial faith ends in ruin.

Uzziah's story is the most important in this section. He reigned for 52 years and "as long as he sought the LORD, God made him prosper." He built towers, dug cisterns, organized a large army, and developed new weapons. His fame spread. "He was marvelously helped, till he was strong." And then the dangerous line: "But when he was strong, he grew proud, to his destruction." He went into the temple to burn incense, which was the priest's job. When eighty priests confronted him, he raged. And leprosy broke out on his forehead. He lived in isolation the rest of his life. The point is stark: success, apart from humility, destroys. This is the same Uzziah in whose death year Isaiah saw the LORD (Isaiah 6:1).

Jotham is a quiet counterexample. "He ordered his ways before the LORD his God." The word "ordered" means to establish firmly. No dramatic event, just steady faithfulness, and he "became mighty."

Ahaz is the opposite: he made metal images for Baals, burned his children, and shut the temple doors. When Assyria pressed him, he sent them the temple treasures. Verse 22 says, "In the time of his distress he became yet more faithless." Hardship should drive us to God. For Ahaz it drove him away.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 16:18: "Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall." James 4:6: God gives grace to the humble. Luke 18:14: "Everyone who exalts himself will be humbled." Isaiah 6:1-5 records the vision that came in the year Uzziah died. Hebrews 7:26-27 says Jesus is the high priest we need. Romans 12:3: do not think of yourself more highly than you ought.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any success in your life has made you less dependent on God.

Be like Jotham: order your ways before the LORD, steadily and quietly.

Notice where you are serving God "not with a whole heart," and ask him to unify your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for a whole heart.
- Ask him to keep you humble when you are strong.
- Ask him to drive you to him, not away, when you are distressed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 545 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33

Hezekiah's great reform, Temple worship restored

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33. Hezekiah reopens the temple, restores the Passover, and trusts God when Sennacherib invades. Read for the extraordinary Passover, where the whole kingdom seeks the LORD, and note 30:18-20.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Hezekiah is the Chronicler's greatest reformer. He begins in the first month of his first year, opening the doors of the temple. Unlike the account in Kings, which emphasizes Sennacherib's invasion, the Chronicler spends three chapters on the temple's cleansing and the great Passover. You read the Sennacherib story in Isaiah in Unit 12. Here it is brief, and in this book it is the reward of faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the first year of his reign, in the first month, he opened the doors of the house of the LORD and repaired them" (29:3).
2. "For our fathers have been unfaithful and have done what was evil in the sight of the LORD our God" (29:6).
3. "Be not like your fathers and your brothers, who were faithless to the LORD" (30:7).
4. "But some men of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humbled themselves and came to Jerusalem" (30:11).
5. "May the good LORD pardon everyone who sets his heart to seek God, the LORD, the God of his fathers, even though not according to the sanctuary's rules of cleanness" (30:18-19).

6. “And the LORD heard Hezekiah and healed the people” (30:20).
7. “So there was great joy in Jerusalem, for since the time of Solomon… there had been nothing like this” (30:26).
8. “Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid or dismayed… for there is one greater with us than with him” (32:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hezekiah acts at once. In the first month of his first year, he reopens the temple, and the priests spend sixteen days cleansing it. His words to the Levites: “Do not now be negligent, for the LORD has chosen you to stand in his presence.” Then the temple is rededicated with burnt offerings and with singing, “the song to the LORD began also, and the trumpets.” The people bring thank offerings, so many that the priests need help.

Then he does something unusual: he invites the northern tribes, now in ruin under Assyria, to come to Jerusalem to keep the Passover. Couriers go throughout Israel, from Beersheba to Dan. Some laugh at them. But others humble themselves and come. The result is a massive celebration, for two weeks, with joy that Jerusalem had not seen since Solomon.

One detail is gracious. Many who came had not purified themselves according to the rules. Hezekiah prays: “May the good LORD pardon everyone who sets his heart to seek God, even though not according to the sanctuary’s rules of cleanness.” And the LORD heard and healed the people. God cares about the heart above ritual precision, though he does not dismiss ritual.

When Sennacherib invades, the Chronicler tells it in a few verses. Hezekiah strengthens the walls, digs a tunnel to bring water into the city, and encourages the people: “With him is an arm of flesh, but with us is the LORD our God, to help us and to fight our battles.” He and Isaiah cry to heaven, and an angel destroys the Assyrian army. The chapter ends with a hint of pride in Hezekiah’s heart, which he repents of, and then notes his prosperity. “God left him to himself, in order to test him and to know all that was in his heart.” Even the best king is human.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 4:16: “Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace.” 1 Corinthians 5:7-8: Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed. Luke 15:20 shows the father welcoming the returning son. Joel 2:12-13 calls for returning with all your heart. 1 John 4:4: “He who is in you is greater than he who is in the world.” Romans 10:1-3 speaks of zeal for God, rightly understood.

STEP 6

Application

Do the first thing first: what is one area where God's "house" in your life needs to be cleaned out and opened?

Invite someone who is far from God to come with you to worship.

When you fear, remember: "There is one greater with us than with him."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to pardon everyone who sets their heart to seek him, including you.

Ask him to help you cleanse what is unclean in your life.

Thank him for healing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 546 · WEEK 78

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Chronicles 16:9 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken as a rebuke to King Asa, but it is full of encouragement. It was meant to say, "You could have had so much more help if you had trusted me." For us, it is an invitation.

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro." The image is of God's active attention. His eyes are not still. They run, like a scout surveying the land. The LORD is looking, searching, always watching. Nothing is hidden from him. For those who want to hide, this is a threat. For those who are seeking him, it is a comfort.

"Throughout the whole earth." His watch covers the entire world, not just Israel. No place is outside his sight. No believer is forgotten, however remote.

“To give strong support.” This is what he is looking for: someone to help. The word means to strengthen or make firm. He is not scanning in order to catch people out but to find those he can support. God is looking for people to help.

“To those whose heart is blameless toward him.” The condition is a heart that is whole, undivided, and loyal. “Blameless” does not mean sinless. Asa was no angel, and neither was David. It means a heart that is fully turned toward him, that does not divide its trust. God looks for those whose reliance is wholly on him.

When you feel alone, small, or unnoticed, remember that God’s eyes are running through the whole earth with a purpose: to help you. Give him a heart that is completely his.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the kings of Judah through the Chronicler’s eyes. You saw Solomon’s glory fade into Rehoboam’s folly, and the kingdom divide. You watched Asa cry out to the LORD against a million Ethiopians and then rely on Syria and doctors in his old age. You saw Jehoshaphat teach the law, make an unwise alliance, and then lead the nation in prayer: “We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you.” You followed the tragedy of Athaliah and the rescue of baby Joash, then Joash’s fall after Jehoiada’s death. You read of Uzziah’s pride and Jotham’s steady faithfulness, and Hezekiah’s reform and Passover. The Chronicler’s lesson is clear: seek the LORD and you will find him; forsake him and he will forsake you.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Chronicler repeats the word “seek” again and again. What does seeking the LORD look like in your daily rhythm?

Asa began well and ended poorly. What practices might help you to finish well?

Hezekiah prayed, “May the good LORD pardon everyone who sets his heart to seek God.” How does the gospel assure us of that pardon?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for a heart that is wholly his.

Thank him that his eyes run to and fro to strengthen the blameless.

Rest in him.

DAY 547 · WEEK 79

2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23

Manasseh's repentance; Josiah; exile; Cyrus's decree

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23. Manasseh sins, repents, and is restored. Josiah finds the Book of the Law. Then the kings fall one by one, and the temple is burned. The book ends with a decree of Cyrus. Read the final verses twice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last four chapters of Chronicles trace the fall of Judah. Manasseh is the worst king, and the Chronicler tells a story found nowhere else: his repentance in Babylon. Josiah's reform is the last great revival. Then come four weak kings, the siege, and the exile. The book closes not with defeat but with an invitation: "Let him go up." It ends where Ezra begins.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Manasseh led Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem astray, to do more evil than the nations" (33:9).
2. "And when he was in distress, he entreated the favor of the LORD his God and humbled himself greatly before the God of his fathers" (33:12).
3. "Then Manasseh knew that the LORD was God" (33:13).
4. "And Josiah… while he was still a boy, began to seek the God of David his father" (34:3).
5. "Hilkiah the priest found the Book of the Law of the LORD given through Moses" (34:14).
6. "Because your heart was tender and you humbled yourself before God" (34:27).
7. "But they kept mocking the messengers of God, despising his words and scoffing at his prophets, until the wrath of the LORD rose against his people, until there was no remedy" (36:16).

8 “Whoever is among you of all his people, may the LORD his God be with him. Let him go up” (36:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Manasseh reigned for 55 years, the longest of any king. He rebuilt high places, set up altars to Baal in the temple, practiced sorcery, and sacrificed his sons. He led the people to do “more evil than the nations.” The Chronicler tells what Kings did not: when the Assyrians took Manasseh in hooks and bronze fetters to Babylon, “he entreated the favor of the LORD his God and humbled himself greatly.” And God “was moved by his entreaty and heard his plea and brought him again to Jerusalem.” “Then Manasseh knew that the LORD was God.” This is one of the great stories of grace in the Old Testament. If Manasseh could be forgiven, anyone can.

Josiah was eight when he began to reign, and at sixteen he began to seek God. At twenty he began purging the land of idols. At twenty-six, while repairing the temple, they found the Book of the Law. When it was read, he tore his clothes. The prophetess Huldah said disaster was coming, but because he humbled himself, he would be gathered in peace. His Passover was the greatest since Samuel. Then, strangely, he is killed at Megiddo after ignoring a warning from Pharaoh Neco, “from the mouth of God.”

After Josiah, four kings fall quickly: Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, and Zedekiah. The key verses are 36:15-16: God sent messengers again and again, “because he had compassion on his people.” But they mocked and despised. “Until there was no remedy.” Babylon burns the temple, breaks down the wall, and carries off the people. The land enjoys its Sabbaths for seventy years, as Jeremiah said.

The book ends with a decree from Cyrus, the same words that open Ezra. It is an open ending. The Hebrew Bible places Chronicles last, so it ends with a call: “Let him go up.” The story invites its readers to return. That is how the Old Testament closes.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 15:11-24 tells the story of the prodigal son who comes to himself and returns. 1 Timothy 1:15-16: Paul, the foremost of sinners, received mercy as an example. 2 Peter 3:9: “The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise… but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish.” Romans 5:20: “Where sin increased, grace abounded all the more.” Matthew 11:28 invites the weary to come. John 14:2-3: “I go to prepare a place for you.”

STEP 6

Application

Remember Manasseh when you feel too sinful to be forgiven, or when someone you love seems beyond reach.

Pray for someone you have given up on, that God would humble them and bring them home.

Read the last verse of Chronicles aloud: “Let him go up.” Hear it as an invitation to come home to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that no one is beyond his mercy.
- Ask him to give you a heart that returns to him quickly.
- Pray for someone far from him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 548 · WEEK 79

Joel 1:1-2:32

The locust plague; the Spirit poured out, Pentecost foretold

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joel 1:1-2:32. A plague of locusts becomes a picture of the coming day of the LORD. Joel calls for repentance, and the LORD promises restoration and the outpouring of his Spirit. Read 2:12-14 and 2:28-32 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joel's date is uncertain. Many place him in the post-exilic period, which fits the focus on the temple, priests, and elders and the lack of a king. He writes after a devastating plague of locusts and a drought. He uses it as a warning and a sign: if a locust swarm is this terrible, think of the day of the LORD. The book is short and its main message is sharp: return to the LORD, and he will restore.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What the cutting locust left, the swarming locust has eaten" (1:4).
2. "Wake up, you drunkards, and weep" (1:5).
3. "Put on sackcloth and lament, you priests" (1:13).
4. "Alas for the day! For the day of the LORD is near" (1:15).
5. "Yet even now, declares the LORD, return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning" (2:12).
6. "And rend your hearts and not your garments" (2:13).
7. "For he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love" (2:13).
8. "I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten" (2:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with an ugly scene. Locusts have stripped the land. Grain, wine, and oil are cut off. The priests cannot offer sacrifices because there is nothing to offer. Even the animals groan. Joel tells the people to look at this and to pass it on to their children. It is a living picture of God's judgment.

Then Joel sees something more. The locusts are a shadow of a greater army, the day of the LORD. "Blow a trumpet in Zion." Chapter 2 describes an unstoppable army before which the earth quakes and the sun and moon grow dark. "The day of the LORD is great and very awesome; who can endure it?"

And then comes one of the sweetest turns in the Old Testament: "Yet even now." Even now, with all of this, the door is open. "Return to me with all your heart." The word for "return" is the main word for repentance. And the repentance is not external: "Rend your hearts and not your garments." Tearing clothes was the visible sign of grief. God asks for the inside to be torn.

The reason to return is God himself. "He is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love." This is the same description you met in Nehemiah 9 and Psalm 145. "And he relents over disaster." The fast, assembly, and prayers that follow are marked by hope: "Who knows whether he will not turn and relent?"

God answers. He is jealous for his land and pities his people. He promises grain, wine, and oil, and then: "I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten." The lost years are not just forgotten; they are repaid. And the great promise follows: "I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh." Sons, daughters, old men, young men, even servants. This is the most important promise of the book, and it is fulfilled at Pentecost.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 2:16-21: Peter quotes Joel 2:28-32 on the day of Pentecost. Romans 10:13: "Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved." Luke 15:20: the father runs to the returning son. 2 Corinthians 7:10: godly grief produces repentance. Psalm 51:17: a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise. Revelation 9:1-11 uses locust imagery for the final judgment.

STEP 6

Application

Where do you need to "return with all your heart"? Confess it to God.

Ask what your religion looks like on the outside only. Pray that God would tear your heart, not just your garment.

Trust God to restore "the years the locust has eaten" in your life: the seasons you feel were wasted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Return to God with all your heart, and tell him what it means.
- Thank him that he is gracious, merciful, and slow to anger.
- Ask him to pour out his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

DAY 549 · WEEK 79

Joel 3:1-21

Judgment on the nations; the LORD dwells in Zion

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joel 3:1-21 (in some Bibles, Joel 2:28-3:21). The LORD gathers the nations for judgment, and the book ends with a vision of a fountain from the LORD's house. Read it as the final answer to the locusts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joel's last chapter looks forward to the final day. The LORD will judge the nations for how they treated his people, and his own people will dwell in safety. The language is vivid, with images of a valley of decision and a fountain flowing from the temple. It points past the post-exilic community to the end of history.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For behold, in those days and at that time, when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem" (3:1).
2. "I will gather all the nations and bring them down to the Valley of Jehoshaphat" (3:2).
3. "Beat your plowshares into swords, and your pruning hooks into spears" (3:10).
4. "Multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision! For the day of the LORD is near in the valley of decision" (3:14).
5. "The sun and the moon are darkened, and the stars withdraw their shining" (3:15).
6. "But the LORD is a refuge to his people, a stronghold to the people of Israel" (3:16).
7. "So you shall know that I am the LORD your God, who dwells in Zion, my holy mountain" (3:17).

8 “And a fountain shall come forth from the house of the LORD and water the Valley of Shittim” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Joel moves from the locusts to the end of the world. God promises to “restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem,” language like Psalm 126. Then he will gather the nations to the Valley of Jehoshaphat, a name meaning “the LORD judges.” There he will judge them for scattering his people and dividing the land, and for selling the children of Israel as slaves.

This section is hard to read, because it describes judgment. But it contains a fundamental truth. God sees injustice and will set it right. For those who are oppressed, this is good news. The prayer for justice is answered. The line “Beat your plowshares into swords” is an inversion of the later promise in Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3, where swords are beaten into plowshares. Here, the nations are summoned to war and are met by God.

The “valley of decision” is the place where judgment is decided. The phrase can mean the decision God makes, not our decision. Still, the image captures the seriousness of the moment. Everyone will stand before the Judge. The sun and moon darken, and the LORD roars from Zion. Yet “the LORD is a refuge to his people, a stronghold to the people of Israel.” The same event that terrifies his enemies shelters his people.

The book ends with restoration. The mountains drip sweet wine, the hills flow with milk, and the streambeds run with water. A fountain flows from the house of the LORD. Egypt and Edom will be desolate, but Judah will be inhabited forever. “The LORD dwells in Zion.” That final sentence is the book’s answer to the locusts. The land will be restored, and God will be with his people.

The fountain from the temple is a thread through the whole Bible, from Eden’s river to Ezekiel 47 to Revelation 22.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 22:1-2 shows the river of the water of life flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb. John 7:37-38: “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink.” Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3 invert the swords and plowshares. Matthew 25:31-46 describes the judgment of the nations. Revelation 14:14-20 uses the harvest image from Joel 3:13. Romans 12:19: “Vengeance is mine, I will repay, says the Lord.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray for those who suffer injustice, trusting God to judge rightly.

Remember that the same day that is terrifying to enemies is a refuge for those who trust in the LORD.

Drink from the fountain: spend time in worship, asking Christ to satisfy your thirst.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he judges rightly and is a refuge to his people.

Ask him to make you ready for his day.

Ask him to let his fountain flow from his house.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

DAY 550 · WEEK 79

Obadiah 1:1-21

Edom falls, God defends his people

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Obadiah (one chapter, 21 verses). This is the shortest book in the Old Testament. It is a prophecy against Edom, Israel's brother nation, for the pride and violence shown to Judah. Read it in one sitting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Edom descended from Esau, Jacob's twin brother. The two nations had a history of rivalry. When Babylon destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, Edom stood by, gloated, and even took part, looting and handing over fugitives. Obadiah's prophecy was likely given soon after. Psalm 137:7 and Lamentations 4:21 also remember Edom's betrayal. The book answers a question: will God let this stand?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rock" (v. 3).
2. "Though you soar aloft like the eagle… from there I will bring you down, declares the LORD" (v. 4).
3. "Because of the violence done to your brother Jacob, shame shall cover you" (v. 10).
4. "On the day that you stood aloof, on the day that strangers carried off his wealth" (v. 11).
5. "You should not gloat over the day of your brother in the day of his misfortune" (v. 12).
6. "You should not enter the gate of my people in the day of their calamity" (v. 13).
7. "For the day of the LORD is near upon all the nations. As you have done, it shall be done to you" (v. 15).
8. "And the kingdom shall be the LORD's" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Edom's capital Sela, "the rock," was built in the cliffs of the mountains, in a nearly impregnable position. The Edomites thought they were safe: "Who will bring me down to the ground?" Obadiah says God will. Pride has deceived them. No place is high enough to escape God's reach.

The chief charge is against Edom's treatment of Judah. Verses 10 to 14 lay out a series of failures, each introduced by "you should not." Edom stood aloof when strangers invaded. It gloated, rejoiced, boasted, entered the gate, looted, and cut off the fugitives. This is not a case of ordinary rivalry. It is a betrayal of kin. And that is what makes it worse. A brother stands by while his brother is attacked.

Notice what is condemned: standing aloof counts as a sin. "On the day that you stood aloof… you were like one of them." Passive indifference is complicity. Gloating over the misfortune of someone else is a serious sin. Proverbs 24:17-18 says, "Do not rejoice when your enemy falls."

God's judgment is described by the principle of reciprocity: "As you have done, it shall be done to you." The proud will be brought low.

But the book does not end in judgment alone. It ends with a vision of deliverance: "On Mount Zion there shall be those who escape, and it shall be holy." Jacob will possess his own. "Saviors shall go up to Mount Zion to rule Mount Esau, and the kingdom shall be the LORD's." This final sentence is the aim of the whole prophecy: God's kingdom will prevail, and all pride will fall before it.

Obadiah is a reminder that God sees how we treat others, especially when they fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 25:41-45 says that what we do or fail to do for the least of these, we do or fail to do for Christ. Luke 10:30-37 shows the priest and Levite who passed by on the other side. Proverbs 24:17: "Do not rejoice when your enemy falls." James 4:6: God opposes the proud. Revelation 11:15: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ." 1 Corinthians 12:26: if one member suffers, all suffer together.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a person whose downfall you secretly enjoyed. Confess it, and pray for them.

Ask whether you have “stood aloof” when someone in your family, church, or community was in trouble.

Be on guard against the pride of security, the sense that nothing can touch you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to humble the pride of your heart.
- Ask him to keep you from gloating over another’s misfortune.
- Ask him to give you a heart that grieves with those who grieve.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 551 · WEEK 79

Psalm 97

The LORD reigns; let the earth rejoice

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 97. You will read it again later in the plan. Read it now as the answer to Obadiah: the LORD reigns, and pride cannot stand before him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 97 is a royal psalm, one of a group (Psalms 93, 95 to 99) that begin or center on "The LORD reigns." Coming after Obadiah's judgment on proud Edom, it celebrates God's rule, which terrifies the proud and delights the righteous. The returned community, small and surrounded by hostile neighbors, sang it as a reminder of who is really in charge.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns, let the earth rejoice; let the many coastlands be glad!" (v. 1).
2. "Clouds and thick darkness are all around him; righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne" (v. 2).
3. "Fire goes before him and burns up his adversaries all around" (v. 3).
4. "The mountains melt like wax before the LORD, before the Lord of all the earth" (v. 5).
5. "The heavens declare his righteousness, and all the peoples see his glory" (v. 6).
6. "All worshipers of images are put to shame, who make their boast in worthless idols" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD loves those who hate evil; he preserves the lives of his saints" (v. 10).
8. "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with joy: the reign of God is good news for the whole earth, even the distant coastlands. This is a striking claim. The one who rules is not a distant tyrant but the one on whose throne "righteousness and justice" rest. His reign is moral. It means that the world is not left to chance or to the powerful.

But his presence is awesome. Clouds and thick darkness, fire, lightning, and melting mountains. These are the images of Sinai. They remind the readers that God is holy. The imagery says that no one can approach him without fear unless he provides a way.

The effect on idols is immediate. "All worshipers of images are put to shame." Even the so-called gods bow down before him. This is the same truth you saw in Psalm 115, and Obadiah's warning to Edom. The proud who trust in themselves, in their strongholds, in their false gods will be shamed.

Yet the psalm is not only about terror. Zion hears and is glad, and the daughters of Judah rejoice. The judgments of God are matters for gladness among his people because they mean that wrongs will be set right. And then the psalm gives instruction: "O you who love the LORD, hate evil." Love and hate are linked. Loving the good means rejecting what destroys it. And God "preserves the lives of his saints; he delivers them from the hand of the wicked."

The last two verses contain a beautiful promise: "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart." The image is of a seed planted in darkness that will rise as light. Those who walk uprightly may seem to sow in sorrow, but God has sown light for them. In the end, the psalm tells us to rejoice in the LORD and give thanks to his holy name.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 19:6: "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns." Hebrews 1:6 quotes verse 7: "Let all God's angels worship him." John 8:12: "Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life." Romans 12:9: "Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good." Matthew 5:14-16 says we are the light of the world. Isaiah 9:2: the people who walked in darkness have seen a great light.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud, "The LORD reigns," when you feel anxious about the world.

Ask what it means to "hate evil" in a way that is tender toward people.

Receive the promise: “Light is sown for the righteous.” Trust that your faithfulness is not wasted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you rejoice that he reigns.
- Ask him to shame the idols you are tempted by.
- Thank him for preserving the lives of his saints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 552 · WEEK 79

Psalm 98

Sing to the LORD a new song, his salvation revealed

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 98. You will read it again later in the plan. Read it now as the song that follows the judgment: the nations see the salvation of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 98 is another royal psalm with a new song. Its last verses mirror Psalm 96. Isaac Watts based "Joy to the World" on this psalm, though he reapplied it to the coming of Christ. For the returned exiles, it carried a message: the God who has brought us home will be seen by the whole world.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song, for he has done marvelous things!" (v. 1).
2. "His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him" (v. 1).
3. "The LORD has made known his salvation; he has revealed his righteousness in the sight of the nations" (v. 2).
4. "He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel" (v. 3).
5. "All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God" (v. 3).
6. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth; break forth into joyous song and sing praises!" (v. 4).
7. "Let the rivers clap their hands; let the hills sing for joy together" (vv. 8).
8. "For he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world with righteousness, and the peoples with equity" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a new song, because God has done something new. The language of verse 1 is like Isaiah's: his right hand and holy arm have worked salvation. This was the language of the exodus. It is a God who saves, not a God who waits to be saved.

The key is verses 2 and 3. "He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel." God is not forgetful. After the exile, the people had wondered if he had forgotten them. The answer is that he has remembered. And the result is for the whole earth: "All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God." God's saving acts for Israel are meant to be visible to all nations. This is the universal side of God's choice of Israel.

The music rises. A joyful noise, then a whole orchestra: lyre, trumpets, horn. The sea roars and the rivers clap their hands. The hills sing for joy. Creation joins because the Lord is coming. And the reason is judgment: "He will judge the world with righteousness." Again, judgment is a cause for rejoicing. If the judge is righteous, it means that the world will be set right.

In this psalm the coming of the LORD has a double face. For Israel, it is salvation and remembrance of love. For the nations, it is the revelation of his righteousness. For creation, it is the end of groaning. For those who trust him, it is the greatest joy.

When Isaac Watts wrote "Joy to the World," he saw in this psalm the coming of Christ. "Let earth receive her King." It is a faithful reading. The one whose salvation was revealed to the nations came as a baby in Bethlehem, and he will come again.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 2:30-32: Simeon said, "My eyes have seen your salvation that you have prepared in the presence of all peoples, a light for revelation to the Gentiles." Luke 1:54-55 says God has remembered his mercy. Romans 8:19-21: creation waits with eager longing. Acts 17:31: God will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed. Revelation 5:9: they sang a new song. Isaiah 52:10: all the ends of the earth shall see the salvation of our God.

STEP 6

Application

Sing a hymn today, such as "Joy to the World," and think of the psalm behind it.

Ask: what "marvelous thing" has God done for you recently? Write it as a new song or a short note.

Pray for the ends of the earth to see his salvation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing to the LORD a new song, in your own words.
- Thank him for the salvation he has revealed.
- Ask him to help you make a joyful noise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

DAY 553 · WEEK 79

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Joel 2:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

REST

Meditation

This verse is a call to real repentance, and it begins with a contrast. It does not say that outward signs are wrong. It says they are not enough.

"Rend your hearts and not your garments." In the ancient world, tearing your clothes was the standard sign of grief or repentance. But a person could tear a garment and keep a hard heart. God asks for the real thing. Sorrow over sin, turning from it, wanting God. In Psalm 51:17, David says, "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit."

"Return to the LORD your God." The call is to return, to come home. The picture is of someone who has wandered and needs to return to a loving master. "Your God." Even in rebellion, he is still their God.

“For he is gracious and merciful.” This is the reason to return. It is not that you can earn his favor, but that he is already kind. Gracious means he gives what we do not deserve. Merciful means he does not give what we do deserve.

“Slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love.” His anger is real but slow. His love is abundant, overflowing. This is God’s own description of himself in Exodus 34:6, and it is repeated across the Old Testament, in Nehemiah 9:17, Psalm 145:8, Jonah 4:2, and here.

“And he relents over disaster.” God is willing to turn back from judgment when people turn to him. This does not mean God changes his character, but that he responds to repentance with mercy.

Whenever you feel you have failed, say this verse. It describes a God who is waiting.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Chronicler’s story of the fall of Judah, with Manasseh’s repentance in Babylon and Josiah’s finding of the Book of the Law. You saw how the book ends with an open door: “Let him go up.” Then you moved to the prophets of the return. In Joel, a swarm of locusts became a picture of the coming day of the LORD, and the prophet’s call was clear: “Return to me with all your heart.” You read the promise of the Spirit poured out on all flesh, and a fountain from the house of the LORD. In Obadiah, you heard God judge proud Edom for standing aloof in the day of Judah’s trouble, and promise that the kingdom shall be the LORD’s. In Psalms 97 and 98, you sang that the LORD reigns and that all the ends of the earth will see his salvation.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Joel says to rend your heart and not your garments. What outward religious habits in your life need an inner reality behind them?

Obadiah condemns standing aloof when a brother suffers. Whom in your life might you be tempted to ignore?

Joel promised the Spirit on all flesh, and Peter said it came at Pentecost. How have you seen the Spirit at work in your life or in your church?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Return to God with all your heart.

Thank him for pouring out his Spirit.

Rest in his love.

DAY 554 · WEEK 80

Psalm 99

The LORD reigns; let the peoples tremble

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 99. You will read it again later in the plan. Read it now as a hymn of the holy God who answers prayer. Notice the refrain "Holy is he."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 99 is the last of the "LORD reigns" psalms. It has a threefold refrain: "Holy is he" (vv. 3, 5) and "Holy is the LORD our God" (v. 9). It recalls Moses, Aaron, and Samuel as those who called on God and were answered. Coming right before the prophet Haggai, who will call the people to build the temple, it is a good reminder of the holiness of the place where God meets his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns; let the peoples tremble! He sits enthroned upon the cherubim; let the earth quake!" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is great in Zion; he is exalted over all the peoples" (v. 2).
3. "Let them praise your great and awesome name! Holy is he!" (v. 3).
4. "The King in his might loves justice. You have established equity; you have executed justice and righteousness in Jacob" (v. 4).
5. "Exalt the LORD our God; worship at his footstool! Holy is he!" (v. 5).
6. "Moses and Aaron were among his priests, Samuel also was among those who called upon his name. They called to the LORD, and he answered them" (v. 6).
7. "You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings" (v. 8).

8 “Exalt the LORD our God, and worship at his holy mountain; for the LORD our God is holy!” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with God’s majesty. He sits enthroned on the cherubim, which refers to the ark’s mercy seat. He is great in Zion and exalted over all peoples. The proper response is trembling. Holiness is not just moral purity but God’s otherness, his set-apartness, the fact that he is not like us.

The first refrain, “Holy is he,” appears after the call to praise his name. The second appears after the call to worship at his footstool, the temple or ark. The third appears at the end. These three refrains remind us of Isaiah’s vision of the seraphim, who cried “Holy, holy, holy.” This psalm gives the three-fold chant in a different form.

In the center, the psalm says that the strong King loves justice. His holiness is not cold but moral. He establishes equity. A holy God is a just God.

Then comes a surprise. This awesome, holy God answers prayer. “Moses and Aaron… Samuel… called to the LORD, and he answered them.” He spoke to them in the pillar of cloud and gave them his testimonies. The God who sits on the cherubim is the God who speaks to his servants. Holiness and nearness are not opposed.

And then the key line: “You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings.” Moses interceded and was heard, yet there were consequences. God’s forgiveness does not erase reality. This is the pattern of the exile: he forgave, yet the people bore the discipline.

For the returned community, the temple was a holy place to be approached with reverence. The message of Haggai is coming: build the house, because the holy God will dwell there. And for us, the holiness is met by the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 6:3: “Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts.” Revelation 4:8 repeats the threefold holy around the throne. 1 Peter 1:15-16: “You shall be holy, for I am holy.” Hebrews 4:14-16: we have a great high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses. Hebrews 12:28-29: let us offer acceptable worship with reverence and awe. James 5:16-18: the prayer of a righteous person has great power.

STEP 6

Application

Pause before prayer and remember who you are addressing: the holy God who sits enthroned.

Remember that you can approach him in Christ, and call on him as Moses, Aaron, and Samuel did.

Ask where you have treated God casually, and recover reverence.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tremble before the God who reigns.
- Thank him that he answered those who called on him.
- Worship him at his footstool.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 555 · WEEK 80

Haggai 1:1-2:23

Rebuild the Temple; the latter glory will be greater

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Haggai 1:1-2:23. Sixteen years after the return, the temple is still unfinished. Haggai's short messages stir the people to build. Notice the repeated call to "consider your ways."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is 520 BC, the second year of Darius. The foundation of the temple was laid in 536, and then the work stopped. The people built their own houses and left God's house in ruins. Then Haggai appears, with four messages over about four months. His words are brief, direct, and effective. Within weeks the work resumes. The book is a model of how a prophet can move a people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Is it a time for you yourselves to dwell in your paneled houses, while this house lies in ruins?" (1:4).
2. "Now therefore, thus says the LORD of hosts: Consider your ways" (1:5).
3. "You have sown much, and harvested little... and he who earns wages does so to put them into a bag with holes" (1:6).
4. "Go up to the hills and bring wood and build the house, that I may take pleasure in it and that I may be glorified" (1:8).
5. "And the LORD stirred up the spirit of Zerubbabel... and the spirit of Joshua... and the spirit of all the remnant of the people" (1:14).
6. "I am with you, declares the LORD" (1:13).

7. “The latter glory of this house shall be greater than the former, says the LORD of hosts. And in this place I will give peace” (2:9).

8. “On that day… I will take you, O Zerubbabel… and make you like a signet ring, for I have chosen you” (2:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Haggai’s first message is a question: “Is it a time for you to dwell in your paneled houses, while this house lies in ruins?” The people had said, “The time has not yet come.” They had excuses. Hard times, opposition, economic pressure. But Haggai shows that their priorities were backward. They had put their own comfort first, and the result was frustration. “You have sown much and harvested little.” When you put God last, even your best efforts leak away. The phrase “consider your ways” appears twice. It is a call to honest reflection.

The remarkable response is that the leaders and people obey. And God’s answer is brief and wonderful: “I am with you.” He stirs up their spirits, and they begin to work, twenty-three days after Haggai’s first word.

A month later, the older people are discouraged, since this temple looks like nothing compared with Solomon’s. Haggai answers: “Be strong… and work, for I am with you.” Then he says, “The latter glory of this house shall be greater than the former.” This was not because of gold, but because of whose presence would fill it. It points to the day when Jesus, the glory of God in flesh, would walk in that temple.

The third message is about holiness: you cannot make unclean things clean by touching the holy. Ritual and obedience cannot be separated. But from this day forward, God promises to bless.

The last message is to Zerubbabel. God will shake the heavens and earth, overthrow the kingdoms, and make Zerubbabel “like a signet ring.” The signet ring was a symbol of authority. In Jeremiah 22:24, Jehoiachin was rejected as a signet ring. Now the line of David is chosen again. Zerubbabel is a sign that God’s promise to David is alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 6:33: “Seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.” Hebrews 12:26-28 quotes Haggai 2:6 about the shaking of heaven and earth and the unshakable kingdom. John 1:14: the Word became flesh and dwelt among us. Matthew 1:12-13: Zerubbabel is in the line of Jesus. 1 Corinthians 3:16-17 says we are God’s temple. Philippians 1:6.

STEP 6

Application

“Consider your ways.” Review how you spend time and money. Is there anything where your own comfort has crowded out God?

Start something you have been postponing for God. Take one small step today.

Take courage from “I am with you” in your work.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to show you where you have put your own house before his.
- Ask him to stir your spirit to work for him.
- Thank him for the promise that his presence is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 556 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 1:1-3:10

The eight visions begin; the Branch foretold

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 1:1-3:10. Zechariah begins with a call to return, and then he sees eight night visions. Today you will read the first four. Read for what each one says about God's care for Jerusalem and his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Zechariah began prophesying two months after Haggai. He was both a prophet and a priest. His book is full of visions, symbols, and messianic promises, and it is the longest of the Minor Prophets. The first six chapters report eight visions that came in one night. They reassure the discouraged community that God has not forgotten Jerusalem.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Return to me, says the LORD of hosts, and I will return to you" (1:3).
2. "Your fathers, where are they? And the prophets, do they live forever? But my words and my statutes… did they not overtake your fathers?" (1:5-6).
3. "I have returned to Jerusalem with mercy; my house shall be built in it" (1:16).
4. "Jerusalem shall be inhabited as villages without walls, because of the multitude of people and livestock in it" (2:4).
5. "And I will be to her a wall of fire all around, declares the LORD, and I will be the glory in her midst" (2:5).
6. "Sing and rejoice, O daughter of Zion, for behold, I come and I will dwell in your midst" (2:10).
7. "Is not this a brand plucked from the fire?" (3:2).

8 “Behold, I have taken your iniquity away from you, and I will clothe you with pure vestments” (3:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with a call that matches the whole Old Testament: “Return to me, and I will return to you.” The previous generation did not listen, but God’s word did what it said. “They repented and said, As the LORD of hosts purposed to deal with us… so has he dealt with us.” Now it is the new generation’s turn.

The visions follow. The first is a man on a red horse among myrtle trees, with angelic patrols. They report that the earth is at rest. But the angel asks, “O LORD of hosts, how long?” The LORD answers with “gracious and comforting words”: “I am exceedingly jealous for Jerusalem.” The second vision, four horns and four craftsmen, shows that the powers that scattered Judah will be dealt with.

The third vision is a man with a measuring line, ready to measure Jerusalem. An angel says that the city will be unwalled, because there will be so many people. And God himself will be “a wall of fire all around” and “the glory in her midst.” This is better than any stone wall. It was wonderful news for those who were proud of Nehemiah’s wall: the true security was the presence of God. “Many nations shall join themselves to the LORD in that day, and shall be my people.”

The fourth vision, in chapter 3, is the center. Joshua the high priest stands before the angel of the LORD, in filthy garments, with Satan at his right hand to accuse him. The LORD rebukes Satan: “Is not this a brand plucked from the fire?” Joshua’s filthy clothes are removed. “Behold, I have taken your iniquity away from you, and I will clothe you with pure vestments.” A clean turban is put on his head. The picture is of justification by grace. Joshua does nothing to earn it. The chapter ends with a promise of “my servant the Branch,” the coming Messiah, and “I will remove the iniquity of this land in a single day.”

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:33-34: “Who shall bring any charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies.” 2 Corinthians 5:21: for our sake he made him to be sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God. Revelation 7:14: they washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb. Isaiah 61:10: he has clothed me with the garments of salvation. Hebrews 10:10-14: one offering has perfected for all time. Revelation 12:10 describes the accuser of our brothers.

STEP 6

Application

When the accuser reminds you of your failures, answer with chapter 3: “The LORD rebuke you.” Remember you are a brand plucked from the fire.

Thank God for the clean clothes of Christ’s righteousness.

Remember that the best security is God’s presence, not any wall you have built.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Return to God, and thank him for returning to you.

Ask him to be a wall of fire around his people.

Thank him for the Branch.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 557 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 4:1-6:15

The lampstand; the flying scroll; the Branch crowned

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 4:1-6:15. You will read the remaining four visions: the lampstand and olive trees, the flying scroll, the woman in a basket, and the four chariots. The chapter ends with a crowning ceremony for Joshua. Read 4:6 and 6:12-13 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The visions continue. The fifth vision shows a golden lampstand fed by two olive trees, and it is meant to encourage Zerubbabel, the governor who is leading the temple's rebuilding. The next three visions deal with sin, and the eighth shows God's judgment on the nations. The section ends with a symbolic act: the crowning of the high priest Joshua, who stands as a picture of the Messiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts" (4:6).
2. "Who has despised the day of small things? For these seven shall rejoice, when they see the plumb line in the hand of Zerubbabel" (4:10).
3. "These are the two anointed ones who stand by the Lord of the whole earth" (4:14).
4. "This is the curse that goes out over the face of the whole land" (5:3).
5. "The hands of Zerubbabel have laid the foundation of this house; his hands shall also complete it" (4:9).
6. "Take from the exiles… silver and gold, and make a crown" (6:10-11).
7. "Behold, the man whose name is the Branch: for he shall branch out from his place, and he shall build the temple of the LORD" (6:12).

8 “And he shall bear royal honor, and shall sit and rule on his throne. And there shall be a priest on his throne” (6:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lampstand vision is among the best known. Zechariah sees a golden lampstand with seven lamps, fed with oil from two olive trees through pipes, with no human hand pouring. The meaning is given in a single sentence: “Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit.” Zerubbabel faces a mountain of difficulty, and he is told that the work will be done by the Spirit of God, not by human strength. The oil is the Spirit, the light is the witness of God’s people, and the supply is limitless. “Who has despised the day of small things?” The small beginning would be finished.

The next three visions are about sin. The flying scroll, thirty feet by fifteen, goes out over the land with a curse on thieves and those who swear falsely. The woman in the basket, “Wickedness,” is carried away to Babylon. God is not just rebuilding a building. He is removing evil from the land. This answers the problem that Ezra and Nehemiah faced: how could the community stay faithful? God would purge it.

The eighth vision of the four chariots goes out to the four winds, and the one going north has “set my Spirit at rest in the north country.” God’s judgment on Babylon is complete.

Then the symbolic act: Zechariah is told to make a crown and set it on the head of Joshua the high priest, and say, “Behold, the man whose name is the Branch.” Joshua is not the Branch himself; he is a sign. The Branch will build the temple, sit and rule on his throne, “and there shall be a priest on his throne.” In Israel, kings and priests were separate. But the Messiah would hold both offices. “The counsel of peace shall be between them both.” This is a clear promise of a priest-king, who is Jesus. And “those who are far off shall come and help to build the temple of the LORD.” The Gentiles will join.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 7:1-3 and Psalm 110:4 describe a priest-king in the order of Melchizedek. Hebrews 4:14-16 names Jesus our great high priest. Luke 1:78 calls Jesus the “sunrise” or “Branch.” Revelation 11:4 uses the two olive trees. Galatians 5:16-25 teaches walking by the Spirit. Acts 1:8: “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you.” Ephesians 2:19-22 shows Gentiles built into the temple.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you trying “by might and by power”? Pray, “Not by my strength, but by your Spirit.”

Don’t despise a small beginning. Ask God to finish what he started.

Thank Jesus that he is both king and priest, and has done what Joshua only pictured.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that it is not by might or power but by his Spirit.
- Ask him not to let you despise the day of small things.
- Ask him to remove wickedness from your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 558 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 7:1-8:23

True fasting; the LORD returns; nations included

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 7:1-8:23. A delegation asks whether they should keep a fast, and Zechariah answers with a question about justice and mercy. Then come eight promises of restoration. Read the final verses of chapter 8.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two years after the visions, in 518 BC, a delegation from Bethel asks the priests whether they should continue to mourn and fast in the fifth month, the month the temple was destroyed. Zechariah answers in two parts: first a rebuke about the heart behind religious practice, and then a series of promises. This is the point where the book turns from visions to messages.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “When you fasted and mourned… was it for me that you fasted?” (7:5).
2. “Render true judgments, show kindness and mercy to one another” (7:9).
3. “Do not oppress the widow, the fatherless, the sojourner, or the poor, and let none of you devise evil against another in your heart” (7:10).
4. “They made their hearts diamond-hard lest they should hear the law” (7:12).
5. “I am jealous for Zion with great jealousy” (8:2).
6. “I will return to Zion and dwell in the midst of Jerusalem” (8:3).
7. “Old men and old women shall again sit in the streets of Jerusalem, each with his staff in his hand because of great age. And the streets of the city shall be full of boys and girls playing” (8:4-5).

8 “In those days ten men from the nations of every tongue shall take hold of the robe of a Jew, saying, Let us go with you, for we have heard that God is with you” (8:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The question is about a fast. For seventy years the exiles had fasted in the fifth and seventh months to remember the destruction. Now that the temple is being rebuilt, should they continue? Zechariah first asks a hard question: “Was it for me that you fasted? And when you eat and drink, do you not eat and drink for yourselves?” Their religion had become self-focused. They were going through the motions.

Then he reminds them of the former prophets, who said the same thing: “Render true judgments, show kindness and mercy to one another. Do not oppress the widow, the fatherless, the sojourner, or the poor.” The ancestors would not listen. “They made their hearts diamond-hard.” Justice and mercy were the point. The exile resulted from ignoring them. The people of the return must learn from this.

Then chapter 8 brings ten promises, each beginning, “Thus says the LORD of hosts.” God is jealous for Zion. He will return and dwell in Jerusalem, which will be called the “faithful city.” The picture is of an ordinary, peaceful city: old men and women sitting in the streets, boys and girls playing. It is one of the loveliest images in the prophets. God’s salvation is not only grand but domestic, a place safe for the old and the young.

The people are told: “Let your hands be strong.” And God promises that their fasts will become “joy and gladness and cheerful feasts.” The fast of the fourth, fifth, seventh, and tenth months, all memories of Jerusalem’s fall, will be turned into feasts. Sorrow will be transformed. The chapter ends with a vision of the nations: ten men take hold of a Jew’s robe and say, “Let us go with you, for we have heard that God is with you.” The mission of Israel to the nations is fulfilled in the church.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 58:3-7 describes the fast God desires. Matthew 6:16-18 speaks of fasting before the Father. Matthew 23:23: justice, mercy, and faithfulness are the weightier matters of the law. Micah 6:8: do justice, love kindness, walk humbly. James 1:27: religion that is pure is to visit orphans and widows in their affliction. Luke 5:34-35: when the bridegroom is with us, there is no mourning. Revelation 21:4.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any spiritual practice in your life has become a ritual done for yourself. Reshape it around love for God and neighbor.

Show “kindness and mercy” to a widow, an orphan, a foreigner, or a poor person this week.

Pray for the day when old men and women sit in the streets and children play, and work for the safety of such a place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where your religion has been for yourself.
- Ask him to teach you to render true judgments and show mercy.
- Ask him to make you glad in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 559 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 9:1-11:17

The humble king on a donkey; the shepherd-king

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 9:1-11:17. A king comes to Zion on a donkey, and a shepherd is rejected and sold for thirty pieces of silver. These chapters are rich in messianic promises, and the New Testament quotes them often. Read 9:9-10 and 11:12-13 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second half of Zechariah is made of two oracles, chapters 9 to 11 and 12 to 14. They are set in a different style than the visions, and they look to the distant future. They describe the coming of the king, the rejection of the shepherd, and the victory of the LORD. This reading covers the first oracle. The memory verse of this unit comes from chapter 9.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion! Shout aloud, O daughter of Jerusalem!” (9:9).
2. “Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey” (9:9).
3. “I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim and the war horse from Jerusalem” (9:10).
4. “And he shall speak peace to the nations; his rule shall be from sea to sea” (9:10).
5. “As for you also, because of the blood of my covenant with you, I will set your prisoners free from the waterless pit” (9:11).
6. “Return to your stronghold, O prisoners of hope” (9:12).
7. “Then I took my staff Grace, and I cut it in two, annulling the covenant that I had made with all the peoples” (11:10).
8. “So they weighed out as my wages thirty pieces of silver” (11:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 9 begins with judgment on the nations around Israel, Syria, Tyre, and Philistia, as God clears the way for his people. Then the focus narrows to a single, striking image: a king arrives in Jerusalem. Everything about him is surprising. He is "righteous and having salvation." He is "humble," or "afflicted." And he rides a donkey, not a war horse. The donkey was a sign of peace and humility. Kings rode horses to war; they rode donkeys when they came in peace (1 Kings 1:33).

His kingdom is likewise surprising. He cuts off the chariot and war horse and the battle bow, and "speaks peace to the nations." His rule reaches from sea to sea. This is a king of peace whose reign is universal, and whose weapon is speech. The Hebrew reading is that his word does it.

Then, "because of the blood of my covenant with you," the prisoners are set free. Notice the phrase "prisoners of hope." Even those who are still in the pit have hope, for a ransom is coming. The covenant is sealed in blood.

Chapters 10 and 11 shift. The people have followed false shepherds. God will care for his flock. But in chapter 11, Zechariah is told to play the part of a shepherd and to care for a doomed flock. He takes two staffs, "Favor" and "Union." The flock rejects him, and he asks for his wages. They weigh out thirty pieces of silver, the price of a slave (Exodus 21:32). The LORD says, "Throw it to the potter," and Zechariah throws the silver into the house of the LORD. It is a bitter irony: the shepherd is valued at the price of a slave.

The final verses describe the worthless shepherd who abandons the flock. This section of Zechariah shows two kings: the humble king who comes in peace and the shepherd who is rejected. They are one person.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 21:1-11 shows Jesus entering Jerusalem on a donkey, quoting Zechariah 9:9. Matthew 26:15 records Judas receiving thirty pieces of silver. Matthew 27:3-10 records the silver being thrown into the temple and used to buy the potter's field. Luke 22:20: "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood." John 10:11: "I am the good shepherd." Philippians 2:5-8 describes Christ's humility.

STEP 6

Application

Read Matthew 21:1-11 alongside today's reading. Notice how precisely Jesus fulfilled Zechariah.

Think about humility in your leadership or relationships. What does it look like to come in peace, “on a donkey”?

Thank Jesus for being the shepherd who was sold for thirty pieces of silver for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Rejoice that your King has come, humble and riding on a donkey.

Tell him what you want to say to the shepherd-king.

Thank him for speaking peace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 560 · WEEK 80

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Zechariah 4:6 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

ZECHARIAH 4:6

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken to a governor who was staring at a mountain. Zerubbabel had laid the foundation of the temple, and for years had been unable to finish it. Armies, kings, and officials stood in the way. Into that situation, God spoke a short sentence.

"Not by might." The word means an army or a strong force. Zerubbabel might have thought that the solution was more soldiers or more money. God says no. Human resources are not what will finish the temple.

"Nor by power." The second word means personal strength, ability, or skill. It is not just armies but individuals. Not by his talent, his leadership, or his charisma.

"But by my Spirit." The third phrase is the answer. The work of God is done by the Spirit of God. This is the oil in the lampstand vision, flowing without human hands. The Spirit gives the energy, the wisdom, and the ability to finish.

"Says the LORD of hosts." This is the ground of the promise. The LORD of hosts, the commander of heaven's armies, makes the promise. He can do what armies cannot.

The verse does not say we do nothing. Zerubbabel had to keep building. But the building was to be done in dependence. The result: "He shall bring forward the top stone amid shouts of Grace, grace to it!" When the work is done, the glory goes to God.

Say this verse when you are tempted to rely on your own strength: in a ministry, a marriage, a job, a struggle with sin. It is a reminder that the work belongs to God, and so does the power.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the prophets of the return. In Haggai, you heard a call to "consider your ways" and to build God's house first, and you saw the people's response and God's promise: "I am with you." In Zechariah, you read the eight night visions: the man among the myrtle trees, the wall of fire, Joshua in filthy garments made clean, the lampstand fed by the Spirit, and the crowning of the Branch, a priest on his throne. You heard a rebuke of empty fasting and a promise of old men and children in the streets of a restored Jerusalem. Then you read the first oracle, with the humble king on a donkey, the prisoners of hope, and the shepherd sold for thirty pieces of silver. Earlier in the week, Psalm 99 reminded you of the holiness of the God who answers.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Haggai said, "Consider your ways." What might God show you if you honestly reviewed how you spend your time, energy, and money?

Zechariah showed Joshua cleansed and clothed by grace alone. How does this picture comfort you when you feel unworthy?

The king of Zechariah 9:9 comes humble and on a donkey, yet his rule reaches the ends of the earth. What does that teach you about how God's kingdom advances?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that it is not by might or power but by his Spirit.

Thank him for the humble King who has come.

Thank him for clothing you in his righteousness.

DAY 561 · WEEK 81

Zechariah 12:1-14:21

The pierced one; the Day of the LORD; living waters

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 36 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 12:1-14:21. The LORD defends Jerusalem, a mourning comes over the house of David, a fountain opens for sin, a shepherd is struck, and the LORD becomes king over all the earth. Read 12:10, 13:1, and 14:9 with care.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second oracle, and it is the most apocalyptic section of the book. It uses vivid, symbolic language to describe the end: a siege of Jerusalem, a great mourning, a day of cleansing, and the final victory of the LORD. The New Testament draws heavily on it, especially in the stories of Jesus' death and in Revelation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy" (12:10).
2. "When they look on me, on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child" (12:10).
3. "On that day there shall be a fountain opened for the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, to cleanse them from sin and uncleanness" (13:1).
4. "Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (13:7).
5. "And I will put this third into the fire, and refine them as one refines silver" (13:9).
6. "They will call upon my name, and I will answer them. I will say, They are my people; and they will say, The LORD is my God" (13:9).
7. "On that day his feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives" (14:4).

8 “And the LORD will be king over all the earth. On that day the LORD will be one and his name one” (14:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 12 begins with a statement of God’s power: he stretched out the heavens and founded the earth. Then he promises that Jerusalem will become a cup of staggering and a heavy stone for all the peoples who attack her. God defends his people. But the real victory is spiritual. Verse 10 is among the most important verses in the Old Testament: God will pour out “a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy,” and the people “will look on me, on him whom they have pierced.” God himself speaks, and the pierced one is both God and someone else. The result is great mourning, like the mourning for an only child. It is repentance, a result of grace.

Chapter 13 gives the cleansing. “A fountain opened… to cleanse them from sin and uncleanness.” It is the answer to the problem the whole Old Testament has been dealing with. Sin cannot be washed away by ritual. A fountain must be opened. Idols and false prophets will be removed.

Then comes the haunting verse 7: “Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered.” The shepherd is “my companion,” says the LORD. God commands the striking of the one who is close to him. This is the suffering shepherd of chapter 11. Through it, one third will be refined as silver and gold, and will say, “The LORD is my God.”

Chapter 14 takes us to the end: the nations fight against Jerusalem, the LORD goes out to fight, his feet stand on the Mount of Olives, which splits in two. Living waters flow out from Jerusalem. Darkness and cold are no more. “And the LORD will be king over all the earth.” Even the pots in Jerusalem will be “holy to the LORD.” The book ends with everything, even the common cooking pots, marked as holy. All of life is consecrated.

STEP 5

Connection

John 19:34-37 says that after the soldiers pierced Jesus’ side, “They will look on him whom they have pierced,” quoting Zechariah 12:10. Revelation 1:7: “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him.” Matthew 26:31 quotes “I will strike the shepherd.” 1 John 1:7: the blood of Jesus cleanses us from all sin. Acts 1:11-12: Jesus ascends from the Mount of Olives. Revelation 22:1: the river of the water of life.

STEP 6

Application

Read John 19:31-37 and look at the pierced one.

Thank God for the fountain opened for sin, and take your own sin there.

Ask God to make “everything holy,” even the ordinary pots of your life: your kitchen, your work, your errands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to pour out a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy on you.
- Look on the one who was pierced, and tell him what you see.
- Thank him for the fountain that cleanses sin.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

“You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins.”

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 562 · WEEK 81

Malachi 1:1-2:17

"Have I not loved you?"; corrupt priests; broken faith

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Malachi 1:1-2:17. This is the last prophetic book of the Old Testament, written around 430 BC. God opens with love, and then the people argue back at every point. Watch for the repeated pattern: God's claim, the people's question, God's answer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Malachi's name means "my messenger." He writes after the temple is rebuilt and the wall is finished, in the generation of Nehemiah's second term. The excitement of the return has faded. The sacrifices are routine and halfhearted, the priests are careless, and many have been unfaithful to their wives. The book is set up as a series of six disputes in which God makes a statement, the people ask "How?" or "What?", and God answers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have loved you, says the LORD. But you say, How have you loved us?" (1:2).
2. "A son honors his father, and a servant his master. If then I am a father, where is my honor?" (1:6).
3. "When you offer blind animals in sacrifice, is that not evil?" (1:8).
4. "Oh that there were one among you who would shut the doors, that you might not kindle fire on my altar in vain!" (1:10).
5. "For from the rising of the sun to its setting my name will be great among the nations" (1:11).
6. "For the lips of a priest should guard knowledge, and people should seek instruction from his mouth" (2:7).

7. “Have we not all one Father? Has not one God created us?” (2:10).
8. “For the man who does not love his wife but divorces her, says the LORD, the God of Israel, covers his garment with violence” (2:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first line gives the key to the whole book: “I have loved you.” It is a statement of fact. But the people respond with doubt: “How have you loved us?” After the return, life was hard. The land was poor, and the nation was a small province under Persia. They wondered whether God’s love was real. God answers by pointing to his choice of Jacob over Esau. He had loved them from the beginning, by electing grace.

The first rebuke is to the priests. Their worship has become an insult. They bring blind, lame, and sick animals for sacrifice, things they would not offer to their governor. “A son honors his father… If then I am a father, where is my honor?” God says he would rather have the temple doors shut than have this halfhearted worship. “I have no pleasure in you.” Worship is not about the ritual but the heart’s honor of God.

In the middle of this rebuke is a remarkable promise: “From the rising of the sun to its setting my name will be great among the nations, and in every place incense will be offered to my name.” The Gentiles will worship. The sacrifices that the priests despise will be replaced by pure offerings from all nations.

Chapter 2 is about the priests’ failure to teach. “The lips of a priest should guard knowledge.” They have turned aside from the way and caused many to stumble. God’s covenant with Levi was one of life and peace, but they have corrupted it.

Then the prophet turns to the people. They have been faithless to one another, marrying foreign wives who worship other gods and divorcing the wives of their youth. The altar of the LORD was covered with tears. “The LORD was witness between you and the wife of your youth.” God hates divorce that comes from faithlessness. The chapter ends with a weary people who have “wearied the LORD with your words.” They say, “Where is the God of justice?” They are asking the question that the whole book is about to answer.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 9:13 quotes “Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated” to speak about God’s electing grace. 1 Peter 2:5 calls us to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God. John 4:21-24 speaks of true worshipers who worship in spirit and truth. Ephesians 5:25: husbands, love your wives as

Christ loved the church. Matthew 19:3-9 speaks of marriage and divorce. Romans 12:1: present your bodies as a living sacrifice. 1 Timothy 3:2 requires teachers to be above reproach.

STEP 6

Application

Ask: am I giving God my best or my leftovers, in time, money, and attention?

Hold onto “I have loved you” when you are tempted to doubt his love.

If you are married, renew your faithfulness. If you teach or lead, guard the knowledge that others depend on.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you have doubted his love.
- Confess where you give him what is blind and lame.
- Ask him to teach you to give him your best.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

“You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins.”

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 563 · WEEK 81

Malachi 3:1-4:6

The forerunner; the sun of righteousness, silence before the Word

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Malachi 3:1-4:6. The messenger will prepare the way, the LORD will suddenly come to his temple, and the book ends with the promise of Elijah. This is the last page of the Old Testament in the Christian canon. Read it slowly, as the lights go down.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Malachi's last two chapters answer the people's question, "Where is the God of justice?" God says he is coming. But first a messenger will prepare the way. Then, the LORD himself will come to his temple. The book also addresses the question of tithing, and distinguishes those who serve God from those who do not. It ends with a promise and a warning. After this, there are about four hundred years of silence before the word of God comes again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I send my messenger, and he will prepare the way before me" (3:1).
2. "And the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple; and the messenger of the covenant in whom you delight, behold, he is coming" (3:1).
3. "But who can endure the day of his coming?... For he is like a refiner's fire and like fullers' soap' (3:2).
4. "For I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed" (3:6).
5. "Return to me, and I will return to you" (3:7).
6. "Bring the full tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house" (3:10).

7. “But for you who fear my name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings” (4:2).

8. “Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the LORD comes. And he will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers” (4:5-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The key announcement is in 3:1. A messenger will prepare the way, and then “the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple.” The people were asking, “Where is the God of justice?” God says, “I am coming.” But the coming will not be what they expect. They wanted judgment on their enemies. But the LORD says that he will first purify his own people. “Who can endure the day of his coming?” He is like a refiner’s fire and fullers’ soap. He will purify the sons of Levi until they present right offerings.

The next section is a call to return, based on God’s unchanging character: “I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed.” This is one of the great verses of grace. The reason Israel survives is not their faithfulness but God’s. “Return to me, and I will return to you.” The people then ask, “How shall we return?” God says they have robbed him in tithes and offerings. He invites them to bring the full tithe and “put me to the test,” with the promise that he will open the windows of heaven. The test is about trust, not a formula for wealth.

Then there is a division. The people had said that it is vain to serve God. But a group “who feared the LORD spoke with one another,” and the LORD listened and wrote a book of remembrance. “They shall be mine… in the day when I make up my treasured possession.” God keeps a record of the faithful.

The last chapter describes the day coming, burning like an oven, when the proud will be stubble. But for those who fear his name, “the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings.” That is one of the most beautiful images in the Old Testament. The book ends with a command to remember the law of Moses, and a promise of Elijah to turn hearts before the great day.

Then there is silence. For four hundred years, no prophet speaks. But the promise is hanging in the air: a messenger, a coming Lord, a rising sun.

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 1:2-4 and Matthew 11:10-14 identify John the Baptist as the messenger and as Elijah. Luke 1:17 says John would go before him "in the spirit and power of Elijah." Luke 1:78-79: "The sunrise shall visit us from on high." John 2:13-22: Jesus comes to the temple. Hebrews 13:8: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever." Revelation 20:12 mentions the books that are opened. Matthew 3:1-3 introduces John the Baptist.

STEP 6

Application

Read Mark 1:1-8 immediately after this passage. Notice where the Old Testament ends and the Gospel begins.

Give to God first, and trust him to provide.

Pray for the "turning of hearts" between fathers and children in your family.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he does not change and so you are not consumed.

Ask him to refine you and return you to him.

Ask him to prepare you for the coming of the Lord.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 564 · WEEK 81

Review and Reflection

Unit 14 review, The Return & the Chronicles Perspective

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey."
>
> ZECHARIAH 9:9

REST

Meditation

This verse stands near the end of the Old Testament like a lamp in a dark room. After centuries of kings who failed, a king is promised who will not. Every phrase counts.

"Behold." The word calls us to stop and look. Something is about to be shown.

"Your king is coming to you." The king is not a distant ruler. He comes to his people. After the return, the Jews had no king of their own. They were governed by Persians. The promise is that their king would come in person. The one who comes belongs to them and comes toward them.

"Righteous." Every earthly king in the Old Testament had flaws. Even David failed. This king is righteous, fully and perfectly. He does what is right.

"And having salvation is he." The phrase can mean he is saved, or he brings salvation. Both are true. He is delivered by God and he delivers others. His mission is to save.

"Humble." The Hebrew word means afflicted or lowly. This king comes not with power but in weakness. He enters Jerusalem not in the pride of a conqueror but in the humility of a servant.

"Mounted on a donkey." The picture is of peace. The next verse says he will cut off the war horse and speak peace to the nations. The kingdom he brings does not come by the sword.

When Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey, the crowds shouted, “Hosanna!” They were seeing this verse come true. He was the king who came to them, righteous, saving, and humble, and he would give his life.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

Unit 14 closed the Old Testament with a partial return. You saw God keep his word through Cyrus, bringing a remnant home to rebuild the altar, the temple, and the wall. In Ezra and Nehemiah, you read of prayer and obstruction, of the word of God read aloud, and of joy and tears mingled, followed by the sad return to old sins. In Esther, you saw God’s hidden hand preserve his people in a foreign land. In Chronicles, the whole story was retold for the returned community, from Adam to Cyrus, with David’s covenant at its center and the repeated call to seek the LORD. Then the prophets of the return spoke. Joel called for hearts to be torn and promised the Spirit. Obadiah warned against pride and standing aloof. Haggai stirred the builders. Zechariah showed a clean Joshua, a humble king on a donkey, a pierced one, an opened fountain, and a Lord who will be king over all the earth. Malachi ended with love, a sharp rebuke, and a promise: a messenger, a Lord who will come suddenly to his temple, a sun of righteousness, and Elijah before the day. The Old Testament closes with its promises unfulfilled. The people are home, but the glory is not yet fully back, and the king has not come. Four hundred years of silence will follow, but the promise stands. Everything you have read from Genesis to Malachi has been preparing for the Gospel.

REFLECT

Review Questions

Why does the post-exilic community’s joy at the Temple’s rebuilding turn to weeping?

Think about Ezra 3:10-13 and Haggai 2:3. What did the old men remember, and what does the contrast say about the return being partial?

What does Chronicles add to our understanding of the monarchy?

Consider the Chronicler’s focus on David, the temple, and the repeated call to “seek the LORD.” How does it differ from Kings, and what does it say to a people with no king?

How does Malachi set up the 400 years of silence before Christ?

Look at Malachi 3:1, 4:2, and 4:5-6. What promises are left hanging, and who do the Gospels say fulfills them?

What do the visions in Zechariah reveal about the coming Messiah?

Think of the Branch, the priest on his throne, the humble king on a donkey, the shepherd sold for thirty pieces of silver, and the pierced one. How do these pictures fit together?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying his people through exile and return.

Thank him for the promises that point to Christ.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.